

Malayalam, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Malayalam one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Malayalam letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read **നമസ്കാരം** *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Malayalam simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Malayalam is the youngest of the four literary **Dravidian** languages — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is the **closest sister of Tamil**, having split from it only about a thousand years ago. That double nature runs through this book: its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (“thanks” is **നന്ദി** *nandi*, twin of Tamil *nanri*; “no” is **ഇല്ല** *illa*, twin of Tamil *illai*), while a vast Sanskrit layer — the old *Maṇipravāḷam* tradition mixed the two freely — gives it a Sanskrit formal greeting (**നമസ്കാരം**) and the largest alphabet of the family. Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Malayalam out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in

brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: 👁 eyes (6) ⇌ **Hands-free start:** first 5 of 6 lessons.

The Malayalam greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Malayalam script and how Malayalam sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once.

1.1 നമസ്കാരം (*namaskāram*) — “greetings,” a making of a bow

The letters in this word

Malayalam reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ന na, മ ma, ര ra. A **vowel sign** changes it: ക ka + long-ā → കാ kā. The *chandrakkala* strips a vowel so consonants **join as a conjunct**: സ + ക → സ്ക “ska.” The **anusvāram** ണ adds a final nasal “-m.” Read ന·മ·സ്കാ·ര·ം → *namaskāram*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നമസ്കാരം (*namaskāram*) is **Sanskrit**: *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“a making,” root *kr*, “to do”), with a Malayalam ending = “the making of a bow.” The same word as Hindi *namaskār*. Worth marking, because Malayalam is otherwise the **closest sister of Tamil** — the two split only about a thousand years ago — yet it absorbed an enormous Sanskrit layer (the old *Maṇipravāḷam* style mixed the two freely), so its

formal greeting is Sanskrit even as its everyday core stays deeply Tamil-like.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Hello”	Source
Malayalam	നമസ്കാരം <i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Even Tamil’s closest sister took the Sanskrit greeting; Tamil alone kept its own.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. Both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone.

1.2 നന്ദി (*nandi*) — “thank you,” and the Tamil kinship made visible

The letters in this word

ന is *na*; ണ് is “ndi” — a **conjunct** of ന (na) + ണ (da) into “nd,” with the “i” sign. Read നന്ദി → *nandi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നന്ദി (*nandi*) is **native Dravidian**, from the same root *nal* / *nan* (“good”) as Tamil *nan̄ri*. Malayalam and Tamil split from one language about a thousand years ago, so their oldest words are near-twins — “thanks” is a perfect case: Malayalam *nandi*, Tamil *nan̄ri*. Meanwhile Kannada and Telugu use the Sanskrit *dhanyavāda*, so the map of “thanks” traces the family’s fault-line exactly.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Malayalam	നന്ദി <i>nandi</i>	native (root <i>nal</i>)
Tamil	<i>nanri</i>	the <i>same</i> native root
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād / shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Tamil and Malayalam on the native side; Kannada and Telugu on the Sanskrit side.

1.3 അതെ (*athe*) — “yes,” literally “that [is so]”

The letters in this word

അ is the **independent vowel** “a” (word-initial). തെ is “the” — ത (*tha*, a soft *th*) with the “e” sign, which is written *in front* of its consonant but read after. Read അ·തെ → *athe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

അതെ (*athe*) is native Malayalam, grown from അത് (*athu*), “that.” To say “yes,” Malayalam essentially says “**that [is so]**,” affirming by pointing at the truth of what was said. Its partner is *alla*, “[it is] not that.”

Grammar Lens

Malayalam’s yes/no are demonstratives in disguise: *athe* (“that [is so]”) vs. *alla* (“not that”). Like its sisters, Malayalam also answers by **echoing the verb** (*vannu*, “[I] came,” for “did you come?”). You agree by confirming *that* is how things are.

1.4 ഇല്ല (*illa*) — “no,” shared almost exactly with Tamil

The letters in this word

ഇ is the independent vowel “i” (word-initial). ള്ല is “lla” — a conjunct of ല (la) + ല (la), a held “ll.” Read ഇല്ല → *illa*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇല്ല (*illa*) is built on the ancient Dravidian root *il*, “not-being” — so, exactly like Tamil *illai*, it means “[it] is not, [there] is not,” serving as the everyday “no.” Its positive twin is ഉണ്ട് (*untũ*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Dravidian negates by *being*. Where English inserts *not*, Malayalam — like Tamil and Kannada — swaps in the negative verb of existence: *pustakam untũ* (“there is a book”) → *pustakam illa* (“there is not a book”). Strongest across the Tamil–Malayalam pair: Tamil *illai*, Malayalam *illa*, Kannada *illa* (Telugu was the outlier, with *lēdu*).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Malayalam	ഇല്ല <i>illa</i>	native, root <i>il-</i>
Tamil	<i>illai</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Kannada	<i>illa</i>	the <i>same</i> root
Telugu	<i>lēdu</i>	native, a <i>different</i> root
Hindi	<i>nahīm</i>	Indo-European (unrelated)

1.5 ശരി (*śari*) — “okay,” the whole-family word once more

The letters in this word

ശ is “śa” (a *sh*-sound). Having borrowed so much Sanskrit, Malayalam keeps the full set of Sanskrit sibilants (*ś*, *ṣ*, *s*) as separate letters — more than Tamil, which uses one. രി is *ri*. Read ശരി → *śari*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ശരി (*śari*) is the pan-Dravidian “correct, right” → “okay, agreed” — the verbal nod of Malayalam. The same family word as Tamil and Kannada *sari* and Telugu *sarē*; Malayalam just spells its opening sound with ശ (*ś*). Doubled, *śari śari* = “fine, fine.”

Grammar Lens

One word, four scripts. *sari* / *sarē* / *śari* is the clearest single proof of how close these four languages are: one word, one meaning, four different scripts. Catching a shared word change its clothes but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the whole family at once — the reason to learn the four side by side.

1.6 Recap, and how Malayalam says goodbye

Read		Meaning	Origin
നമസ്കാരം	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello	Sanskrit
നന്ദി	<i>nandi</i>	thank you	native (= Tamil <i>nan̄ri</i>)
അതെ	<i>athe</i>	yes	native (“that is so”)
ഇല്ല	<i>illa</i>	no / isn’t	native (= Tamil <i>illai</i>)
ശരി	<i>śari</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

How **Tamil-like** the native core is: four of the five everyday words are shared with Tamil — because Malayalam is Tamil’s closest sister — while only the formal greeting reached for Sanskrit.

Why it's said this way

Nearly the Tamil words exactly. Malayalam, too, will not say a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*), “having gone, I [will] come [back]” — set beside Tamil’s *pōy varugirēn* and Kannada’s *hōgi baruttēne*: the same sentence, the same worldview, and in Malayalam and Tamil almost the same *words*.

That completes the four Dravidian first chapters. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *enre pēru...* (“my name...”) — and Malayalam’s *nī / ninnīṇaḷ* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) 👁 eyes (5) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** all 9 lessons.

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്. (*enre pēru Arun āṇũ* — “My name is Arun.”)

നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (*ninre pēru entāṇũ* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled.

2.1 പേര് (*pēru*) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

The letters in this word

പ (*pa*) + േ (the *ē*-sign) → പേ (*pē*); ൾ (bare *r*, with the *chandrakkala*). Read പേര് → *pēru*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പേര് (*pēru*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **pēr* — the *same* word as Tamil *peyar* and Telugu *pēru*, a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (*p*→*h*). Being Tamil’s closest sister, Malayalam naturally keeps the native word, *not* the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*).

2.2 എന്റെ (*enre*) — “my”

The letters in this word

എ (independent *e*) + the conjunct ർന്റെ (*nre*) → *enre*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) is the possessive of ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, the same pronoun stem behind Tamil *nān* / *en*. No Indo-European cousin.

2.3 ആണ് (*āṇ*) — “is,” where Malayalam breaks with its sisters

The letters in this word

ആ (independent long *ā*) + ണ് (bare retroflex *ṇ*) → *āṇ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ആണ് (*āṇ*, “is”) is Malayalam’s **copula** — a real word for “is,” grown from the verb ആക (*āka*, “to be, to become”). Here is the surprise: Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu all use the **zero copula** — no word for “is” at all — yet Malayalam, though it is Tamil’s *closest* sister, went its own way and grammaticalised a “to be” verb. So where Tamil says only *en peyar Arun*, Malayalam adds *āṇ*: *enre pēru Arun āṇ*.

2.4 എന്റെ പേര് ...ആണ് (*enre pēru ...āṇ*) — “my name is...”

എന്റെ (my) + പേര് (name) + name + ആണ് (is) = *enre pēru ...āṇ*.
Enre pēru Arun āṇ. = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

The verb comes last — as in Hindi (*hai*) and unlike Tamil’s verbless sentence. Malayalam is subject–object–*verb*, and the copula *āṇṭ* closes the sentence: “my name Arun *is*.” (In fast speech Malayalis sometimes drop *āṇṭ*, but the full, correct form keeps it.)

2.5 നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (*nī* / *ninṇaḷ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

നീ (*nī*); നിങ്ങൾ (*ninṇaḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — the same native root as Tamil *nī*, Kannada *nīnu*, Telugu *nuvvu*. നിങ്ങൾ (*ninṇaḷ*) is the respectful/plural “you” — *nī* + a plural ending, the exact cousin of Tamil *nīṅgaḷ*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural, once more. *nī* (familiar) vs. *ninṇaḷ* (respectful, literally plural) — the family’s shared politeness-by-plural, and the same idea as French *vous*. For a first meeting, *ninṇaḷ*.

2.6 എന്ത് (*entṭ*) — “what”

The letters in this word

എ (*e*) + the conjunct ന്ത് (*ntṭ*) → *entṭ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്ത് (*entṭ*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā*/**e*- — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *enna* and Telugu *ēmiṭi*, heading Malayalam’s question family: *entṭ* (what), *ār*

(who), *evite* (where), *entīnanū* (why).

2.7 നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (*ninre pēru entānū*) — “what’s your name?”

നിന്റെ (*ninre*, “your”) is the possessive of *nī* (“you”). And watch the last word: *entānū* is *entū* (what) + *ānū* (is), fused — so നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? is literally “**your name what is?**” Unlike the Tamil question (which had *no* verb), Malayalam’s carries its copula *ānū* right inside the question-word.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *Enre pēru Arun ānū*. The respectful “your” is *ninnāḷe*: *ninnāḷe pēru entānū?*

2.8 സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is നിങ്ങളെ കണ്ടതിൽ സന്തോഷം (*ninnāḷe kaṇḍatil santōṣam*) — “**joy at having seen you.**” The word സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*, “joy”) is **Sanskrit** — the same loan Kannada and Telugu use. So even Malayalam, the great keeper of native words (recall *nandi* for “thanks”), reaches for Sanskrit here: the loan words spread *selectively*, word by word, which is exactly what these lessons trace.

2.9 The whole exchange

Malayalam		English
എന്റെ പേര് മീരാ ആണ്.	<i>enre pēru Mira ānū</i>	My name is Mira.
നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്?	<i>ninre pēru entānū</i>	What’s your name?
എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്.	<i>enre pēru Arun ānū</i>	My name is Arun.
സന്തോഷം.	<i>santōṣam</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *pēru* (Dravidian *pēr, *not name*), *enre* (from *ñān*, “I”), *entŭ* (Dravidian question-stem), *santōṣam* (Sanskrit). And the Malayalam standout: it *has* a copula *āṇŭ* (“is”), where its Dravidian sisters use none. Next chapter: *sukhamāṇō?* (“are you well?”) — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and Malayalam, unlike its sisters, asks it with a real verb “to be”:

സുഖമാണോ? (*sukhamāṇō* — “Are you well? / How are you?”)
സുഖമാണ്, നന്ദി. (*sukhamāṇŭ, nandi* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

3.1 എങ്ങനെ (*eṇṇane*) — “how,” another of the e- questions

The letters in this word

എ (*e*) + ണ് (*ṇṇa*, a doubled velar nasal) + നെ (*ne*) → എങ്ങനെ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എങ്ങനെ (*eṇṇane*, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base *e-* from *entŭ*. Malayalam gathers its questions here: *entŭ* (what), *eṇṇane* (how), *ārŭ* (who), *evite* (where), *eppō!* (when). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s *eppaṭi* — the most native layer of a language otherwise rich in Sanskrit.

3.2 സുഖമാണോ? — “are you well?”

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being”) + ആണ് (*āṇŭ*, “is,” from Chapter 2) + the question-marker ഓ (*ō*) → സുഖമാണോ — “is [it] well?” Where English says “how are you?”, Malayalam more often asks “are you well?”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — *sukha* = *su-* (“good, well,” the Greek *eu-*) + *kha*. Onto it Malayalam adds its **native** copula *āṇṁ* and the question particle *-ō*: a Sanskrit noun, a Dravidian verb — Malayalam in miniature.

Grammar Lens

-ō makes a yes/no question. Add ഒ (̄ō) to the end of a statement: *sukham āṇṁ* (“it is well”) → *sukham āṇō?* (“is it well?”). No word-order change, no helper — just the little *-ō*.

3.3 ഞാൻ (*ñān*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ഞ (*ña*, a palatal nasal like “ny,” at the very start) + ാ (long *ā*) + ന് (*n*, a *chillu*) → ഞാൻ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **ñān* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) from Chapter 2.

Grammar Lens

Malayalam does not drop “I.” Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu verbs carry the person in their ending, so they freely drop the pronoun. But Malayalam verbs *do not change for person at all* (Chapter 5) — so *ñān* must be said; the verb won’t tell you who acts.

3.4 സുഖം (*sukham*) — “well-being,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort, ease”) is a **Sanskrit** loan, the *su-* of Greek *eu-*. Where Tamil answers “how are you?” with native *nam*, Malayalam — Tamil’s closest sister, but far deeper in Sanskrit — reaches for *sukham*. The reply, with the copula: സുഖമാണ് (*sukhamāṇ*), “[I am] well,” reusing the greeting’s own words without the question *-ō*.

3.5 സാരമില്ല (*sāramilla*) — “it doesn’t matter”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സാരമില്ല means “**there’s no matter to it**” — used for “never mind / no worries / you’re welcome.” A perfect emblem of Malayalam: സാരം (*sāram*, “substance, essence”) is **Sanskrit**, while ഇല്ല (*illa*, “is not”) is the **native** Dravidian negative from Chapter 1. Sanskrit noun, Dravidian verb, one word. That *illa* is shared across **Malayalam, Tamil, and Kannada** (Telugu alone diverges, to *lēdu*).

Grammar Lens

Illa negates existence and stands alone as “no”: *paṇam illa* (“there’s no money”). It is the negative twin of the copula *āṇ* (“is”) — *āṇ* affirms, *illa* denies.

3.6 The whole exchange

Malayalam	English
സുഖമാണോ?	Are you well? / How are you?
സുഖമാണ്, നന്ദി.	I’m well, thank you.
സാരമില്ല.	It doesn’t matter / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *enñane* (the native e- questions), *ñān* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *sukhaṃ* (Sanskrit “well,” the *su-* of Greek *eu-*), and the *āṇũ* / *illa* pair — “is” and “is-not,” the *illa* shared with Tamil and Kannada. Next chapter: the farewells — and Malayalam, like all its family, never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ◉ eyes (4) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

Malayalam, like every Dravidian language, does not say a plain “good-bye.” It promises to return:

പോയി വരാം. (*pōyi varām* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

4.1 പോകുക (*pōkuka*) — “to go,” and വരിക (to come)

The letters in this word

പോ (*pō*) + കുക (*kuka*, the *-uka* infinitive) → പോകുക. Its partner വരിക (*varika*, “to come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോകുക (*pōkuka*, “to go”) and വരിക (*varika*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs. The ending -ക (*-uka*) is how Malayalam names a verb in the dictionary — its “to ...” form (where Tamil uses a bare stem). You need both, because the Malayalam goodbye is “I go, and I come back.”

4.2 പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) — “I’ll go and come back”

പോയി (*pōyi*, “having gone”) + വരാം (*varām*, “I’ll come”) — literally

“**having gone, I’ll come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Malayali never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” The warm reply is പോയി വരു (*pōyi varū*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṇ</i>
Tamil	<i>pōy varugiṛēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)

The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The **-ആം** ending, “**I will / let me.**” *-āṇ* on a verb stem is a soft, volitional future: *varāṇ* (“I’ll come”), *kāṇāṇ* (“let’s see,” next lesson), *ceyyāṇ* (“I’ll do it”).

4.3 നാളെ കാണാം (*nāḷe kāṇāṇ*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

നാളെ (*nāḷe*): നാ (*nā*) + ളെ (*ḷe*, retroflex ള *ḷ*). കാണാം (*kāṇāṇ*) = കാṇ (“see”) + *-āṇ* (“let’s”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നാളെ (*nāḷe*, “tomorrow”) is native, from *nāl* (“day”) — the same root as Tamil’s *nāḷai* and Kannada’s *nāḷe*. കാണുക (*kāṇuka*, “to see”) gives *kāṇāṇ* — so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].”

4.4 വീണ്ടും കാണാം (*vīṇṭum kāṇām*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

വീണ്ടും കാണാം = വീണ്ടും (*vīṇṭum*, “again”) + *kāṇām* (“let’s see”). Both native Dravidian: *vīṇṭum* (“again,” from *vīṇṭu*, “to return”) and *kāṇ* (“to see”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Malayalam — like Kannada — keeps its own native verb.

4.5 The farewells

Malayalam	English
പോയി വരാം.	I’ll go and come back. (goodbye)
പോയി വരു.	Go and come back. (the reply)
നാളെ കാണാം.	See you tomorrow.
വീണ്ടും കാണാം.	We’ll meet again.

Roots banked: *pōkuka/varika* (go/come), *nāḷe* (“tomorrow” ← *nāl* “day,” shared with Tamil & Kannada), *kāṇ* (“to see”), and the *-ām* “I will” ending. Next chapter: the first real verbs — *ñāṇ malayāḷam saṁsārikkunnu* — and Malayalam’s one astonishing simplicity.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) 👁 eyes (4) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and the one astonishingly simple thing about Malayalam grammar:

ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു. (*ñāṇ malayāḷaṁ saṁsārikkunnu* — “I speak Malayalam.”)

5.1 സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

സം (*saṁ*) + സാ (*sā*) + രി (*ri*) + കുക (*kkuka*) → സംസാരിക്കുക.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*, “to speak, converse”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *saṁsāra*, “flowing together”), beside the native *parayuka* (“to say”) — another sign of Malayalam’s deep Sanskrit layer. To say “I speak,” add the present ending -ഉന്നു (*-unnu*) to the stem: *saṁsārikk-* + *-unnu* → സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (*saṁsārikkunnu*).

Grammar Lens

The verb never changes for person. In Tamil, Telugu, and Kannada the verb changes ending for *who* acts. *Malayalam does not.* It is the same for everyone:

ñāñ saṃsārikkunnu (I speak) *nī saṃsārikkunnu* (you speak) *avan saṃsārikkunnu* (he speaks)

One form, all persons — which is exactly why (Chapter 3) Malayalam can never drop the pronoun. Of all its Dravidian sisters, Malayalam went the furthest here.

5.2 ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam”

ഞാൻ (I) + മലയാളം (*malayāḷam*, the object) + സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (speak) — “I Malayalam speak,” the verb last. The name മലയാളം (*malayāḷam*) is native Dravidian: *mala* (“mountain”) + *āḷam* (“place, region”) — “**the mountain land**,” for the Western Ghats along its coast. The signature retroflex *ള* (*l̥*) sits in the middle of the word.

Grammar Lens

Because *saṃsārikkunnu* is the same for every person, the pronoun ഞാൻ (*ñāñ*) cannot be dropped — it is the only thing marking “I.”

5.3 താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*, “to live, reside, stay”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *tāmasa*, “dwelling”); Malayalam often prefers such Sanskrit-built verbs where Tamil uses a native word (*vāḷ*). “I live in Kochi” is ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു (*ñāñ kocchiyil tāmasikkunnu*) — the same *-unnu* present, the same for every person.

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. കൊച്ചിയിൽ (*kocchiyil*) = *Kochi* + *-il* (“in”), on the noun’s *end*. Malayalam uses **postpositions**: “Kochi-in I live,” verb last, pronoun kept.

5.4 ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചെയ്യുക (*ceyyuka*, “to do, make”) is core native Dravidian — the same root as Tamil *sey*. Like Hindi’s *karnā*, Tamil’s *sey*, Telugu’s *cēyu*, and Kannada’s *māḍu*, Malayalam builds compounds with it: ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*, “work-do” = “to work”). So “I work” is ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു (*ñān jōli ceyyunnu*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + ചെയ്യുക = a new verb — the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*, Tamil’s *sey*, Telugu’s *cēyu*, Kannada’s *māḍu*. Five languages, two from an unrelated family, one shared trick.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Malayalam	English
ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു.	I speak Malayalam.
ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു.	I live in Kochi.
ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു.	I work.

Three verbs, one endlessly simple engine: the *-unnu* present, the verb always last, the same for every person — so the pronoun always stays. Roots banked: *saṃsārikkuka* (Sanskrit; native twin *parayuka*), *tāmasikkuka* (Sanskrit; where Tamil uses native *vāḷ*), *ceyyuka* (the same root as Tamil *sey*), and *malayāḷaṇ* = “the mountain land.” From here, Malayalam’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ✍ pen (2) 🖐 Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I know Malayalam the way Malayalam itself builds it – with no subject at all, marking myself with the dative -ikku.

Say enikku malayālam ariyām, set it against ñān malayālam samisārikkunnu, and stack the dative’s four Dravidian cousins.

6.1 -ിക്കു (-ikku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English puts “to” in **front** as its own word. Malayalam sticks it on the **back** — and that is the biggest structural fact about the language.

What to know first

word	+ dative	meaning
പേര് <i>pēru</i> — name	പേരിന് <i>pērinu</i>	to/for the name
ജോലി <i>jōli</i> — work	ജോലിക്കു <i>jōlikku</i>	for work

Malayalam’s dative has two shapes — -ിക്കു *-ikku* and -ിന് *-inu* — chosen by the sound the noun ends in. Same case, same job; the seam is still visible.

And with “I”, which reshapes first:

ഞാൻ *ñān* (“I”) → എനിക്ക് *enikku* (“to me”)

Learn *enikku* cold — it opens a great many everyday Malayalam sentences, as the next lesson shows.

Why it's said this way

	Malayalam -ikku	a Latin ending like -īs
pins down the case?	yes — dative, always	no — <i>-īs</i> is dative or ablative
carries number?	no — a separate suffix does	yes — plural, baked in
carries declension class?	no	yes — 1st/2nd only
can you see the seam?	yes : <i>jōli + kku</i>	no — one fused lump

Malayalam **stacks**: each suffix means one thing and sits in a fixed order — so a long word can be read piece by piece. Latin **fuses**: *-īs* is case *and* plural *and* declension at once, indivisible, and it doesn't even settle *which* case. Malayalam's dative is never ambiguous. That's what “**agglutinative**” means, and why Malayalam words grow long without growing hard: they are **built**, not memorised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pēru ... pērinu*”
- “*ñān ... enikku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*jōlikku*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5's ജോലി
- the principle — “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”

Before you move on

What does **-ിക്കു** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun.) What is “to me”? (**എനിക്കു** *enikku*.) Why does the suffix have two shapes? (**-ikku** and **-inu** are chosen by the noun's ending — one case, two forms.) How is that unlike a Latin ending? (Latin **fuses** case+number+declension — and *-īs* doesn't even fix *which* case; Malayalam's carries **one** meaning,

unambiguously, seam visible.) Next: the sentence where the person isn't the subject.

6.2 എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം — “I know Malayalam”

Chapter 5 gave you ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam.” Now say “I **know** Malayalam.” Malayalam will not let you use *ñān*.

What to know first

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം. *enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ*. literally: “**to-me** Malayalam is-knowable.”

piece

എനിക്ക് <i>enikku</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
മലയാളം <i>malayāḷam</i>	Malayalam (Ch. 5)
അറിയാം <i>ariyāṁ</i>	“can be known” — <i>ariy-</i> “know” + -ām , the <i>able-to</i> ending

You are not the subject. *Ñān* is gone; the person has been moved into the dative, and the sentence is now about the **language**. Malayalam isn't saying you perform an act of knowing — it's saying the language is knowable **to you**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam separates what you **do** from what **happens to** you. Speaking is an action, so Ch. 5 used *ñān*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry — these **arrive** at you. Malayalam marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Malayalam frames it as
I know Malayalam	Malayalam is known to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me
English preserves one fossil of exactly this: “ methinks ” — <i>me</i> is a	

dative, “it seems **to me**.” Malayalam made it the rule.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	“I know [the language]”	the dative
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayāḷam ariyām</i>	-ikku
Tamil	<i>enakku tamīl teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge

Look at the first column: Malayalam’s *enikku* and Tamil’s *enakku* are nearly the **same word** — the two languages separated most recently of the four, and it shows. One construction, four languages, four visibly related suffixes: the Dravidian family showing its bones, as *blanc/bianco/branco* did for Romance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enikku malayāḷam ariyām*”
- the contrast — “*ñān malayāḷam samisārikkunnu*” (I speak) ... “*enikku malayāḷam ariyām*” (known to me)
- the near-twins — “*enikku* ... *enakku*”
- the four cousins — “*-ikku · -ukku · -ku · -ge*”

Before you move on

What does എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം literally say? (“**To-me** Malayalam **is-knowable**.”) What has English got that Malayalam hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *ñān* is replaced by the dative *enikku*.) Why the dative? (Knowing **happens to** you.) Which Tamil word is *enikku* almost identical to, and why? (**Enakku** — Tamil and Malayalam split most recently of the four.) Which English word keeps the same idea? (**Methinks**.)

6.3 ക — one character, met inside words you already say

Highly rounded and loopy — full circles, hooks and curls, with almost no straight lines.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ക

ക — *ka*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *k*, it is **ka**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ക somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- നാളെ കാണാം *nāḷe kāṇāṁ* — see you tomorrow
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay
- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: ക — copy what you see

Put your pen on ക and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ക in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · നാളെ കാണാം · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ക three times, saying *ka* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ക once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ക? What sound does it carry? (*ka*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

6.4 ര — one character, met inside words you already say

Highly rounded and loopy — full circles, hooks and curls, with almost no straight lines.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ര

ര — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ര somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- ശരി *sari* — okay / alright / correct (śari)
- പേര് *pēr* — name
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn't matter / no problem / you're welcome

Writing: ര — copy what you see

Put your pen on ര and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find റ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · ശരി · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* റ three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find റ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — റ? What sound does it carry? (*ra*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ✍ pen (2) 🖐 Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to ten in Malayalam.

Count āru to pattu, keep the rare_l of ēlu, and take ompatu apart as 'one short of ten'.

7.1 ഒന്ന്, രണ്ട്, മൂന്ന്, നാല്, അഞ്ച് — one to five

Of all the Dravidian cousins, Malayalam is Tamil's closest — they were one language a thousand years ago — and its numbers show it.

What to know first

	numeral	word	said
1	൧	ഒന്ന്	<i>onnu</i>
2	൨	രണ്ട്	<i>raṇṭu</i>
3	൩	മൂന്ന്	<i>mūnnu</i>
4	൪	നാല്	<i>nālu</i>
5	൫	അഞ്ച്	<i>añcu</i>

The symbols ൧ ൨ ൩ ൪ ൫ are Malayalam's own digits.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where Telugu breaks the family with *okaṭi*, Malayalam stays loyal: its **one** is *onnu*, the direct cousin of Tamil *onru* (both from the old *on-*). Laid beside Tamil, the whole row is barely changed:

	Tamil	Malayalam
1	<i>onru</i>	onnu
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	raṇṭu
3	<i>mūnru</i>	mūnnu
4	<i>nānku</i>	nālu

The one that moved most is **five**: Tamil *aintu* softened its *nt* to a palatal, giving Malayalam **añcu** — the same shift English feels between *nature* said stiffly and said naturally.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Every word here ends in **chandrakkala** — the little hook ് on the last letter (ചന്ദ്രക്കല) — which trims the final vowel down to a half-heard *ũ*. It's why these read *onn'*, *nāl'* rather than a full *onnu*, *nālu*. And the doubled letters (*onnu*, *mūnnu*) are real **held** consonants — linger on the *nn*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “onnu, raṇṭu, mūnnu, nālu, añcu”
- the near-identity — “onru ↔ onnu”, “iraṇṭu ↔ raṇṭu”
- the one that shifted — “aintu → añcu”

Before you move on

Count to five in Malayalam. (*Onnu, raṇṭu, mūnnu, nālu, añcu*.) Does Malayalam's **one** follow Tamil or break away like Telugu? (**Follows Tamil** — *onnu* ↔ *onru*.) Which number changed most from Tamil, and how? (**Five** — *aintu*'s *nt* palatalised to *añcu*.) What does the **chandrakkala** ് do to a word's last sound? (Trims its vowel to a half-heard *ũ*.) Next: six to ten.

7.2 ആറ്, ഏഴ്, എട്ട്, ഒമ്പത്, പത്ത് — six to ten

Malayalam holds onto a Tamil sound the other cousins let go — and you’ll hear it in seven.

What to know first

	numeral	word	said
6	൬	ആറ്	<i>āru</i>
7	൭	ഏഴ്	<i>ēlu</i>
8	൮	എട്ട്	<i>eṭṭu</i>
9	൯	ഒമ്പത്	<i>ompatu</i>
10	൧൦	പത്ത്	<i>pattu</i>

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Watch **seven** travel across the three sister scripts:

	word	its 7-letter
Tamil	<i>ēlu</i>	୧ (l)
Malayalam	<i>ēlu</i>	൭ (l) — kept
Kannada	<i>ēlu</i>	ಲ — hardened
Telugu	<i>ēḍu</i>	ఢ — hardened further

Malayalam, alone with Tamil, **keeps the l** — the rare retroflex sound that sits in the name *Tam̐l* itself. (The name *Malayālam*, by contrast, carries the **hardened** cousin **ḷ** — **ള** — the very sound Kannada’s *ēlu* shows; the two letters **൭ l** and **ള ḷ** are worth keeping apart.) Six (*āru*), eight (*eṭṭu*) and ten (*pattu*) are likewise almost letter-for-letter Tamil: this is the closest of all the cousin-columns.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Nine comes, exactly as in Tamil, from the old *on* (“one”) + *patu* (“ten”) — one short of ten. But before the *p*, the *n* shifts to an **m**: so the underlying *onpatu* is both **written** ഒമ്പത് and **said** *ompatu* (say “onpatu” fast and you’ll do it yourself). Kannada does the same in *ombattu*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āru, ēlu, eṭṭu, onpatu, pattu”
- seven’s kept sound — “ēlu”, the l of *Taml* (not the ḷ of *Malayāḷam*)
- nine taken apart — “onṇ + patu → ompatu”, one short of ten

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Malayalam. (*Āru, ēlu, eṭṭu, ompatu, pattu.*) Which sister languages keep Tamil’s rare l in *seven*, and which hardened it? (**Malayalam keeps it**; Kannada → *ḷ*, Telugu → *ḍ*.) How is *ompatu* built, and why the **m**? (*on* “one” + *patu* “ten”; the *n* becomes *m* before *p*.) Which of these numbers is furthest from Tamil? (None much — this is the closest cousin-set.)

7.3 ് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഃ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ്

ഃ — *no sound of its own — it takes one away.*

It is a **vowel-killer**. Every consonant in this script arrives with an *a* already inside it — that is what an abugida is. This mark takes the *a* back, leaving the bare consonant. It is how the script writes two consonants in a row.

You already say these, and every one of them has ് somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- ഇല്ല *illa* — no / there isn’t (illa — the negative)
- പേര് *pēr* — name

Writing: ࣳ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ࣳ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ࣳ in the ones that have it
നമസ്കാരം · നന്ദി · ശരി
- *Trace it:* ࣳ three times, and each time say what it does: **it kills the built-in a**
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ࣳ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ࣳ? What does it do to the consonant it sits on? (**Takes away the built-in a.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.4 ࣳ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ࣳ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ࣳ

ࣳ — *va*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *v*, it is **va**.

You already say these, and every one of them has **വ** somewhere inside it:

- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāmi* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- വീണ്ടും കാണാം — we’ll meet again

Writing: **വ** — copy what you see

Put your pen on **വ** and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find **വ** in the ones that have it
- നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* **വ** three times, saying *va* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **വ** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **വ**? What sound does it carry? (*va.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 8

Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say please in Malayalam, and soften a request with the everyday verb ending instead.

Say dayavāyi, split it into daya 'compassion' plus -vāyi, then use the plainer -u verb ending as the everyday alternative.

8.1 ദയവായി (dayavāyi) — please (as a compassion)

Malayalam’s “please” turns compassion into an adverb: do this thing **as a kindness**.

What to know first

ദയവായി = please, literally “**kindly / as a compassion.**” Two pieces:

- ദയ (daya) = **compassion, kindness, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya**.
- -വായി (-vāyi) = “**having become / as,**” turning the noun into “*in the manner of* compassion” — i.e. **kindly**. (The true historical seam is *dayavu* “kindness” + -ആയി -āyi, the adverb of ആകുക ākuka “to become”; we split it -vāyi here just to keep the *daya* root visible.)

So *dayavāyi* asks you to act *kindly, as a kindness*. Where Tamil and Telugu say “**do** the kindness” and Kannada “having **placed** it,” Malayalam makes kindness the **manner** of the whole request.

The family resemblance is unmistakable, and it reaches beyond Dravidian: **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”) ask by the same grace-naming instinct.

Why it’s said this way

daya + a light verb, four ways:

- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**
- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**

Why it’s said this way

Honestly: as elsewhere in the family, the standalone word is a touch **formal / emphatic**. Everyday Malayalam politeness leans on the **respectful request** form of the verb — endings like -**ു** (-*ū*) or -**ണം** (-*aṇam*): ഇരിക്കൂ (*irikkū*) “please sit,” പറയൂ (*parayū*) “please tell me.” Add ദയവായി in front when you want the courtesy spoken aloud.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The heart of the word is **വാ** — *va* stretched by the **long-ā** sign **ാ** (-*ā*) — then **യി**, *ya* + the *i* sign (**ി**). Malayalam’s rounded letters hang their vowel-signs to the right; the long **ാ** is simply a tall stroke after the consonant, the same *ā* you would meet across the Dravidian scripts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**daya**” — compassion — then “-*vāyi*,” as / kindly
- the whole word — “*dayavāyi*” = please
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “*irikkū*” = please sit

Before you move on

What is the Malayalam word for please? (ദയവായി *dayavāyi*.)
 What do its pieces mean? (“**Compassion**” *daya* + “**as / having become**” *-vāyi* — *kindly*.) Which cousins ask the same way?
 (Tamil, Kannada, Telugu with *daya* — plus Arabic *faḍl*, Hindi *kṛpā*.) What carries “please” in ordinary speech? (The respectful verb form, endings like -ഓ -ū / -ണം -aṇani.)

8.2 ി — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ള — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ി

ി — *i*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *i*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ി somewhere inside it:

- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- ശരി *sari* — okay / alright / correct (śari)
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāṁ* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Writing: ി — copy what you see

Put your pen on ി and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ി in the ones that have it
നന്ദി · ശരി · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ി three times, saying *i* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ി once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ി? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *i* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

8.3 ച — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ള — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ച

ച — *ca*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *c*, it is **ca**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ച somewhere inside it:

- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (lit. “work-do”)
- ഒന്ന് രണ്ട് മൂന്ന് നാല് അഞ്ച് — one to five

Writing: ച — copy what you see

Put your pen on ച and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ച in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ച three times, saying *ca* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ച once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ച? What sound does it carry? (*ca*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 9

Sorry

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Malayalam with *kṣamikkaṇaṁ*, and use the plainer *kṣamikkū* when it suits.

*Say *kṣamikkaṇaṁ*, hear the necessitative -aṇaṁ softening it into politeness, then drop to the plain *kṣamikkū*.*

9.1 ക്ഷമിക്കണം (*kṣamikkaṇaṁ*) — (you) should forgive / sorry

You already know ദയവായി and the necessitative -ണം ending mentioned there. Malayalam’s “sorry” is that very ending, now carrying a forgiveness-verb.

What to know first

- ക്ഷമ (*kṣama*) = “**forgiveness, patience**” — the Sanskrit noun.
- -ഇക്കുക (*-ikkuka*) = a **verb-making suffix**: *kṣama* + *-ikkuka* → ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamikkuka*), “**to forgive**.”
- -ണം (-*aṇaṁ*) = the **necessitative** ending, “**must / should**” — literally *kṣamikkaṇaṁ* says “[you] **must forgive**,” used as a softened, polite request exactly the way English can soften a request into “you should really forgive me” without meaning it as an order.

So ക്ഷമിക്കണം leans on obligation to be polite — a very different move from a plain imperative.

Why it's said this way

- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkanaṁ* — Sanskrit *kṣama* + **-ikkuka** (verb) + **-aṇaṁ** (necessitative: “must/should”)
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-isu** (verb) + **-i** (imperative)
- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamin̄caṇḍi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-iṅcu** (verb) + **-aṇḍi** (imperative)
- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — its **own** native root *manni*, not Sanskrit at all

Why it's said this way

ക്ഷമിക്കണം is a genuine, common way to ask forgiveness — but Malayalam speakers reach just as often for the plain imperative ക്ഷമിക്കൂ (*kṣamikkū*, using the -ൂ ending from the please lesson) or simply the borrowed English “sorry.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṣama” — the Sanskrit noun, forgiveness
- the verb — “kṣamikkuka,” to forgive — then “kṣamikkanaṁ,” you should forgive
- the plainer version — “kṣamikkū,” using the -ū ending you know

Before you move on

What does ക്ഷമിക്കണം literally say, and why is that polite? (“[You] **must forgive**” — the necessitative **-aṇaṁ** softens an obligation into a request, same as ദയവായി’s note on -aṇaṁ.) Which cousins also verb-ify *kṣama*? (**Kannada and Telugu**; **Tamil** uses its own root *manni*.) What’s a plainer alternative? (**Kṣamikkū**, using the -ū ending, or borrowed English “sorry.”)

9.2 ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ി — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഓ

ഓ — *ā*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *ā*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഓ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāṁ* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- നാളെ കാണാം *nāḷe kāṇāṁ* — see you tomorrow

Writing: ഓ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഓ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ാ in the ones that have it
നമസ്കാരം · സാരമില്ല · നന്ദി
- *Trace it:* ാ three times, saying *ā* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ാ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ാ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ā* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

9.3 പ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: പ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: പ

പ — *pa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *p*, it is **pa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has പ somewhere inside it:

- പേര് *pēr* — name
- എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ് — my name is...
- നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? — what's your name?
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Writing: പ — copy what you see

Put your pen on പ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find പ in the ones that have it

പേര് · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* പ three times, saying *pa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find പ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — പ? What sound does it carry? (*pa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (2) 🗣 Hands-free start: none of the 3 lessons.

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the seven days of the Malayalam week and say which planet each one is named for.*

Name the seven planet-days, separate the native ones from the Sanskrit ones, and explain their near-identity with Tamil's.

10.1 തിങ്കൾ to ഞായർ — the week Malayalam shares with Tamil

Malayalam and Tamil are close cousins — they were once, long ago, the same language — and nowhere does that show more clearly than in the words for the days of the week.

What to know first

Malayalam	planet-word	meaning	compare Tamil
തിങ്കളാഴ്ച	<i>thinkaḷ</i>	“Moon”	<i>thingaḷ</i> — nearly identical
ചൊവ്വാഴ്ച	<i>covva</i>	traditionally “the red one”	<i>cevvāy</i> — the same word, worn differently
ബുധനാഴ്ച	<i>budhan</i>	Mercury	Sanskrit Budha , same as Tamil <i>pudhan</i>
വ്യാഴാഴ്ച	<i>vyāzham</i>	Jupiter	matches Tamil’s <i>viyāzhan</i> closely
വെള്ളിയാഴ്ച	<i>velli</i>	traditionally “silver”	<i>velli</i> — the same word
ശനിയാഴ്ച	<i>śani</i>	Saturn	Sanskrit Śani , same as Tamil <i>sani</i>
ഞായറാഴ്ച	<i>ñāyar</i>	“Sun”	<i>ñāyīru</i> — the same root

Why it’s said this way

This is the closest family match anywhere in Dravidian: **thinkaḷ**/**thingaḷ**, **velli**/**velli**, and **ñāyar**/**ñāyīru** are essentially **the same words**, because Malayalam only became a distinct language from Tamil within roughly the last thousand years or so. Where Tamil says കിഴമൈ (*kizhamai*) for “day,” Malayalam says ആഴ്ച (*āzhcha*) — a different word for the same idea (the two aren’t confirmed cognates; treat this as two languages solving the same naming problem separately, not necessarily one shared root). Like Tamil, Malayalam mixes **native** planet-words (Moon, Mars, Venus, Sun) with **Sanskrit** ones (Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn) — the same split, inherited from the same shared ancestor language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thinkal” — moon — then “āzhcha,” day/week
- the shared words — “velli” (Venus), same in both Malayalam and Tamil
- the Sanskrit ones — “budhan, vyāzham, śani” — Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn

Before you move on

Why do Malayalam and Tamil’s day-names look so alike? (**They were the same language until roughly a thousand years ago.**) Which planet-names does Malayalam share almost word-for-word with Tamil? (**thinkal/Moon, velli/Venus, ñāyar/Sun** — and *covva*/Mars, a worn variant of *cevvāy*.) Which three come from Sanskrit in both languages? (**Mercury (Budha), Jupiter (vyāzham/viyāzhan), Saturn (Śani).**)

10.2 ന — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഐ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ന

ന — *na*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *n*, it is **na**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ന somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- എന്റെ *enre* — my
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you

Writing: ന — copy what you see

Put your pen on ന and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ന in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · നന്ദി · ഇല്ല

- *Trace it:* ന three times, saying *na* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ന once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ന? What sound does it carry? (*na*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

10.3 ണ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ണ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ണ

ണ — *na*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *n*, it is **ṇa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ണ somewhere inside it:

- ആണ് — is (the copula)
- എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ് — my name is...
- നാളെ കാണാം *nāḷe kāṇāmi* — see you tomorrow
- ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇaṁ* — (you) should forgive / sorry

Writing: ണ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ണ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ണ in the ones that have it
ആണ് · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ണ three times, saying *ṇa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ണ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ണ? What sound does it carry? (*ṇa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Malayalam.

Say karuppŭ, vellā, cuvappŭ and nīla, and mark which three are native Dravidian and which one is a shared Sanskrit loan.

11.1 കറുപ്പ്, വെള്ള, ചുവപ്പ്, നീല — the same split as Tamil

You’ve seen Malayalam and Tamil share day-names almost word-for-word. Their colors follow the exact same family pattern.

What to know first

- കറുപ്പ് (*karuppŭ*) = “**black**” — matches Tamil *karuppu* almost exactly.
- വെള്ള (*vellā*) = “**white**” — the same **vel-** “bright/silvery” root as Tamil *vellai*.
- ചുവപ്പ് (*cuvappŭ*) = “**red**” — a related word from the same Dravidian root family as Tamil *sivappu*, though the two differ in both their opening consonant’s sound and their vowel — a looser cousin than *karuppŭ*/*karuppu* or *vellā*/*vellai*, which match almost exactly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീല (nīla) = “blue” — the same **Sanskrit** loan Tamil uses (*nīlam*), and the same one Hindi uses (*nīlā*). Blue is where Malayalam, Tamil, and Hindi all converge on one shared Sanskrit word, even though Malayalam and Tamil otherwise built their own native words for black, white, and red.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “karuppū, vellā, cuvappū” — black, white, red
- “nīla” — blue, shared with Tamil and Hindi
- the family match — “karuppū/karuppu, vellā/vellai, cuvappū/sivappu”

Before you move on

Which three Malayalam colors closely match Tamil’s own words? (**Karuppū, vellā, cuvappū** — black, white, red.) Which color is a shared Sanskrit loan across Malayalam, Tamil, and Hindi? (**Blue** — നീല *nīla* / நீலம் *nīlam* / नीला *nīlā*.)

11.2 ശ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ണ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ശ

ശ — ll.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *ll* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You already say these, and every one of them has ശ somewhere inside it:

- നീ / നിങ്ങൾ — you (familiar / respectful)
- തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ — the seven weekdays

Writing: ശ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ശ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ശ in the ones that have it

നീ / നിങ്ങൾ · തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി
ഞായർ · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ശ three times, saying *ll* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ശ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ശ? What sound does it carry? (*ll*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

11.3 മ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഞ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: മ

മ — *ma*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *m*, it is **ma**.

You already say these, and every one of them has മ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay
- എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം *enikku malayāḷam ariyām* — ‘I know Malayalam’

Writing: മ — copy what you see

Put your pen on മ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find മ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സാരമില്ല · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* മ three times, saying *ma* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find മ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **ǝ**? What sound does it carry? (***ma***.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 12

Family

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my father, mother, and my older and younger brothers and sisters in Malayalam.

Say the six family words in age-graded pairs, and note that Malayalam built its own sibling set rather than tracking Tamil's.

12.1 അച്ഛൻ, അമ്മ, and four sibling words — Malayalam's own set

Malayalam and Tamil share a great deal of their vocabulary — but family words are where Malayalam goes its own way further than you might expect, while still keeping the family's signature age-first sibling system.

What to know first

- അച്ഛൻ (*acchan*) = “**father**” — a different form from Tamil's *appā*; **this word's own deeper origin is less settled** than the simple *appā/amma* pattern, and worth a linguist's extra look.
- അമ്മ (*amma*) = “**mother**” — matches the family's shared *amma* pattern closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam	meaning
ചേട്ടൻ (<i>cēṭṭan</i>)	older brother
അനിയൻ (<i>aniyan</i>)	younger brother
ചേച്ചി (<i>cēcci</i>)	older sister
അനിയത്തി (<i>aniyatti</i>)	younger sister

Notice these don't closely match Tamil/Kannada/Telugu's *aṇṇan/anna*, *tambi/tammudu*, *akkā/akka*, or *tangai/celli* — Malayalam built its own set of sibling words. But the **structure** is identical: **four** words, not two, split by whether the sibling is **older or younger than you** — the same signature pattern you've now seen across all four Dravidian languages, even where the specific words diverge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “acchan, amma” — father, mother
- “cēṭṭan, aniyān” — older/younger brother
- “cēcci, aniyatti” — older/younger sister

Before you move on

Do Malayalam's sibling words closely match Tamil's? (**No** — Malayalam built its own distinct set (cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, and aniyatti), unlike how closely Kannada and Telugu track Tamil.) Does Malayalam still split siblings by age? (**Yes** — four words, older vs. younger, the same structural pattern across the whole Dravidian family.)

12.2 ൾ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ൾ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ു

ു — *u*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *u*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ു somewhere inside it:

- സുഖമാണോ? — how are you? (lit. “are you well?”)
- സുഖം *sukhami* — well-being — and the reply ”സുഖമാണ്
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay
- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: ു — copy what you see

Put your pen on ു and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ു in the ones that have it
സുഖമാണോ? · സുഖം · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ു three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ു once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ു? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *u* on;**

takes the built-in *a* off.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

12.3 ഞ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: **മ** — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഞ

ഞ — *ña*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ñ*, it is **ña**.

You already say these, and every one of them has **ഞ** somewhere inside it:

- ഞാൻ — I
- ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — I speak Malayalam
- ഒന്ന് രണ്ട് മൂന്ന് നാല് അഞ്ച് — one to five
- തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ — the seven weekdays

Writing: ഞ — copy what you see

Put your pen on **ഞ** and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഞ in the ones that have it

ഞാൻ · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ഞ three times, saying *ñā* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഞ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഞ? What sound does it carry? (*ñā.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Malayalam.

Say thala and kai, and match them against Tamil's talai and kai.

13.1 തല, കൈ — head and hand, matching Tamil closely

Malayalam's family words (*achan*, *cēṭṭan*...) went their own way from Tamil's. Body parts snap right back to the close match you saw in colors and days.

What to know first

- തല (*thala*) = “**head**” — matches Tamil *talai* closely.
- കൈ (*kai*) = “**hand**” — matches Tamil *kai* almost exactly.

Both native Dravidian, both close cousins of Tamil's own words — a reminder that Malayalam and Tamil's vocabulary agreement varies concept by concept, not uniformly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thala” — head
- “kai” — hand
- the match — nearly identical to Tamil’s talai/kai

Before you move on

What are Malayalam’s words for head and hand, and how closely do they match Tamil? (തല **thala**, കൈ **kai** — very closely, both native Dravidian.)

13.2 ത — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ു — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ത

ത — *ta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ta**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ത somewhere inside it:

- അതെ — yes (athe — “that [is so]”)
- എന്ത് — what
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay

Writing: ത — copy what you see

Put your pen on ത and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ത in the ones that have it
അതെ · എന്ത് · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ത three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ത once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ത? What sound does it carry? (*ta.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

13.3 S — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഞ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: S

S — *ta.*

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ṭa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has S somewhere inside it:

- വീണ്ടും കാണാം — we'll meet again
- ഒന്ന് രണ്ട് മൂന്ന് നാല് അഞ്ച് — one to five
- ആറ് ഏഴ് എട്ട് ഒമ്പത് പത്ത് — six to ten

- അച്ഛൻ അമ്മ ചേട്ടൻ അനിയൻ ചേച്ചി അനിയത്തി — father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words

Writing: S — copy what you see

Put your pen on **S** and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find **S** in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* **S** three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **S** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **S**? What sound does it carry? (*ta*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 14

Seasons

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name Malayalam’s four seasons, including the monsoon that sits at the centre of the year.

Say vēnalkkālam, mazhakkālam and śaithyakālam as native compounds, then vasanthakālam as the shared Sanskrit loan.

14.1 വസന്തകാലം, വേനൽ, മഴ, ശൈത്യം — the same pattern as Tamil

Malayalam’s season words follow the very same recipe as Tamil’s — native words for what a season *feels like*, plus one shared Sanskrit loan for spring.

What to know first

Malayalam	meaning	source
വസന്തകാലം (<i>vasanthakaalam</i>)	“spring”	<i>vasantham</i> — the same Sanskrit loan as Tamil
വേനൽക്കാലം (<i>venalkkaalam</i>)	“summer”	വേനൽ <i>venal</i> , native Dravidian, matching Tamil <i>kodai</i> ’s role
മഴക്കാലം (<i>mazhakkaalam</i>)	“rainy season”	മഴ <i>mazha</i> , native Dravidian, matching Tamil <i>mazhai</i> closely
ശൈത്യകാലം (<i>śaithyakaalam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	<i>śaithya</i> — this one leans more Sanskrit-flavored than Tamil’s native <i>kulir</i>

Every one shares the ending **-കാലം** (*-kaalam*, “time/season”) — itself ultimately from Sanskrit **काल** (*kāla*), but assimilated so long ago that it functions as ordinary vocabulary, quite unlike a fresher loan like *vasantham*.

Why it’s said this way

As with Tamil, Kerala’s actual climate is shaped far more by **മഴക്കാലം** (*mazhakkaalam*, “the rains” — including Kerala’s famous southwest monsoon) than by a clean four-way Western split. The rains aren’t a footnote to “summer” or “autumn” — they’re their own major season, central to daily and agricultural life.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venal” — summer heat — then “kaalam,” season
- “mazhakkaalam” — the rains, the real central season
- “śaithyakaalam” — the cold season
- the shared loanword — “vasanthakaalam,” spring, same as Tamil

Before you move on

Which Malayalam season-words match Tamil's closely, and which is shared with Tamil as a Sanskrit loan? (**Venal/mazha** match Tamil's *kodai/mazhai*; **vasanthakaalam** is the same Sanskrit loan as Tamil's *vasantha kaalam*.) What's the real central season in Kerala's climate? (**Mazhakaalam**, the rains/monsoon.)

14.2 ഴ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: **ട** — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഴ

ഴ — *lla*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ll*, it is **lla**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഴ somewhere inside it:

- ആറ് ഏഴ് എട്ട് ഒമ്പത് പത്ത് — six to ten
- തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ — the seven weekdays
- വസന്തകാലം വേനൽക്കാലം മഴക്കാലം ശൈത്യകാലം — spring, summer, monsoon, winter

Writing: ഴ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഴ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find **൧** in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* **൧** three times, saying *lla* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **൧** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **൧**? What sound does it carry? (*lla*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water and rice in Malayalam, keeping raw ari apart from cooked cōru.

Say vellam and explain why it does not match Tamil's n̄r, then split ari from cōru.

15.1 വെള്ളം, അരി, ചോറ് — a different water-word, the same rice-words

For once, Malayalam's everyday word for something basic genuinely **doesn't** match Tamil's — even though water is about as basic as vocabulary gets.

What to know first

വെള്ളം (*vellam*) = “**water**” — and notably, this is **not** built on *n̄r* the way Tamil's *taṇṇ̄r* is. Instead, *vellam* shares the വെൾ (*vel-*, “**bright, white**”) root you already met in *velli*, “silver/ Venus,” from the colors and days lessons — *vellam* originally meant something closer to “**flood, deluge**” before becoming Malayalam's plain, everyday word for water. (*N̄r* itself hasn't vanished from Malayalam — it survives inside compounds like ഇളനീർ *iḷan̄r*, “tender coconut water,” and കണ്ണീർ *kaṇṇ̄r*, “tears” — it's just not the standalone everyday word anymore.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Rice, though, tells the familiar story:

- അരി (*ari*) = “**rice**” (raw grain) — closely matching Tamil *arisi*.
- ചോറ് (*cōru*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal) — and here Malayalam actually **does** have a Tamil cognate: Tamil keeps its own native சோறு (also *cōru*), used alongside the Sanskrit-influenced *sātam* as an everyday near-synonym. Malayalam simply made *cōru* its main word, where Tamil more often reaches for *sātam*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vellaṁ” — water, NOT matching Tamil’s *neer*
- “ari” — raw rice, matching Tamil closely
- “cōru” — cooked rice, Malayalam’s own word

Before you move on

Does Malayalam’s everyday water-word match Tamil’s? (**No** — *vellaṁ* shares the *vel-* “bright/white” root instead, originally meaning “flood”; though *nīr* itself survives in compounds like *iḷanīr* and *kaṇṇīr*.) Does its raw-rice word match Tamil’s? (**Yes** — *ari* closely matches *arisi*.)

15.2 ്ര — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ്ര — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ൫

൫ — *ō*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *ō*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ൫ somewhere inside it:

- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- സുഖമാണോ? — how are you? (lit. “are you well?”)
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: ൫ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ൫ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ൫ in the ones that have it
സന്തോഷം · സുഖമാണോ? · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ൫ three times, saying *ō* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ൫ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ൫? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ō* on;**

takes the built-in *a* off.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 16

The Traditional Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months of the Malayalam Kollam-era calendar and say which zodiac sign each one carries.

Recite the twelve months from Chirīṇṇam, tie Chirīṇṇam to Leo, and contrast Malayalam’s zodiac naming with Tamil’s nakshatras.

16.1 ചിങ്ങം to കർക്കടകം — Kerala’s own solar calendar, named by the zodiac

Malayalam, like Tamil, has its **own** solar calendar — but even here, the two closest cousins name their months by two **different** logics.

What to know first

ചിങ്ങം, കന്നി, തുലാം, വൃശ്ചികം, ധനു, മകരം, കുംഭം, മീനം, മേടം, ഇടവം, മിഥുനം, കർക്കടകം (*Chirīṇṇam, Kanni, Tulām, Vṛścikam, Dhanu, Makaram, Kumbham, Mīnam, Mēḍam, Iḍavam, Mithunam, Karkīḍakam*).

This is the **Kollam Era** calendar (also called the Malayalam calendar), Kerala’s own solar civil calendar — genuinely separate from the Gregorian, the pan-Indian Hindu lunisolar calendar, **and** Tamil’s solar calendar.

Why it's said this way

Both Tamil's and Malayalam's calendars are **solar**, and both are independent of the Hindu lunisolar system — but they name their months differently. Tamil ties each month to a **nakshatra** (a lunar-mansion star cluster). Malayalam instead names each month directly for the **zodiac sign** (rāśi) the sun is passing through: ചിങ്ങം (*Chinṇam*) = Leo, കന്നി (*Kanni*) = Virgo, തുലാം (*Tulām*) = Libra, and so on straight through the zodiac. Same underlying idea — track the sun's yearly path against the stars — but two Dravidian languages chose two different sets of star-markers to name it by.

ചിങ്ങം 1 (the 1st of Chinṇam) marks the **Malayalam New Year** and the start of the **Onam** festival season — Kerala's own solar calendar, running its own independent year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Chinṇam, Kanni, Tulām, Vṛścikam, Dhanu, Makaram, Kumbham, Mīnam, Mēḍam, Iḍavam, Mithunam, Karkidakam”
- “Chinṇam = Leo” — a zodiac sign, not a nakshatra
- the contrast — Tamil uses nakshatras, Malayalam uses zodiac signs

Before you move on

Is Malayalam's calendar solar or lunisolar? (**Solar** — like Tamil's, and separate from the Hindu lunisolar system.) How does it differ from Tamil's in naming logic? (**Zodiac signs** — Chinṇam=Leo, Kanni=Virgo — rather than Tamil's nakshatra-based names.) What does Chinṇam 1 mark? (**Malayalam New Year**, the start of the Onam season.)

16.2 ൾ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ൾ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഌ

ഌ — *a nasal, ridden on the syllable before it.*

It is a **nasal**, written as a mark rather than as a letter. It rides on the syllable before it and turns the end of it nasal.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഌ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- സുഖം *sukham* — well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Writing: ഌ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഌ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഌ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സന്തോഷം · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ഌ three times, humming the nasal at the end of the syllable as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഌ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ㄛ? What does it add to the syllable before it? (**A nasal.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Malayalam and hear paathi, 'half', inside paathira.

Say pāthira, pull pāthi out of it, and show it is a native half-word rather than Sanskrit ardha.

17.1 ഉച്ച — a different Sanskrit metaphor, not a Sanskrit-free one

Kannada and Telugu both reached for Sanskrit's *madhya*, “middle,” to name noon. Malayalam looks different at first glance — but be careful before you call it “native.”

What to know first

ഉച്ച (*ucha*) = “**noon, midday**” — and unlike Kannada's *madhyāhna* or Telugu's *madhyāhnam*, this is **not** a *madhya* (“middle”) compound at all. It most likely shares its root with Tamil உச்சி (*ucci*, “**crown of the head, peak, summit, zenith**”) and Kannada's own ಉಚ್ಚಿ (*ucci*). Here's the honest twist: per Wiktionary, that whole *ucci* family across Tamil and Kannada is itself documented as a **Sanskrit borrowing**, from उच्च (*ucca*, “**high**”). Malayalam's own *ucha* has no fully documented etymology yet, so treat the connection as likely rather than settled — but if it holds, this isn't a case of Malayalam **avoiding** Sanskrit at all. It's Malayalam reaching for a **different** Sanskrit root than its neighbors: *ucca* (“high”) instead of *madhya*

(“middle”). Noon becomes “**the sun at its peak**” rather than “the middle of the day” — the same zenith-based idea inside Arabic’s *az-ẓuhr* (from a root meaning “to appear, become visible/apex”), just arrived at from Sanskrit rather than Arabic.

Why it’s said this way

Don’t walk away thinking Malayalam dodged Sanskrit here while Kannada and Telugu didn’t. The more likely picture: ഉച്ച may be just as Sanskrit-rooted as *madhyāhna* — it’s simply a *different* Sanskrit root (*ucca*, “high,” rather than *madhya*, “middle”). What’s genuinely different is the **metaphor**, not necessarily the **language of origin**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ucha*” — noon, “the peak” — compare Tamil’s “*ucci*”
- the honest contrast — Kannada/Telugu’s noon word means “middle”; Malayalam’s most likely means “peak” — both probably still Sanskrit, just different Sanskrit roots

Before you move on

Is ഉച്ച a Sanskrit “middle” word like Kannada’s *madhyāhna*? (**No** — it most likely comes from a *different* Sanskrit root, *ucca*, “high/peak,” not *madhya*, “middle.”) Does that make ഉച്ച a native Dravidian word? (**Not necessarily** — its likely relatives, Tamil *ucci* and Kannada *ucci*, are themselves documented Sanskrit borrowings.)

17.2 പാതിരാ — midnight as “half-night”

ഉച്ച named noon by the sun’s height. Malayalam builds midnight with a different spatial idea: cut the night in half.

What to know first

പാതിരാ (*paathira*) means “**midnight**.” It is built on പാതി (*paathi*), the everyday Malayalam word for “**half**”—as in *paathi vila*, “half price”—fused with a shortened form of “night.”

The result has the same “half-night” shape as Telugu అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*) and Hindi *ādhī rāt*. The pieces are not all cousins, though. Malayalam പാതി is a genuinely different word from Sanskrit **ardha**, the root behind Telugu *ardharātri* and, farther back, Hindi *ādhī*.

So two languages can independently choose the same transparent construction while filling it with unrelated words for “half.” The metaphor matches; the vocabulary does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paathira* — midnight
- *paathi* — half
- Malayalam *paathi* versus Sanskrit *ardha* — same job, different roots

Before you move on

What does പാതിരാ build on? (പാതി, “half,” plus a shortened night-word.) Is *paathi* the same root as Telugu *ardha*? (**No.** The two languages share the “half-night” logic but use unrelated half-words.)

17.3 ഉ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഊ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ഉ

ഉ — *u*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *u* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഉ somewhere inside it:

- ഉച്ച *ucca* — noon, most likely from a different Sanskrit metaphor than Kannada and Telugu

Writing: ഉ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഉ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഉ in the ones that have it

ഉച്ച · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ഉ three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഉ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഉ? What sound does it carry? (*u*.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 18

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the hour in Malayalam with *maṇi*, as in *oru maṇi*, one o'clock.

Say maṇi for hour, bell and gem, then oru maṇi, and state where Malayalam's and Tamil's dictionaries disagree about it.

18.1 മണി — one word in Malayalam's dictionaries, two in Tamil's

Kannada and Telugu both borrowed Sanskrit's “bell” word for “hour.” Malayalam's story is genuinely murkier — and it's about to disagree with its closest cousin, Tamil, on how this exact word is even structured.

What to know first

മണി (*maṇi*) = “hour, o'clock” — and it also means “bell, gong” and “gem, jewel, pearl.” Here's the honest, slightly untidy part: Malayalam's own dictionary tradition treats **all three of these senses as ONE word**, borrowed from Sanskrit मणि (*maṇi*, “gem, jewel, pearl”) — the same Sanskrit word behind names like *Manipravalam* and the mantra syllable in “*om maṇi padme hum*.” Under this account, “bell/hour” isn't a separate native word at all — it's just another meaning that grew out of the same borrowed “gem” word (a bell-shaped gem or ornament, perhaps, extending to the bell itself, and then to the hour it announces).

Why it's said this way

Here's what makes this genuinely interesting rather than settled: Tamil's closely related cognate மணி is analyzed very differently by Tamil's own reference dictionaries — as **two separate, unrelated words** that happen to be spelled and pronounced identically: a **native Dravidian** “bell, gong” word (which extends to “hour”), and a completely separate Sanskrit loan meaning “gem.” The broader comparative Dravidian dictionary (DEDR) does list Malayalam among the languages sharing that native “bell” word too — but even DEDR flags a possible Sanskrit connection for the whole word-family as unresolved. So: two closest-cousin languages, and even the specialists don't fully agree on whether this is one Sanskrit word wearing three meanings, or a native word and a Sanskrit word that just happen to sound alike.

Grammar Lens: telling the time

ഒരു മണി. — “One o'clock.” (*oru mani*, “one hour/bell”)
 രണ്ട് മണി. — “Two o'clock.” (*raṇṭṭu mani*, “two hour/bell”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mani” — hour, also “bell,” also “gem” — genuinely debated whether that's one word or two
- “oru mani” — one o'clock
- the honest point — Malayalam's own dictionaries call it one Sanskrit word; Tamil's call the bell/hour sense a separate, native word

Before you move on

According to Malayalam's own dictionary tradition, are “hour,” “bell,” and “gem” one word or two? (**One** — all traced to Sanskrit *maṇi*, “gem.”) How does Tamil's own dictionary tradition treat its cognate word differently? (As **two separate, unrelated homophones** — a native “bell/hour” word and a distinct Sanskrit “gem” loan.) Is this fully settled? (**No** — even the comparative

Dravidian dictionary flags the Sanskrit connection as an open question.)

18.2 ഷ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഉ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഷ

ഷ — *ṣa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ṣ*, it is **ṣa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഷ somewhere inside it:

- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇam* — (you) should forgive / sorry

Writing: ഷ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഷ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look*: at these words, and find ഷ in the ones that have it

സന്തോഷം · ക്ഷമിക്കണം · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* **ş** three times, saying *şa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **ş** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **ş**? What sound does it carry? (**şa**.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how old someone is in Malayalam and answer with a dative subject.

Ask *ningalkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?* and answer *enikku irupatu vayassuṇṭū* – ‘to me twenty age exists’.

19.1 നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? — “to you, how much age exists?”

Same Sanskrit word as Kannada and Telugu — but Malayalam builds a genuinely different sentence around it.

What to know first

വയസ്സ് (*vayass*) = “age” — the same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) behind Kannada’s *vayassu* and Telugu’s *vayasu*.

Grammar Lens: dative subject + “exists”

നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? — “How old are you?”
(formal/plural) — literally “**to you, how much age exists?**” (*ningalkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?* — from *ningalkku*, “to you” [dative] + *ethra vayassu*, “how much age” + *uṇṭū*, “exists.”) എനിക്ക് ഇരുപത് വയസ്സുണ്ട്. — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**to me twenty age exists.**” (*enikku irupatu vayassuṇṭū*.)

This is a real grammatical departure from Kannada and Telugu’s plain “your age how-much?” Malayalam puts the **person in the dative case** (“to you,” not “your”) and adds ഉണ്ടു് (*uṇṭŭ*, “exists, there is”) — the same existential verb Malayalam uses for ordinary possession and existence sentences generally. So the literal shape is “**to me, twenty years’ worth of age exists**” — a dative-subject-plus-existential-verb construction, genuinely different from its two Dravidian cousins even though the age-word itself is identical.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vayassu” — age
- “ningalkku ethra vayassuṇṭŭ?” — how old are you?
- “enikku irupatu vayassuṇṭŭ” — I am twenty, “to me twenty age exists”

Before you move on

Is Malayalam’s വയസ്സ് the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s and Telugu’s? (**Yes.**) Does Malayalam ask age the same simple way Kannada and Telugu do? (**No** — it uses a **dative** subject, “to you,” plus the existential verb ഉണ്ടു്, “exists.”) What does *enikku irupatu vayassuṇṭŭ* literally mean? (“**To me twenty age exists.**”)

19.2 യ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ധ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: യ

യ — *ya*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *y*, it is **ya**.

You already say these, and every one of them has യ somewhere inside it:

- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāṁ* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (lit. “work-do”)
- എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം *enikku malayāḷam ariyām* — ‘I know Malayalam’
- ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — please (dayavāyi)

Writing: യ — copy what you see

Put your pen on യ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find യ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* യ three times, saying *ya* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find യ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — യ? What sound does it carry? (*ya*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 20

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Malayalam and say what the weather is doing.

Say kālāvastha as ‘the state of time’, split it into kālam and avastha, and add mazha peyyunnu for rain.

20.1 പതിനൊന്ന്, ഇരുപത് — transparent “two-tens,” matching Tamil closely

Malayalam keeps the same “two-tens” idea you’ve now seen across this whole family — and here it’s still fully visible on the surface, almost identically to its closest cousin, Tamil.

What to know first

Malayalam’s teens echo പത്ത് (*pathu*, “ten”) plus each digit. പതിനൊന്ന് (*pathinonnu*) is 11, പന്ത്രണ്ട് (*panthraṇṭṭu*) is 12, and the pattern continues through പത്തൊമ്പത് (*pathompathu*, 19) — the same digit-plus-ten-echo compounding as its Dravidian cousins.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇരുപത് (*irupathu*, “twenty”) = ഇരു (*iru*, an older word for “two”) + പത്ത് (*pathu*, “ten”) — still fully visible as “two-tens” today. This matches **Tamil’s own** *irupathu* almost letter-for-letter, both languages having kept this compound transparent — unlike Telugu’s *iravai*,

which most likely continues the same underlying pattern but has worn down past the point of visibly splitting apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pathinonnu, panthraṇṭŭ” — 11, 12
- “iru” — an older word for two, “pathu” — ten
- “irupathu” — twenty, “two-tens,” transparent

Before you move on

How are Malayalam’s teens built? (പത്ത (ten) + a digit, compounded.) What two pieces build ഇരുപത് (twenty)? (ഇരു “two” + പത്ത് “ten” — “two-tens.”) Which other Dravidian language keeps this exact same transparent compound for twenty? (Tamil.)

20.2 കാലാവസ്ഥ — “the state of time,” an echo of Spanish’s tiempo

Remember Spanish’s *tiempo*, one word for both “time” and “weather”? Malayalam reaches the same connection between time and weather — but builds it as a compound instead of reusing one word.

What to know first

കാലാവസ്ഥ (*kālāvastha*) = “weather” — built from:

- കാലം (*kālam*, “time”) — Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), “time,” also the name of the god **Kāla** (an epithet of Śiva/Yama as the personification of time).
- അവസ്ഥ (*avastha*, “state, condition”) — Sanskrit अवस्था (*avasthā*).

So *kālāvastha* literally means “**the state of time**” — a genuinely different construction than Spanish’s *tiempo*, but reaching for the exact same underlying idea: weather as bound up with time. Where Spanish just **reuses** its word for “time” to also mean “weather,” Malayalam **compounds** “time” with “state” to build a brand-new word for the same concept.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മഴ പെയ്യുന്നു. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling.**” (*mazha peyyunnu.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kālāvastha*” — weather, “the state of time”
- “*kālam*” — time, “*avastha*” — state
- “*mazha peyyunnu*” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two Sanskrit pieces of കാലാവസ്ഥ, and what does the whole word literally mean? (കാലം, “time,” + അവസ്ഥ, “state” — “**the state of time.**”) What earlier lesson does this echo, and how is the construction different? (Spanish’s *tiempo* — Spanish reuses ONE word for both senses; Malayalam **compounds** two separate words instead.) What word does Malayalam use for “rain”? (മഴ, *mazha.*)

20.3 ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഓ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ദ

ദ — *da*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *d*, it is **da**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ദ somewhere inside it:

- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — please (dayavāyi)

Writing: ദ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ദ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ദ in the ones that have it

നന്ദി · ദയവായി · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ദ three times, saying *da* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ദ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ദ? What sound does it carry? (*da*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) ✍ pen (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Malayalam.

Say nāya on the shared Dravidian dog-root, then pūcha, which follows Tamil’s cat-word rather than Kannada’s.

21.1 നായ, പൂച്ച — matching Tamil closely on both counts

Malayalam keeps close company with its nearest cousin, Tamil, on both words this time — while still fitting into the honest, more fragmented Dravidian picture for “cat.”

What to know first

നായ (*nāya*, “dog”) continues the same solid, native **Proto-Dravidian** root as Kannada’s ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*) and Tamil’s own word — no mystery here at all, unlike the tangled dog-words of Spanish, Hindi, and English.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പൂച്ച (*pūcha*, “cat”) closely matches Tamil’s **everyday** word for cat — a different root from Kannada’s ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*, related instead to the word for “wildcat”) and Telugu’s పిల్లి (*pilli*, a separate Proto-Dravidian root of its own, most likely the source behind Sanskrit’s *biḍāla* and Hindi’s *billī*). So “cat” genuinely splits three ways across just these

four Dravidian languages, even though “dog” mostly agrees.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāya” — dog, same solid root as Kannada and Tamil
- “pūcha” — cat, matching Tamil’s everyday word closely

Before you move on

Does നായ share Kannada’s *nāyi* root? (**Yes** — the same solid, native Proto-Dravidian root.) Does പൂച്ച match Kannada’s *bekku* or Tamil’s everyday cat-word? (**Tamil’s** — Kannada’s *bekku* and Telugu’s *pilli* both come from different roots entirely.)

21.2 സ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഓ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: സ

സ — *sa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *s*, it is **sa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has സ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- സുഖം *sukham* — well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്”
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome

Writing: സ — copy what you see

Put your pen on സ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find സ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സന്തോഷം · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* സ three times, saying *sa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find സ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — സ? What sound does it carry? (*sa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Malayalam and say why the two come from unrelated roots.

Say paccha beside Tamil paccai and mañña beside mañcal, and show they are not doublets of each other.

22.1 പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ — matching Tamil twice over, by two different routes

Telugu’s green and yellow turned out to be one word wearing two faces. Malayalam’s green and yellow are a different story again — two completely separate native words, each one matching Tamil closely, just not matching *each other*.

What to know first

പച്ച (paccha, “green”) comes from **Proto-Dravidian** **pac-* — matching Tamil’s பச்சை (paccai) almost exactly, and the same root already seen in Kannada’s *hasiru* and Telugu’s *pacca*. No surprises here; this is the familiar family from the last two lessons.

Why it’s said this way

മഞ്ഞ (mañña, “yellow”) and മഞ്ഞൾ (maññal, “turmeric”) are a native **doublet pair**. This is a **completely different** Dravidian root from *pac-*, matching Tamil’s own turmeric/yellow pair, மஞ்சள்

(*mañcal*), closely. So here’s the honest shape of this arc so far: Kannada split green and yellow into two unrelated families (native vs. Sanskrit loan); Telugu kept them as doublets of the **same** native root; and Malayalam keeps them as **two separate** native Dravidian roots, each one independently matching its Tamil counterpart. No single pattern holds across all three languages — the honest answer is that each solved “green vs. yellow” its own way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പച്ച” — green, matching Tamil *paccai*
- “മഞ്ഞ” — yellow, matching Tamil *mañcal*, a separate root entirely
- the contrast — *paccha* and *mañña* are NOT doublets of each other, unlike Telugu’s *pacca/pasupu*

Before you move on

Does മഞ്ഞ (*mañña*, “yellow”) share a root with പച്ച (*paccha*, “green”)? (**No** — they are two separate native Dravidian roots.) What Tamil word does മഞ്ഞ closely match? (மஞ்சள், *mañcal*, “turmeric/yellow.”) Across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam, is there one single pattern for how green and yellow relate? (**No** — Kannada split them into native vs. Sanskrit-loan; Telugu made them doublets of one root; Malayalam keeps them as two separate native roots.)

Chapter 23

Day

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use divasam for an everyday day in Malayalam and still recognise native nāl where it survives.

Find nāl alive inside nāle, oru nāl and pirannāl, and answer whether Sanskrit divasam erased it.

23.1 ദിവസം (divasam) — the everyday Sanskrit day-word

You already met Malayalam’s native word for “day” back in Chapter 4 — hiding inside “tomorrow.” This lesson gives it, and its Sanskrit rival, their own honest reckoning.

What to know first

ദിവസം (divasam) — “day” — is Malayalam’s common, everyday word for counting a day (as in മൂന്ന് ദിവസം, *mūnnu divasam*, “three days”). It’s a Sanskrit **tatsama**, borrowed whole from दिवस (*divasa*), which itself traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **dyew-* (“to shine”), via the Sanskrit root दिव् (*div*). That’s the **same ultimate PIE root** behind Hindi/Kannada’s दिन/ದಿನ (*dina*) and Latin’s own *diēs* — but be careful here: *divasa* and *dina* are **two different Sanskrit formations** off that shared root (one built with an *-asa* suffix, one with Sanskrit’s own *-nó-* formation), not the same word wearing two scripts. Same root, different branch — the *din/diēs* pattern, replaying itself one level deeper, inside Sanskrit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam also has ദിനം (**dinam**) — the **exact same** Sanskrit tatsama word as Kannada’s plain, everyday *dina*. But in Malayalam, **dinam** is the more **literary, formal** alternate (think ജന്മദിനം, *janmadinam*, “birthday,” the modern calque-style term) — **divasam** does the everyday counting work instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “divasam” — “day,” the everyday counting word
- “dinam” — the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s *dina*, but formal here

Before you move on

What PIE root does ദിവസം ultimately share with Hindi/Kannada’s *dina* and Latin’s *diēs*? (**dyew-*, “to shine” — though *divasa* and *dina* are different Sanskrit formations off it, not the same word.) Which is the everyday counting word? (**divasam**.) Which is more literary or formal? (**dinam**.)

23.2 നാൾ — the native day-word that narrowed its job

ദിവസം counts ordinary days and ദിനം writes formally. But Malayalam’s native day-word never disappeared—you met it long ago inside “tomorrow.”

What to know first

നാൾ (*nāl*) means “day” and descends from Proto-Dravidian **nāl*, cognate with Tamil நாள் and Kannada ನಾಳ. Chapter 4 already gave you നാളെ (*nāle*, “tomorrow”), with the native day-word still visible inside.

The Sanskrit loan ദിവസം took over ordinary counting, but നാൾ narrowed rather than vanished. ഒരു നാൾ (*oru nāl*, “one day”) remains natural in storytelling, and the word stays productive in പിറന്നാൾ (*pirannāl*),

“birthday,” literally “day of birth.” That traditional compound stands beside the newer Sanskrit-style ജന്മദിനം (*janmadīnam*).

Three words therefore carry three honest jobs: *divasam* counts, *dinam* is formal, and native *nāl* tells stories and marks birthdays. This echoes Kannada’s native *hagalu*: borrowing narrowed a native word’s domain without erasing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nāle* — tomorrow, with *nāl* inside
- *oru nāl* — one day, narrative register
- *pirannāl* — birthday, day of birth

Before you move on

Has Sanskrit **divasam** erased native നാൾ? (No.) Where does *nāl* live now? (Inside tomorrow, in narrative “one day,” and in the living compound for birthday.)

Chapter 24

Night

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say night in Malayalam with *rāthri* and tell literary *iravū* apart from everyday *iruḷ*, ‘darkness’.

Sort iravū from iruḷ by the job each one still does in the modern language.

24.1 രാത്രി (rāthri) — night, already hiding inside midnight

Last lesson’s *divasam* had three words doing three honest jobs. This word’s family is smaller, but the split is just as real — and one piece of it, you’ve technically already heard.

What to know first

രാത്രി (rāthri) — “night” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**. You’ve likely already met a piece of it: പാതിരാ (pāthirā, “midnight,” Chapter 17) is built from പാതി (pāthi, “half”) fused with what’s most plausibly a **shortened form** of this very word — “rā” standing in for the whole of *rāthri* (Chapter 17 itself didn’t spell out which word was being shortened, but the parallel Tamil compound, *pāti-y-irāttiri*, points the same way). This lesson gives it its own, full standing.

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest echo across the family: just like Hindi's own रात (*raat*, ultimately from the same Sanskrit रात्रि), Malayalam's *rāthri* traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-* (“to rest”) — a **completely different** PIE root from Latin's *nox* (**nók^wts*). Two Indo-European languages, two words for “night,” that **look** like they might be old cousins — but genuinely **aren't**. Same false-cognate story, now confirmed across a second Indo-Aryan-rooted borrowing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rāthri” — “night,” already hiding, shortened, inside pāthirā
- the honest PIE echo — *h₁reh₁-*, “to rest,” like Hindi's *raat*, *NOT* related to Latin's *nox*

Before you move on

Where did you already, technically, meet a piece of രാത്രി before this lesson? (Shortened to “rā” inside പാതിരാ, *pāthirā*, “midnight,” Chapter 17.) Does *rāthri*'s PIE root match Latin *nox*'s? (No — **h₁reh₁-* “to rest,” a completely different root, the same false-cognate pattern already seen with Hindi's *raat*.)

24.2 ഇരവ് / ഇരുൾ — two native words, two jobs

രാത്രി is the ordinary Sanskrit night-word. Malayalam also kept two native Dravidian words, but they do not compete with it in the same way.

What to know first

- ഇരവ് (*iravū*) is cognate with Tamil இரவு (*iravu*) and is traced by one source to Proto-Dravidian **cira*, “darkness.” It survives mainly as a **literary or classical-register** synonym for “night.” Poetry is a more likely home for it than everyday conversation.

- ഇരുൾ (*irul*) descends from Proto-Dravidian **cirVl* and belongs to the pan-Dravidian family Kannada ಇರುಳು, Tamil இருள், and Telugu ఇరులు. It remains current in modern Malayalam—a 2021 film is titled *Irul*—but its ordinary sense is **darkness**, not night as a time period.

This is not one native night-word simply pushed into archaism. It is two native words carrying different pieces of രാത്രി's semantic space: one formal and poetic, the other common but narrower.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *iravũ* — literary night
- *irul* — current darkness
- related ideas, different modern jobs

Before you move on

Are ഇരവ് and ഇരുൾ interchangeable everyday words for night? (No.) Which is literary “night”? (*iravũ*.) Which is current “darkness”? (*irul*.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Malayalam with śubha rāthri.

Say śubha rāthri as 'auspicious night', and mark the English code-switching claim as thinly sourced and not unique to Malayalam.

25.1 ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri) — “good night,” and a pattern seen before

You already have *rāthri*. One more Sanskrit word, shared with Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu, completes Malayalam’s “good night” — and this lesson’s honest twist is one you’ve technically seen before, just in a different language.

What to know first

ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri) — “good night” — literally “auspicious night.” Both pieces are Sanskrit **tatsama**: രാത്രി (*rāthri*, “night,” already met last lesson) plus ശുഭ (*śubha*, “auspicious,” from root śubh, “to be beautiful,” ultimately PIE **kewb^h-* — the same word, the same root, already verified for the Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu siblings of this exact arc).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the honest twist, hedged deliberately: some sources describe modern Malayalam speakers, especially in casual settings, **code-switching to English** “good night” rather than saying ശുഭ രാത്രി aloud — treating it more as the standard, correct-but-formal translation than an everyday spoken phrase. But this lesson isn’t presenting that as a fresh Malayalam discovery. The **exact same claim**, sourced from similarly thin blogs and forum posts, is also made for **Telugu**, and there too it is genuinely **unclear** whether the pattern is Telugu-specific or something broader. Seeing the same claim turn up again for Malayalam **strengthens the suspicion that this is a broader South Asian pattern** (or simply a sourcing artifact — the languages that happen to get commented on in casual sources), not a language-specific trait worth treating as a genuine discovery each time. Either way, *śubha rāthri* itself remains perfectly correct, understood Malayalam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha rāthri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- śubha’s own root — śubh, “to be beautiful” → “auspicious” — the same root already met for Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu
- the honest twist — this code-switching claim isn’t uniquely Malayalam’s; the same weakly-sourced claim already appeared for Telugu

Before you move on

What does ശുഭ രാത്രി literally mean? (“**Auspicious night.**”) Is the “Malayalam speakers code-switch to English instead” claim a fresh discovery in this lesson? (**No** — the identical claim, similarly thinly sourced, is also made about **Telugu**, suggesting a broader pattern or a sourcing artifact, not a Malayalam-specific fact.) Does this affect whether *śubha rāthri* itself is correct? (**No** — it’s perfectly correct and understood Malayalam, whatever its actual spoken frequency.)

Chapter 26

Morning

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say morning in Malayalam with *rāvile* and hear the night-word hidden inside it.

*Say *rāvile*, pull *rāvũ* ‘night’ out of it, and place *prabhātami* beside it as the Sanskrit alternative.*

26.1 രാവിലെ (*rāvile*) — “morning,” built from “night”

Kannada’s morning word means “the shining.” Telugu’s means “rise.” Malayalam’s most common morning word means something stranger on its face: night.

What to know first

രാവിലെ (*rāvile*) — “morning” — is, per Wiktionary, a compound: രാവ് (*rāvũ*) plus the suffixes **-il** and **-e**. Here’s the honest surprise: രാവ് shares its root — not its exact form — with the word already met in Chapter 24, ഇരവ് (*iravũ*), there a **literary-register synonym for “night”** itself. Wiktionary confirms both as cognates, both tracing to **Proto-Dravidian** **cira* (“darkness”) — a cognate doublet within Malayalam, not literally one word in two spellings. So Malayalam’s everyday word for “morning” is, transparently, built from **night** plus locative-ish suffixes — not from light, dawn, or rising, the strategies Kannada’s ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (“the shining”) and Telugu’s ఉదయം (Sanskrit “rise”) both reach for instead.

Why it's said this way

No source spells out **why** “at/in the night” came to mean “morning” specifically — it’s a plausible semantic path (perhaps “the night just ending,” the pre-dawn hours) rather than one directly documented step by step. Treat the **morphological composition** as confirmed (Wiktionary is explicit about the *rāvũ+il+e* breakdown); treat the **semantic mechanism** as a reasonable but unconfirmed inference, not a settled fact.

Why it's said this way

Malayalam keeps two other words for “morning” too. പ്രഭാതം (*prabhātam*) is a Sanskrit **tatsama** sharing its root — **prabhāta**, “to shine, become bright” — with Telugu’s own సుప్రభాతం (*suprabhātam*, Telugu’s own morning greeting) — a genuine cross-language echo. പുലർച്ച (pularcca) is native Dravidian, but be honest about its etymology: one database entry links it to a root meaning “to subsist, live,” which may or may not be the same root behind its “dawn” sense — treat that specific connection as unconfirmed, not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rāvile” — “morning,” built from *rāvũ* (“night”) + locative suffixes
- the honest surprise — a cognate doublet of the night-word already met as *iravũ* (Chapter 24), same root, now doing morning’s job
- *prabhātam* — same Sanskrit root as Telugu’s *suprabhātam*

Before you move on

What is രാവിലെ literally built from? (രാവ് — “night” — plus locative suffixes *-il/-e*; a cognate doublet, same root, as ഇരവ് met in Chapter 24 — not literally the same word.) Is the exact reason “night” came to mean “morning” fully documented? (**No** — the compound itself is confirmed, but the semantic shift is a plausible, unconfirmed inference.) What root does പ്രഭാതം share with Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం? (**prabhāta** — the same root behind Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం.)

Chapter 27

Evening

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say evening in Malayalam with *vaikunnēram*, ‘latening time’.

Say vaikunnēram, trace it to vaikuka ‘to get late’, and flag that sources disagree on whether it also covers afternoon.

27.1 വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnēram) — “evening,” built from a verb meaning “to get late”

Telugu reached for Sanskrit to name the evening. Malayalam’s most common word takes a completely different route — an everyday verb, not a borrowed noun.

What to know first

വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnēram) — “evening” — is, per Wiktionary, a compound: വൈക് (vaikū) + -ഉം (-um) + നേരം (nēram, “time”), literally “latening time.” നേരം is itself confirmed native **Proto-Dravidian** (cognate Tamil நேரம்), not a Sanskrit borrowing — so unlike Telugu’s Sanskrit సాయంత్రం, this whole compound is native Dravidian, start to finish. The വൈക് root plausibly connects to an everyday Malayalam verb, വൈകുക (vaikuka), confirmed “to get late” — though be honest that this specific link is the author’s own reasonable inference, not something Wiktionary’s compound entry states outright.

Why it's said this way

Here's a real tension, not smoothed over: Wiktionary's own entry lists **both** “afternoon” **and** “evening” as senses of this single word. But two independently-fetched phrasebook sources (ling-app.com, talkpal.ai) draw a cleaner line — **evening** is വൈകുന്നേരം, while **afternoon** gets its own, separate compound built on ഉച്ച (already met, Chapter 17, “noon”) plus കഴിഞ്ഞ് (*kazhinju*, “passed, gone by”). This project's discipline is to flag genuine disagreement rather than quietly pick whichever source is more convenient — so treat the afternoon/evening boundary here as **genuinely blurry** in the dictionary sense, even though the two everyday phrasebook sources agree on a cleaner practical split.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vaikunnēraṇi” — “evening,” literally “latening time”
- the everyday verb root — vaikuka, “to get late”
- the honest tension — Wiktionary blurs afternoon/evening; phrasebooks split them cleanly

Before you move on

What does വൈകുന്നേരം literally mean, and what verb is it plausibly built from? (“**Latening time**” — from വൈകുക, “to get late.”) Do all sources agree on where “afternoon” ends and “evening” begins for this word? (**No** — Wiktionary lists it as covering both senses; phrasebook sources instead draw a clean line, treating afternoon as a separate compound.) Is വൈകുന്നേരം a Sanskrit borrowing, like Telugu's సాయంత్రം? (**No** — it's a native Dravidian compound, built from an everyday verb and a native “time” word, നേരം.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say afternoon in Malayalam as uchakaliññ – literally ‘noon having passed’.

Build uchakaliññ from ucha plus kaliyuka, and contrast it with Telugu, which widened its noon-word instead.

28.1 ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് (uchakaliññ) — “noon, having passed”

Telugu let its noon-word quietly widen to also mean “afternoon.” Malayalam solves the same problem with a completely different strategy: it builds a new phrase instead.

What to know first

ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് (uchakaliññ) — “afternoon” — is a transparent **two-word phrase**, not a single dictionary headword (no Wiktionary entry exists for the compound as a whole). It’s built from ഉച്ച (already met, Chapter 17, “noon”) plus കഴിഞ്ഞ്, the **past converb form** of കഴിയുക (*kaliyuka*), itself Wiktionary-confirmed **Proto-Dravidian** **kazi* (“to be over, spent, finished”). Be honest about the citation: Wiktionary’s own conjugation line shows only the finite past tense, കഴിഞ്ഞു (*kaliññu*) — not this converb form directly. The converb is the grammatically correct choice for chaining into a compound like this one, but treat the exact written form as

a reasonable grammatical inference, not a directly Wiktionary-sourced citation. Put together: “**noon having passed**” — afternoon is, quite literally, the time after noon is done.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest structural contrast: Telugu’s own afternoon word (మధ్యాహ్నం) is the exact **same word** as its “noon,” simply **widened** to also cover “afternoon” — one word, stretched. Malayalam does something structurally different: ഉച്ച itself stays put, meaning only “noon,” and a **second word** — കഴിഞ്ഞ, “passed” — gets bolted on to build a new phrase for “afternoon.” Same problem (naming the stretch of time after noon), two genuinely different solutions: semantic widening in Telugu, compositional phrase-building in Malayalam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uchakaliññ” — “afternoon,” literally “noon having passed”
- the verb behind it — kalīyuka, “to be over, spent” — Proto-Dravidian *kazī*
- the honest contrast — Telugu widens the same noon-word; Malayalam builds a new phrase on top of it

Before you move on

What does ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ literally mean? (“**Noon having passed**” — ഉച്ച, “noon,” plus the past tense of കഴിയുക, “to be over, spent.”) Is ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ a single dictionary word, like ഉച്ച itself? (No — it’s a transparent two-word phrase; no Wiktionary entry exists for the compound as a whole.) How does Malayalam’s strategy for naming “afternoon” differ from Telugu’s? (**Telugu widens its existing noon-word’s meaning; Malayalam instead builds a new phrase, keeping the noon-word unchanged.**)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the morning in Malayalam with suprabhātani.

Say suprabhātani, split su- from prabhātani, and show it is NOT built on śubha the way good night is.

29.1 സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātani) — Malayalam’s real “good morning,” a familiar word wearing a new hat

You might expect Malayalam’s “good morning” to pair ML-C25’s “auspicious” word with ML-C26’s morning word. It doesn’t — Malayalam reaches for a completely different Sanskrit “good,” and for a word you’ve technically already half-met.

What to know first

സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātani) — “good morning” — is Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting: two independently-fetched sources confirm it: one states it’s used in **both formal and informal** contexts, the second separately calls it “the most general greeting” for good morning — genuine corroboration, not a single source’s claim taken on faith. Here’s the honest surprise: it is **not** built on ശുഭ (ML-C25’s “auspicious,” the word behind Malayalam’s own “good night”) at all. Instead, it’s built from the Sanskrit **prefix su-** (“good”) fused directly onto പ്രഭാതം — already met,

Chapter 26, as an alternative Malayalam word for “morning.” Two genuinely different Sanskrit “good” morphemes: ശുഭ is a standalone adjective; **su-** here is a bound prefix that only ever attaches to another word.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest cross-language twist: സുപ്രഭാതం is the **exact same Sanskrit tatsama word** as Telugu’s own సుప్రభాతం — same su-prefix, same ప్రభాత/ *prabhāta* root. But the two languages hand it **opposite jobs**. In Malayalam, it’s the **primary**, most commonly used morning greeting. In Telugu, it’s only a **secondary** alternative — Telugu’s primary greeting, శుభోదయం, is built on a completely different Sanskrit root (*udaya*, “rise,” not *prabhāta*). Same borrowed word, opposite roles across two closely related languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “suprabhātam” — “good morning,” su- (“good”) + prabhāta (“shine, dawn,” ML-C26)
- the honest surprise — NOT built on śubha; a different Sanskrit “good” morpheme entirely
- the cross-language inversion — Malayalam’s primary greeting is Telugu’s secondary alternative

Before you move on

Is സുപ്രഭാതం built on ശുഭ, ML-C25’s “auspicious” word? (**No** — it’s built on the Sanskrit prefix su-, a different “good” morpheme, fused onto പ്രഭാതం, ML-C26’s alternative morning word.) Is സുപ്രഭാതం the primary morning greeting in both Malayalam and Telugu? (**No** — it’s PRIMARY in Malayalam but only a SECONDARY alternative in Telugu, where శుభోదయం — built on a different root — is primary.) Is the “used in both formal and informal contexts” claim as shaky as Telugu’s own morning-greeting claim? (**No** — it’s confirmed by TWO independently-fetched sources, a genuinely stronger evidentiary footing than resting on just one.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the evening in Malayalam with śubha sāyāhnam.

Say śubha sāyāhnam, note it is built on the poetic sāyāhnam rather than native vaikunnēram, and follow sāya back to PIE.

30.1 ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam) — “good evening,” a different evening-word than expected

You might expect this greeting to pair śubha with the evening-word you already know. It doesn’t — Malayalam reaches for a completely different word instead, one with a poetic edge.

What to know first

ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam) — “good evening” — is confirmed real by a directly-fetched source, used “**from late afternoon until sunset.**” It’s built from ശുഭ (ML-C25, “auspicious”) plus സായാഹ്നം (*sāyāhnam*, “evening, eventide”). Here’s the honest surprise: this is **not** built on വൈകുണ്ഠം, the native word already met in Chapter 27, at all. സായാഹ്നം is a **completely separate** word — a Sanskrit **tatsama**, which Wiktionary’s own part-of-speech label calls “**poetic.**” That’s a real, independently-checkable signal (not an unverifiable blog claim) that this

particular greeting likely leans formal or literary, even though the phrase itself is confirmed correct and genuinely used.

Why it's said this way

സായാഹ്നം is, per a Sanskrit dictionary, a compound of साय (“end”) plus अह्न (“day”) — the same “-ahna” day-part suffix already met in words like *madhyāhna* and *aparāhna*. Following the etymology one hop further, Wiktionary’s own साय entry explicitly confirms this root traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **seh₁-* (“long, lasting”), directly naming सायम् (*sāyam* — Telugu’s own root) and **Latin** *sērus* as cognates. So this is a genuinely, properly-verified shared ancestor with Telugu’s సాయంత్రం — the same striking PIE chain to Latin *sērus*, French *soir*, and Italian *sera* — not merely a plausible guess, but a confirmed cognate, reached by chaining through two Wiktionary pages rather than stopping at the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha sāyāhnaṁ” — “good evening,” confirmed real, used from late afternoon until sunset
- the honest surprise — NOT built on vaikunnēraṁ; a separate, Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” Sanskrit word instead
- the confirmed echo — sāyāhnaṁ’s साय root genuinely shares the PIE *seh₁-*/*Latin sērus* ancestry behind Telugu’s సాయంత్రం

Before you move on

Is ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം built on വൈകുണ്ഠനരം, ML-C27’s native evening word? (No — സായാഹ്നം is a completely separate Sanskrit tatsama.) What does Wiktionary’s own part-of-speech label for സായാഹ്നം suggest about its register? (“Poetic” — a real, checkable signal it likely skews formal or literary.) Is it confirmed that സായാഹ്നം shares that spectacular PIE root with Telugu’s సాయంత్రం? (Yes — Wiktionary’s separate साय entry directly confirms the same PIE *seh₁-* ancestry, naming *sāyam* and *Latin sērus* as cognates — a genuinely verified shared root, reached by

following the etymology one hop further.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the afternoon in Malayalam with śubha madhyāhnam, and say how it differs from the everyday afternoon word.

Line up the three sister languages' everyday afternoon words and show where all three converge on śubha + madhyāhna.

31.1 ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam) — formal good afternoon

Morning broke the pattern entirely. Evening kept the pattern but swapped in an unexpected word. This final greeting brings a different kind of surprise: a word you haven't met, that turns out to connect Malayalam right back to Kannada and Telugu.

What to know first

ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam) — “good afternoon” — is confirmed, by a directly-fetched source, as a genuinely **formal** greeting: “**mainly used in official or ceremonial settings**” and “**not as commonly used in daily conversation.**” (A suspiciously precise “fewer than 1%” statistic turned up in an initial search summary for this claim — but it couldn't be traced to either page actually fetched, so it's deliberately left out here as an apparent confabulation; the real, hedged qualitative finding stands on its own.) It's built from ശുഭ (ML-C25) plus മധ്യാഹ്നം (*madhyāhnam*, “**noon**”) — which Wiktionary confirms is a direct **synonym** of

ML-C17’s ഉച്ച. Here’s the honest surprise: Malayalam had this “middle”-based noon-word all along — ML-C17 simply didn’t highlight it, teaching ഉച്ച (“peak, high”) instead. And this greeting is **not** built on ML-C28’s ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് compound (the actual TIME-AFTERNOON phrase already taught) at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha madhyāhnam” — “good afternoon,” a formal, ceremonial-register greeting
- the honest surprise — madhyāhnam is a genuine synonym of ucca, Malayalam’s own “noon” word, just not the one taught first

Before you move on

Is ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം built on ML-C28’s ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ്? (**No** — it’s built on മധ്യാഹ്നം, a genuine Wiktionary-confirmed synonym of ML-C17’s ഉച്ച, not the TIME-AFTERNOON compound.) Is the “fewer than 1% use this” statistic something this lesson confirms? (**No** — it couldn’t be traced to any directly-fetched source and is deliberately excluded; only the hedged “formal, not common in daily conversation” finding is asserted.)

31.2 One greeting, three afternoon strategies

Malayalam’s formal greeting uses ശുഭ + മധ്യാഹ്നം. Kannada and Telugu land on the same phrase—but their ordinary afternoon words took three different routes.

What to know first

language	formal afternoon greeting
Malayalam	ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം
Kannada	ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ
Telugu	శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం

All three share the Sanskrit **śubha + madhyāhna** structure. That shared greeting is striking because the languages' everyday time words diverge:

- **Telugu** widened its *madhya*-based noon-word so the same word also covers afternoon.
- **Kannada** built a separate Sanskrit tatsama, ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (aparāhna, *apara + ahna*), rather than widening *madhyāhna*.
- **Malayalam** built ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ, the unrelated *ucca* “noon” plus “having passed.”

So there are three genuinely different everyday strategies, not a simple two-versus-one split. At the formal greeting layer, all three converge on the same borrowed building blocks.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shared greeting structure — *śubha + madhyāhna*
- Telugu — widening
- Kannada — a separate *aparāhna* word
- Malayalam — “noon having passed”

Before you move on

Do the three languages share one ordinary afternoon-word strategy? (No.) Where do they converge? (In the formal greeting, all using **śubha + madhyāhna**.)

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a Malayalam verb as stem plus one ending with no person marking at all, swap that ending for past, future or mood, and say why ‘I know Malayalam’ puts me in the dative instead of the subject slot.

Say എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം, name the two slots that built *irikkunnu*, *pōkunnu* and *kāṇunnu*, and explain why this verb moves the knower out of the subject slot altogether.

32.1 ഉണ്ട് (uṇṭŭ) — “there is,” and the machine inside every Malayalam verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. English makes one verb, “to be,” do three jobs. Malayalam uses three words.

What to know first

ഉണ്ട് — *uṇṭŭ* — there is, there are; [someone] has

ഇരിക്കുക — *irikkuka* — to be somewhere, to stay, to sit

Chapter 2 gave you ആണ് (*āṇŭ*), the “is” that links two nouns: *enre pēru Arun āṇŭ*, “my name is Arun.” ഉണ്ട് does a different job — **existing** and **having**: *enikku oru sahōdaran uṇṭŭ*, “to-me one brother there-is,” which

is how Malayalam says “I have a brother.” ഇരിക്കുക is being in a **place**: *nān vīṭṭil irikkunnu*, “I am at home.”

Identity, existence, location — and none stands in for another.

The letters in this word

ഉ (the standing vowel *u*) + ണ് + ൾ → ഉണ്ട്. Both consonants are retroflex — tongue curled back — and both have had their vowel stripped, so the word trails off on a half-swallowed *ũ*: *uṇ-ṭũ*. ഇരിക്കുക runs *i-rik-ku-ka*, with the doubled ക held long.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both are native Dravidian, from the oldest layer, and the family split them between its daughters: **Tamil** kept இரு (*iru*), “be, stay”; **Kannada** kept the same word, ಇರು (*iru*); **Telugu** kept the other one, ఉండు (*uṇḍu*). Malayalam kept **both**, and gave each a job.

Grammar Lens: two pieces, where Tamil has three

English changes a verb with words **around** it: *I am*, *I was*, *I will be*. Malayalam glues a piece **onto the end**:

ഇരിക്ക് + ഉന്നു → ഇരിക്കുന്നു

irikk- (stay) + *-unnu* (happening now) → *irikkunnu*

Stem, then tense. Two slots, and that is the whole machine. Tamil glues on a **third** piece naming who acts: *iru* + *-kkir-* + *-ēn* (I) → *irukkirēn*, “I am,” against *irukkirān*, “he is.” Malayalam threw that slot away. *Nān irikkunnu*, *nā irikkunnu*, *avan irikkunnu* — the verb never moves. Chapter 5 showed this with one verb; it holds for **every** Malayalam verb, and for no sister.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three jobs — “āṇũ” is, “uṇṭũ” there-is, “irikkuka” be somewhere
- “enikku oru sahōdaran uṇṭũ” — I have a brother

- the two pieces — “irikk ... unnu”
- one verb, three people — “ñān, nī, avan ... irikkunnu”

Before you move on

Which be-word does Malayalam use for having something? (ഉണ്ട്, *uṇṭū*.) What are the two pieces of *irikkunnu*? (**Stem and tense**; there is no third piece.) How does the verb change between “I stay” and “he stays”? (**It does not.**) Next: the piece that carries time.

32.2 പോകുക (pōkuka) — “to go,” and the piece that carries time

Stem, then tense. Hold the stem still and swap the second piece. That is the whole of Malayalam tense, and it is a shorter list than you expect.

What to know first

പോകുക — *pōkuka* — to go

Chapter 4 met this verb in passing, on the way to a farewell. Here it goes to work. The dictionary form is the stem പോക്- (*pōk-*) plus -ഉക (-*uka*), the ending that means “to ____.”

when	Malayalam	the ending
now	<i>pōkunnu</i>	<i>-unnu</i>
already	<i>pōyi</i>	<i>-i</i>
not yet	<i>pōkum</i>	<i>-um</i>

You have said the middle one already: the goodbye പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) opens with *pōyi*, “having gone.”

The letters in this word

പോ (*pa* wearing the long-*ō* sign) + കു (*ku*) + ക (*ka*) → പോകുക.
The *ō* is long and round; let it run.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോ- is native Dravidian, so old it has barely moved: Tamil போ (pō), Telugu పోవు (pōvu), the same verb.

Kannada's everyday word is ಹೋಗು (hōgu), and that *h* is no different root. Old Dravidian *p*- softened to *h*- in Kannada — “ten” is Malayalam പത്തു (pattū) against Kannada ಹತ್ತು (hattu), the very same swap.

Grammar Lens: three forms are the whole conjugation

In most languages a tense is a **list**. English has *I go / he goes*. Tamil, Malayalam's closest sister, needs an ending for every person: *pōgīrēṇ* (“I go”), *pōgīrāy* (“you go”), *pōgīrāṇ* (“he goes”), *pōgīrōm* (“we go”). Malayalam's present tense is one word long. *Ñān pōkunnu*, *nī pōkunnu*, *avan pōkunnu*, *avar pōkunnu* — I, you, he, they, and *pōkunnu* every time. So those three forms are not the start of a conjugation. **They are the whole of it.**

That is the bargain. Nothing to memorise on the verb — and the pronoun in front can never be dropped, since it is now the only thing telling you who went.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pōkuka” — to go
- the three times — “pōkunnu ... pōyi ... pōkumì”
- the pair that shares one sound-law — “pattū ... hattu”, “pō ... hōgu”
- four people, one verb — “ñān, nī, avan, avar ... pōkunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I will go.” (*Ñān pōkumì*.) How many words are in this verb's whole Malayalam present tense? (**One** — *pōkunnu*, for every person.) Is Kannada's *hōgu* a different root from *pō*? (**No** — the same old *p* softened to *h*.) Next: the one place a Malayalam verb can still surprise you.

32.3 വരുക (varuka) — “to come,” and a past that reshapes the stem

Pōkuka took its endings without a fuss. Its lifelong partner does not — and the difference sits in exactly one of the three tenses.

What to know first

വരുക — *varuka* — to come

The stem is വരു- (*varu-*), and the command is shorter still: വാ! (*vā!*), “come!” (Chapter 4 met the dictionary form in its other common spelling, വരിക, *varika*; both name this verb.)

Go and come are inseparable here. The everyday goodbye പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) is the two verbs holding hands — “having gone, I’ll come” — and Malayalam has no plain farewell that leaves the coming back out.

The letters in this word

വ (*va*) + രു (*ru*) + ക (*ka*) → വരുക, three light beats. In the past form വന്നു (*vannu*) the ന is a doubled *n*, held long: *van-nu*, not *vanu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Native Dravidian, and every sister kept it — each reshaping the front of the word. **Tamil** has வா (*vā*) as the command and வரு- (*varu-*) as the stem; **Kannada** has ಬಾ (*bā*); **Telugu** has రా (*rā*).

V, b, r: three regular reworkings of one old word, not three verbs. And Malayalam’s *vā* / *varu-* pairing is Tamil’s exactly, down to the two shapes — which is what “closest sister” means in practice.

Grammar Lens: where Malayalam keeps its irregularity

Line the two verbs up:

tense	go	come
now	<i>pōkunnu</i>	<i>varunnu</i>
already	<i>pōyi</i>	<i>vannu</i>
not yet	<i>pōkuni</i>	<i>varuni</i>

Present and future are built the same way for both: stem, plus *-unnu* or *-uni*. The past is not — *varu-* collapses into *vann-*, and no rule would have told you so.

That is Malayalam’s whole irregularity budget, spent in one place. Once a verb’s **past** is learned, nothing else about it can catch you out, because the missing person slot means there is no second, third or plural form waiting behind it. A Malayalam verb costs you three forms. A Tamil one costs three tenses times six persons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “vā!”
- the three times — “varunnu ... vannu ... varuṁ”
- the pair, past against past — “pōyi ... vannu”
- the goodbye you now understand — “pōyi varāṁ”

Before you move on

Which tense of *varuka* is the irregular one? (**The past** — *vannu*.) Say “I will come.” (*Ñān varuṁ*.) Are Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* different verbs from *varuka*? (**No** — one old Dravidian word, reshaped three ways.) Next: a verb Malayalam kept where Tamil built a new one.

32.4 തിന്നുക (tinnuka) — “to eat,” and the ending that names a verb’s homeland

Malayalam took in a great deal of Sanskrit. Eating is one of the places it never reached.

What to know first

തിന്നുക — *tinnuka* — to eat

ഉണ്ണുക — *uṇṇuka* — to eat a meal, to dine

Two inherited verbs, both alive. *Tinnuka* is eating in general. *Uṇṇuka* is sitting down to a proper meal, and gives the noun ഉൺ (uṇṇ), “lunch.” The tenses are regular: *tinnunnu*, *tinnu*, *tinnuṁ*.

The letters in this word

തി (*ti*) + ന്നു (a doubled *nn* with *u*) + ക (*ka*) → തിന്നുക, with the long *n* you held in *vannu*. In ഉണ്ണുക that doubled letter is retroflex ണ്ണ (*ṇṇ*): *uṇ-ṇu-ka*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

തിന്നുക goes back to Dravidian *tin-*, and the family kept it: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*).

Tamil kept *tin* too, as தின், but narrowed it to chewing and built a **new** everyday word from two of its own: சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*) is *sāppu* (“food”) plus *iḍu* (“to put”). Put food. Tamil’s ordinary eat-verb is home-made; Malayalam’s is the family’s original.

Grammar Lens: -ഉക and -ഇക്കുക, two doors into the verb

Every verb so far has ended in -ഉക (*-uka*): *tinnuka*, *pōkuka*, *varuka*, *irikkuka*. Chapter 5’s “to speak” did not — it was സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*), with a longer -ഇക്കുക (*-ikkuka*). That difference is a passport stamp:

ending	what it marks
-ഉക <i>-uka</i>	an inherited Dravidian verb
-ഇക്കുക <i>-ikkuka</i>	a Sanskrit word made into a verb

Sanīsārīkkuka is built on Sanskrit *sanīsāra*; Chapter 9’s ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamīkkuka*, “to forgive”) on *kṣamā*. Malayalam needed one dependable way to make a verb of any borrowed noun, and -ഇക്കുക is it: a naturalisation ceremony you can hear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two eat-verbs — “tinnuka” (eat) and “uṇṇuka” (dine)
- the three times — “tinnunnu ... tinnu ... tinnunṇu”
- the cousins that kept the root — “tinu ... tinnu ... tinnuka”
- the two endings — “-uka is ours, -ikkuka came from Sanskrit”

Before you move on

Did Malayalam borrow its everyday word for eating? (**No** — Tamil is the one that built a new compound.) Which verb is for sitting down to a meal? (ഉണ്ണുക, *uṇṇuka*.) What does *-ikkuka* tell you? (**That the verb was made from a Sanskrit word.**) Next: a verb Malayalam kept where all three sisters walked away.

32.5 കാണുക (kāṇuka) — “to see,” and everything else the second slot can hold

Two slots, and the second one has only carried tense so far. It holds a good deal more — and you have used one of its other endings since Chapter 4.

What to know first

കാണുക — *kāṇuka* — to see, to meet

Present *kāṇunnu*, future *kāṇuni*, and a past that reshapes the way *vannu* did: കണ്ടു (*kaṇṭu*), “saw.”

You have said this verb in a goodbye. നാളെ കാണാം (*nāle kāṇāmi*) — “see you tomorrow” — is *nāle* (“tomorrow”) plus this stem with a different ending.

The letters in this word

കാ (*ka* with the long-*ā* sign) + ണു (retroflex *ṇu*) + ക (*ka*) → കാണുക. That ണ is the letter that ended *uṇṭū*: tongue curled back to the roof of the mouth.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kāṇ- is the family’s own see-root, inherited from Proto-Dravidian — and here the four sisters part company. **Tamil** says പറ (pār), keeping കാண் (*kāṇ*) for formal writing; **Kannada** says ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), keeping കാಣു (*kāṇu*) alongside; **Telugu** says చూడు (*cūḍu*). Malayalam simply kept the inherited word in daily use. Twice now — *tinnuka* and *kāṇuka* — the youngest of the four sisters turns out to be the conservative one.

Grammar Lens: tense is only one thing that ending can be

Hold *kāṇ-* still and change what follows it:

ending on <i>kāṇ-</i>	what it says
<i>kāṇunnu</i>	sees, is seeing
<i>kāṇumī</i>	will see
<i>kāṇāmī</i>	may see; let's see
<i>kāṇaṇamī</i>	must see
<i>kāṇarutū</i>	must not see

Time, permission, obligation, prohibition — all in the same single slot. This is where the person ending went: Malayalam gave that slot up and spent the room on **mood** instead.

And the payoff lands on every line. *Kāṇaṇamī* is “I must see,” “you must see” and “they must see” without changing a letter. In Tamil each of those five ideas must still pick a person ending before it can be said aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kāṇuka*” — to see — and the past, “*kaṇṭu*”
- the farewell you now understand — “*nāḷe kāṇāmī*”
- the ladder — “*kāṇunnu ... kāṇumī ... kāṇāmī ... kāṇaṇamī ... kāṇarutū*”
- one form, three people — “*ñān, nī, avar ... kāṇaṇamī*”

Before you move on

Which of the four sisters kept the inherited see-word for everyday use? (**Malayalam** — the other three each chose a different word.) Say “must see” and “must not see.” (*Kāṇaṇamī*; *kāṇarutū*.) What besides tense does that second slot carry? (**Mood** — permission, obligation, prohibition.) Next: the verb that moves the person out of the sentence altogether.

32.6 അറിയുക (*ariyuka*) — “to know,” the verb that takes no subject

Five verbs, and every one let you stand in front of it as *ñān*, “I.”
The last one will not — and Chapter 6 already handed you the sentence it makes.

What to know first

അറിയുക — *ariyuka* — to know

Present *ariyunnu*, past അറിഞ്ഞു (*arīññu*), and the form you have met: അറിയാം (*ariyāmi*), with the *-āmi* ending of the last lesson.

Native Dravidian, and the sisters kept the root — Tamil அறி (*ari*), Kannada ಅರಿ (*ari*) — though for everyday knowing each reached elsewhere: Tamil தெரியும் (*teriyum*), Telugu తెలుసు (*telusu*). Malayalam stayed with *ari-*.

The letters in this word

അ (the standing vowel *a*) + റി (*ri*) + യു (*yu*) + ക (*ka*) → അറിയുക. The റ is Malayalam’s hard, tapped *r*, a different letter and a different sound from the soft ര (*r*) of *varuka*.

Grammar Lens: the knower leaves the subject slot

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം. — *enikku malayāḷam ariyāmi* — “I know Malayalam.”

Chapter 6 gave you that sentence whole. Here is the verb inside it. You cannot say *ñān malayāḷam ariyāmi*: the one who knows is not the subject. That person moves into the **dative**, the “to me” case.

- *enikku ariyāmi* — it is known **to me**
- *ninakku ariyāmi* — it is known **to you**
- *avanŭ ariyāmi* — it is known **to him**

Malayalam treats knowing as something that **arrives at** you rather than something you **do**, and marks it with the pronoun’s case. That is the chapter’s closing symmetry. With the other five verbs the pronoun in front was the only thing telling you who acted, because the

verb carried no person. Here it has changed case, so the sentence has no subject at all. Malayalam took the person off the verb; this construction takes it out of the subject slot too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a_{ri}yuka” — to know — and the past, “a_{ri}ññu”
- “enikku malayāḷaṁ a_{ri}yāṁ” — I know Malayalam
- three knowers, one verb — “enikku ... ninakku ... avanū a_{ri}yāṁ”
- the chapter’s six — “uṇṭū, pōkunnu, varunnu, tinnunnu, kāṇunnu, a_{ri}yunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I know Malayalam,” and name the case the “I” wears. (*Enikku malayāḷaṁ a_{ri}yāṁ* — the **dative**.) Name the two slots of a Malayalam verb. (**Stem and tense**, with no third slot for person.) Which of the six verbs has an irregular past? (*Varuka* → *vannu*, and *kāṇuka* → *kaṇṭu*.) Which be-word says “I have”? (ഉണ്ടു, *uṇṭū*.) How many forms has the Malayalam present tense, for any verb at all? (**One**.)

Chapter 33

The Mind and the Page

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Malayalam, hear from a verb’s own ending which of the four Malayalam borrowed, and put the understander in the dative where Malayalam puts him.

Say ഞാൻ മലയാളം എഴുതുന്നു, run the chapter’s four verbs back and pick out the two wearing the Sanskrit -ഇക്കുക stamp, and say why Malayalam and Tamil write with one word while Kannada and Telugu, having lost its ഴ, reach for another.

33.1 ചിന്തിക്കുക (cintikkuka) — “to think,” on a suffix you have used since Chapter 9

Say *enikku malayāḷam ariyāmi*. Knowing **arrived** at you, so the “I” left the subject slot. Thinking you do — and you keep it.

What to know first

ചിന്തിക്കുക — *cintikkuka* — to think

ഞാൻ ചിന്തിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān cintikkunnu* — “I think.”

Past ചിന്തിച്ചു (*cinticcu*), future *cintikkumī*. And *cintikkunnu* is the whole present tense — *ñān*, *nī*, *avar*, one word for everybody.

The letters in this word

ചി (*ca* + the *i* sign) + ന്നി (the conjunct ന്ത *nta*, also with *i*) + ക്കു + ക.
That ക്ക is the held-long *kk* of *kṣamikkuka*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചിന്ത (*cinta*) is a **noun** first — “thought, care” — borrowed whole from Sanskrit चिन्ता (*cintā*), which carries the same double sense of thinking and worrying.

Native think-words live on beside it: ഓർക്കുക (*ōrkkuka*), narrowed to “remember”; നിനക്കുക (*ninekka*), now literary.

Grammar Lens: -ഇക്കുക, the suffix that naturalises a loan

Chapter 9 made ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamikkuka*, “to forgive”) from Sanskrit ക്ഷമ plus -ഇക്കുക; Chapter 32 made that ending a passport stamp — -ഉക on an inherited verb, -ഇക്കുക on a borrowing. *Cinta* + *-ikkuka* is the same machine.

That second slot still takes mood as readily as tense: *cintikkāṇi* (“let’s think”), ചിന്തിക്കണം (*cintikkaṇaṇi*, “must think”) on the very -ണം that made *kṣamikkaṇaṇi* polite, *cintikkarutū* (“must not think”).

Each sister has that suffix in her own shape — Kannada -ಇಸು, Telugu -ఇంసు — all inherited from one source. What differs is who used it here. **Tamil** kept native நினை (*niṇai*); **Telugu** and **Kannada** built theirs from a word meaning “to say,” *anukō*, “to say to oneself.” Only Malayalam borrowed — and the word it demoted, *ninekka*, is *niṇai* exactly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān cintikkunnu,” then the past, “cinticcu”
- noun, verb, and its cousin — “cinta ... cintikkuka ... kṣamikkuka”
- the mood ladder — “cintikkāṇi ... cintikkaṇaṇi ... cintikkarutū”
- three strategies — “niṇai” kept, “anukō” built, “cintikkuka” borrowed

- knowing, then thinking — “enikku malayāḷam aṛiyāṁ,” “*ñān cintikkunnu*”

Before you move on

Say “I think,” and name the noun inside it. (*Ñān cintikkunnu*; ചിന്ത, Sanskrit for **thought**.) What does -ഇക്കുക tell you, and which earlier verb wore it? (**Made from a borrowing**; *kṣamikkuka*.) Say “must think.” (*Cintikkaṇaṁ* — the -ണം of *kṣamikkaṇaṁ*, a mood in the tense slot.) Which sister kept a native think-word, and which built one from “say”? (**Tamil**, *ninai*; **Telugu**, *anukō*.) Why can *aṛiyuka* not take *ñān*? (**Knowing arrives at you**.)

33.2 മനസ്സിലാക്കുക (manassilākkuka) — “to understand,” or: to put it in the mind

Say *ñān cintikkunnu*, then *enikku*. One is what you do; the other is the “to me” of Chapter 6. This word needs both.

What to know first

മനസ്സിലാക്കുക — *manassilākkuka* — **to understand**

ഞാൻ മനസ്സിലാക്കുന്നു. — *ñān manassilākkunnu* — “I understand.”

Past മനസ്സിലാക്കി (*manassilākki*). It is long, but not one lump: you can hear the seams.

The letters in this word

മ (*ma*) + ന (*na*) + സ്സി (a doubled സ് *ssa* with the *i* sign) + ലാ (*la* + long *ā*) + ക്ക + ക. Hold that സ്സി long.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Three pieces, and you have met every one:

- മനസ്സ് (*manassū*) — “**mind**,” Sanskrit मनस् (*manas*)
- -ഇൽ (*-il*) — “**in**,” the ending of *vīṭṭil*, “at home”

- ആക്കുക (*ākkuka*) — “to make, to put”

Put in the mind. That is the whole word — transparent to any Malayalam speaker, which is why it never wore down.

Sanskrit *manas* is from the Indo-European root **men-*, “to think,” and so are English **mind** and **mental** and Latin *mēns* — by a different branch of it, so relatives rather than the same word. (*Mind*’s exact Sanskrit match is मति *mati*; *manas*’s is Greek *ménos*.)

Grammar Lens: two verbs, one root, and who does the work

ആക്കുക *makes* something so; its twin ആകുക (*ākuka*) means it *becomes* so. Swap them and the sentence changes hands:

എനിക്ക് മനസ്സിലായി. — *enikku manassilāyi* — “I understood.”

Literally: “to me — it became in the mind.” No *ñān*. The understander wears the dative -ഇക്ക്, as the knower does in *enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ*. Chapter 6 separated what you **do** from what **happens to** you; here one root does both, and the ending decides which. *Manassilāyi* is much the commoner in speech.

Neither form takes -ഇക്കുക: both sit on native *ākuka*, so no passport stamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three pieces — “manassū ... -il ... ākkuka”
- “ñān manassilākkunnu,” then the past, “manassilākki”
- the everyday one — “enikku manassilāyi”
- three understanders — “enikku ... ninakku ... avanū manassilāyi”
- the two datives together — “enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ,” “enikku manassilāyi”
- with and without a stamp — “cintikkuka ... manassilākkuka”

Before you move on

Name the three pieces of *manassilākkuka*. (**Mind, in, put.**) Which English words share its root? (**Mind, mental.**) Say “I understood” the way it is usually said, and name the case you wear. (*Enikku manassilāyi*; the **dative**, as in *enikku malayāḷam ariyāmi*.) Which of today’s two verbs carries **-ഇക്കുക**, and why? (*Cintikkuka* — its noun was borrowed.)

33.3 വായിക്കുക (vāyikkuka) — “to read,” and a mouth that turns out not to be there

Manassilākkuka came apart into three pieces you could name. The next word looks as obliging — and the piece you hear is not there.

What to know first

വായിക്കുക — *vāyikkuka* — to read

ഞാൻ മലയാളം വായിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu*
— “I read Malayalam.”

Past വായിച്ചു (*vāyiccu*). The noun beside it is വായന (*vāyana*), “reading.”

The letters in this word

വാ (*va* + long *ā*) + യി (*ya* + the *i* sign) + ക്കു + ക. Nothing new since *cintikkuka* — the same ക്കുക tail.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The obvious guess is വായ് (*vāy*), “mouth” — reading as mouthing the words. A good guess, and wrong.

Gundert marks the noun വായന a *tadbhava* of Sanskrit वच् (*vac*), “to speak,” and gives the Tamil verb as *vācikka*. Sanskrit वाचन (*vācana*) is “reading aloud.” Reading was named for the **voice**; the mouth-word only sounds like it.

The *c* did not soften in Malayalam. It softened on the road — a *tadbhava* is a word that came the long way, through the middle Indo-Aryan languages, which drop a single consonant between vowels. Malayalam also holds the same Sanskrit word borrowed **straight**, വാചകം (*vācakam*), so it sits here twice; *vāyana* is the travelled one, and the -ഇക്കുക stamp agrees.

Nor did the sisters agree which word to use. Tamil’s everyday படி (*paṭi*) is Sanskrit too, from *paṭh*-; Telugu has చదువు (*caduvu*). Only **Kannada** kept a native read-verb in ordinary use, ಓದು (*ōdu*) — which Malayalam also has, as ഓതുക (*ōtuka*), narrowed to reciting scripture.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu,” then the past, “vāyiccu”
- the false trail, then the true one — “vāy” ... “vac, vācana, vāyana”
- the same word twice — “vācakam” straight, “vāyana” travelled
- the four read-verbs — “vāyikkuka ... paṭi ... ōdu ... caduvu”
- read what you know — the planet-days, “tiṅkaḷ ... velli ... ñāyar” — and the year’s first month, “Chinṇam”
- when — “ñān rāville vāyikkunnu,” I read in the morning
- what you do, what arrives — “ñān vāyikkunnu,” “enikku manassilāyi”
- the three pieces of understanding — “manassū ... -il ... ākkuka”

Before you move on

Say “I read Malayalam.” (*Ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu.*) Is *vāy*, “mouth,” inside it? (**No** — the trail runs to Sanskrit *vac*, “speak,” and *vācana*, “reciting aloud”; the *c* softened **on the road**, and Malayalam keeps *vācakam* unsoftened beside it.) Do the sisters share a read-verb? (**No** — *paṭi*, *ōdu*, *caduvu*, and only *ōdu* is native.)

33.4 എഴുതുക (elutuka) — “to write,” and the one letter two sisters kept

Reading came from Sanskrit. Writing did not travel at all — and it kept a sound most of the family has lost.

What to know first

എഴുതുക — *elutuka* — to write

ഞാൻ മലയാളം എഴുതുന്നു. — *ñān malayāḷam elutunnu* —
“I write Malayalam.”

Past എഴുതി (*eluti*). Note the tail: plain -ഉക, no ഇ — no passport stamp, because nothing was borrowed.

The letters in this word

എ (the standing vowel *e*) + ഴ (ഴ *la* with *u*) + തു (*tu*) + ക (*ka*). The ഴ is the letter of *ēlu*, “seven” — curl the tongue back and let the air pass, neither quite an *l* nor quite an *r*. Standard Malayalam keeps it; northern dialects have let it go, as Kannada did.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam’s എഴുതുക and Tamil’s எழுது (*elutu*) are not cousins. They are the **same word** — and the Dravidian etymological dictionary finds it in only two other, much smaller languages. Beside “write, paint, draw” it records a stranger sense: “**become indented by pressure**.” A letter is a mark pressed into a leaf with the കൈ (*kai*), the hand. (You may see it linked to എഴു *elu*, “to rise”; the dictionary keeps them apart, so treat that as unproven.)

The ഴ is the sound inside the name തമിഴ് itself. Chapter 7 watched it harden going east: *ēlu*, *ēlu*, *ēdu*. Kannada and Telugu lost the letter — and with it this verb. They write with an unrelated root: ಬರೆ (*bare*), രాయ (*rāyu*), from an old word for a **drawn line**.

Malayalam has that root too — വരയ്ക്കുക (*varaykkuka*) — and gave it the other job: **to draw**. Two roots, two tasks, as with *uṇṭū* and *irikkuka*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān malayāḷam̐ elutunnu,” then “eluti”
- when — “ñān rāthri elutunnu,” I write at night
- the two sisters’ one word — “elutuka ... elutu”
- the sound hardening east — “ēlu ... ēḷu ... ēḍu”
- write, then draw — “elutuka ... varaykkuka”
- the chapter’s നാല് — “cintikkunnu, manassilākkunnu, vāyikkunnu, elutunnu”
- with Chapter 32’s six that makes പത്ത് — “uṇṭṭṭu, pōkunnu, varunnu, tinnunnu, kāṇunnu, aṛiyunnu”
- the two that carry the stamp — “cintikkuka, vāyikkuka”
- and the sentence with no subject — “enikku manassilāyi”

Before you move on

Say “I write Malayalam,” and how far Tamil’s word is from it. (*ñān malayāḷam̐ elutunnu*; **not at all**.) Which sound do the standard languages keep, and what did Kannada and Telugu do about writing? (ഴ; they lost it and took another root, *bare*, *rāyu*.) Run the chapter’s four, and say which two were borrowed. (*Cintikkunnu*, *manassilākkunnu*, *vāyikkunnu*, *elutunnu*; *cinta* and *vac*, wearing -ഇക്കുക.) Which refuses you as its subject? (*Enikku manassilāyi*.)

Chapter 34

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask, help and say what I like in Malayalam, tell a native geminate stem apart from the Sanskrit verb-maker that looks just like it, and say why എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് leaves no room for me as its subject.

Say എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് and hear that you are not its subject, set it beside എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം and എനിക്ക് മനസ്സിലായി so one frame carries three meanings, and run the chapter's four back by the past tenses that betray which of them were borrowed.

34.1 എടുക്കുക (eṭukkuka) — “to take,” and a rule that needed one correction

Vāyikkunnu was borrowed, *elutunnu* was not, and you could hear which was which. This one sounds borrowed and is not.

What to know first

എടുക്കുക — *eṭukkuka* — to take, to pick up

ഞാൻ വെള്ളം എടുക്കുന്നു. — *ñān vellam eṭukkunnu* — “I take water.”

Three times, as always: *eṭukkunnu*, എടുത്തു (*eṭuttu*), *eṭukkumi*.

The letters in this word

എ (the standing vowel *e*, as in *elutuka*) + ടു (retroflex *ṣ ṭa* with *u*) + കു + ക. Curl the tongue back for the *ṣ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Gundert glosses it “**to raise, lift, take up**,” and the lifting came first. Tamil எடு (*eṭu*) is the same word again — and the etymological dictionary gives this root no entry of its own, filing *eṭu* inside the family of എഴു (*eḷu*), “**to rise**.” Rise, then raise, then take. Kannada and Telugu say ఎత్తు / ఎత్త (ettu) for lifting; whether that is the same word the dictionaries argue over, so take the resemblance and leave the verdict.

It wants an object: *vellam eṭukkunnu*, water; *ari eṭukkunnu*, raw rice; *cōrū eṭukkunnu*, the cooked kind.

Grammar Lens: the stamp is the ഇ, not the ക

Chapter 32 gave you a rule: -ഉക on an inherited verb, -ഇക്കുക on a borrowing made into one. *Eṭukkuka* looks like a counter-example. It is not: the rule was always about one letter.

- *cintikkuka*, *vāyikkuka* — ഇ before the ക: borrowed
- *eṭukkuka*, *irikkuka* — no ഇ: native, doubling its own consonant

The ക belongs to the stem; the ഇ is the naturalisation ceremony. And the past tense settles every case: a borrowed verb ends -ഇച്ചു (*cinticcu*, *vāyiccu*), a native one does not (*eṭuttu*, *eḷuti*).

Beneath that, nothing has changed. *Ñān eṭukkunnu*, *nī eṭukkunnu*, *avar eṭukkunnu* — three forms are still the whole conjugation, native or borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān vellam eṭukkunnu,” then the past, “eṭuttu”
- three things to take — “vellam ... ari ... cōrū”
- rise, raise, take — “eḷu ... eṭu ... eṭukkuka”

- listen for the *i* — “cintikkuka, vāyikkuka” against “eṭukkuka, eḷutuka”
- and the pasts that prove it — “cinticcu, vāyiccu” against “eṭuttu, eḷuti”
- three people, one form — “ñān, nī, avar ... eṭukkunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I take water,” then the past. (*Ñān vellani eṭukkunnu; eṭuttu.*) What did the root mean before “take”? (**To rise**, then **to raise**.) Is *eṭukkuka* a borrowing, and how do you know? (**No** — no ഇ, no -ഇച്ചു past; *cintikkuka* and *vāyikkuka* have both.) How many present forms has it? (**One**.)

34.2 ചോദിക്കുക (cōdikkuka) — “to ask,” which began as pushing

Eṭuttu — a native past. Listen for what the next verb’s past does instead, and you will know where it came from before you are told.

What to know first

ചോദിക്കുക — *cōdikkuka* — to ask

ഞാൻ ചോദിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān cōdikkunnu* — “I ask.”

Past ചോദിച്ചു (*cōdiccu*) — there it is, the -ഇച്ചു of a borrowing. The noun beside it is ചോദ്യം (*cōdyam*), “a question.”

The letters in this word

ചോ (*ca* wearing the long-*ō* sign) + ദി (*ṛ da* with the *i* sign) + ക്കു (*kku*) + ക (*ka*). That *ṛ* is a voiced *d*, one of the sounds Sanskrit brought into the alphabet.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Gundert files it under the Sanskrit root ചുട് (*cud*), “**to incite, to urge**” — and his entry still lists the senses in the order they arrived: first to incite, then to demand, then to question. In Sanskrit philosophy चोद्य (codya) was an **objection pressed** at an opponent. Asking began as pushing.

Malayalam needed the word because of something it had done to its own. The family’s inherited ***kēḷ-** covered **hearing and asking together**, and Tamil’s கேள் (*kēḷ*) still does both. Malayalam kept കേൾക്കുക (*kēḷkkuka*) for **hearing only** — and the empty half is exactly where the loan settled.

Two questions from Chapter 18 and Chapter 19 you can now say you are asking: *ethra maṇi?*, “what hour?”, and *ninṇaḷkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?*, “how old are you?” Chapter 8’s ദയവായി in front softens either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān cōdikkunnu,” then the past, “cōdiccu”
- verb, then noun — “cōdikkuka ... cōdyaṁ”
- the three senses in order — “incite ... demand ... ask”
- ask the hour — “dayavāyi, ethra maṇi?”
- ask the age — “ninṇaḷkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?”
- hear, then ask — “kēḷkkuka ... cōdikkuka”
- the two pasts — “cōdiccu” borrowed, “eṭuttu” and “eḷuti” not

Before you move on

Say “I ask,” then the past, and say what the past tells you. (*Ñān cōdikkunnu*; *cōdiccu*; -ഇച്ഛ means **borrowed**.) What did the root mean first, and why did Malayalam need it? (**To incite, to urge** — and its own *kēḷkkuka* had narrowed to hearing, where Tamil’s *kēḷ* still asks.) Now ask someone’s age, politely. (*Dayavāyi, ninṇaḷkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?*)

34.3 സഹായിക്കുക (sahāyikkuka) — “to help,” or: to go along with

Cōdiccu told you it was borrowed. The next verb’s past says the same — and by now you can guess what happened to the Malayalam word it replaced.

What to know first

സഹായിക്കുക — *sahāyikkuka* — to help

ഞാൻ സഹായിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān sahāyikkunnu* — “I help.”

Past സഹായിച്ചു (*sahāyiccu*). The noun is സഹായം (*sahāyam*), “help,” and it came first — the verb was made from it.

The letters in this word

സ (*sa*) + ഹാ (ഹ *ha* + long *ā*) + യി (*ya* + the *i* sign) + ക്കു + ക. That ാ + യി pair is the one you spelled inside ദയവായി, letter for letter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Sanskrit सहाय (*sahāya*) first meant a **companion**. Monier-Williams reads it as सह (*saha*), “with,” plus a form of the root ३ (*i*), “to go” — one who **goes along with** you — and marks the reading *probable* rather than certain. That go-root is Indo-European ***h₁ey-**, the one inside Latin *īre* and Greek *eīmi*. Helping, named as walking beside. Tamil alone kept the family’s own word for everyday use: உதவி (*utavi*). Malayalam has the cognate — ഉതവി, with the verb ഉതക്കുക — but the daily work goes to the loan, as it does in Kannada, Telugu and Hindi.

That is the fourth time in two chapters: *ōtuka* gave up reading, *ōrkkuka* gave up thinking, *kēlkkuka* gave up asking, *utavi* gave up helping — and a Sanskrit word took each vacated slot. It is not random. It is the mark of the centuries when Kerala’s writers mixed the two languages on purpose.

The other direction exists too. ദയവായി is Sanskrit *daya*, and there **all four sisters borrowed together** — *tayavu seytu*, *dayavittu*, *dayacēsi*. For politeness nobody kept a native word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān sahāyikkunnu,” then the past, “sahāyiccu”
- noun, then verb — “sahāyaṁ ... sahāyikkuka”
- the pieces — “saha” with, “i” to go — one who goes along
- ask for it politely, on Chapter 8’s ending — “sahāyikkaṇaṁ”
- native, then loan — “utavi ... sahāyaṁ”
- the four that gave way — “ōtuka, ōrkkuka, kēlkkuka, utavi”
- and the four that borrowed together — “dayavāyi, tayavu seytu, dayaviṭṭu, dayacēsi”

Before you move on

Say “I help,” and say what *sahāya* meant first. (*Ñān sahāyikkunnu*; **a companion** — one who goes with you.) Which sister kept her own help-word for daily use? (**Tamil**, *utavi* — Malayalam has *utavi* but rarely reaches for it.) Say “please help.” (*Sahāyikkaṇaṁ*, on the -**ണം** that carries everyday politeness.) And which word did all four sisters borrow together? (**ദയ** *daya*.)

34.4 എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് — “I like Malayalam,” and you are not its subject

Ñān sahāyikkunnu, ñān eṭukkunnu — you have stood in front of every verb so far. Not this one.

What to know first

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ്. *enikku malayāḷaṁ iṣṭamāṇṁ*
— “to me — Malayalam — is a liking.”

ഇഷ്ടം is a **noun**; **-ആണ്** is Chapter 2’s copula. Only the front moves: *enikku, ninakku, avanū*.

The letters in this word

ഇ (the standing vowel *i*) + ഞ്ശ (ഞ *ṣa* over *ś* *ṭa*, both retroflex) + ൾ, the anusvāram of *malayāḷam*.

Grammar Lens: three sentences on one frame

Enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ — I **know** it. *Enikku manassilāyi* — I **understood**. *Enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇũ* — I **like** it. One frame, three meanings; Chapter 6 promised the third before you had words for it. Swap the thing and it holds: *enikku maḷa iṣṭamāṇũ*, “I like rain.” Here the dative is not a preference. *Ñān malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇũ* is **ungrammatical**.

Two ways round it, one native. ഇഷ്ടപ്പെടുക (*iṣṭappetuka*) is this noun made a verb, and takes either shape. പിടിക്കുക (*piṭikkuka*), “to catch,” is Malayalam’s own: Gundert records എനിക്കു പിടിച്ചില്ല, “it did not please me.” Malayalam never needed *iṣṭam*; it took it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇഷ്ടം is Sanskrit इष्ट, the participle of इष् (iṣ), “to desire,” from the Indo-European root **h₂eys-*, which also produced English **ask**. The chapter’s two Sanskrit words crossed over: *cōḍikkuka*, which **means** ask, came from a root meaning **drive**; *iṣṭam*, which means **like**, came from **ask**’s root.

The shape turns up far from Kerala. Spanish says **me gusta**, “to me it pleases”; Italian **mi piace**; Tamil **enakkut tamil piḍikkum**. None borrowed it from another — Tamil is not even in their family — yet all three put the liker where Malayalam does. Chapter 6’s row is the near end: **-ikku, -ukku, -ku, -ge**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇũ*” — to me, Malayalam, is a liking
- three likers, then a new thing — “*enikku ... ninakku ... avanũ*,” then “*enikku maḷa iṣṭamāṇũ*”
- the three datives — “*ariyāṁ, manassilāyi, iṣṭamāṇũ*”
- the two ways round — “*ñān iṣṭappetunnu*,” “*enikku piṭiccu*”

- the chapter’s **മാലി** — “eṭukkunnu, cōdikkunnu, sahāyikkunnu, iṣṭamāñũ”
- the borrowings, by their pasts — “cōdiccu, sahāyiccu,” not “eṭuttu”
- the same shape far away — “me gusta ... mi piace ... piḍikkum” — on “-ikku · -ukku · -ku · -ge”

Before you move on

Say “I like Malayalam,” and how many verbs it holds. (*Enikku malayāḷaṁ iṣṭamāñũ*; **one**, the copula.) Can you be its subject? (**No** — not unusual, **impossible**.) Name the three dative sentences and Malayalam’s own way of liking. (*Ariyāṁ, manassilāyi, iṣṭamāñũ*; പിടിക്കുക.) Which English word shares *iṣṭam*’s root, and is it *cōdikkuka*’s? (**Ask; no** — that came from **drive**.)

Chapter 35

Family and Friend

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ⇐ eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my family as a group and name a friend in Malayalam, and say which of the two words is a Sanskrit loan and which of Malayalam’s two friend-words leans on a borrowed ending even though its root is native.

Say ithu ente kudumbamaanu and ithu ente suhruthaanu, take suhruthu apart into su plus hrid, and name the six Chapter 12 people-words next to the one group-word none of them supplied.

35.1 കുടുംബം (kuṭumbam) — “family,” the word the six people-words never needed

Enikku malayāḷaṇi iṣṭamāṇṁ closed the last chapter on a sentence built from nothing but nouns and a dative. This chapter opens on the plainest nouns of all: the people you would actually say it to.

What to know first

കുടുംബം — *kuṭumbam* — family

ഇത് എന്റെ കുടുംബമാണ്. — *ithu ente kuṭumbamāṇṁ*. —
“This is my family.”

Ente, “my,” has been yours since your very first sentences; -ആണ് is the same copula that closed *enikku malayāḷaṇi iṣṭamāṇṁ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കുടുംബം is Sanskrit तत्सम कुटुम्ब (kuṭumba), “family, household,” absorbed with the same nativizing -അം ending you already met on ഇഷ്ടം and സുഖം — a genuine Malayalam habit: dress a bare Sanskrit neuter stem in Malayalam’s own **-am̐**. Kannada borrows the identical word **bare**, ಕುಟುಂಬ (kuṭumba), no ending added — one more place Malayalam leans harder into Sanskrit than its sisters do, this time in the shape of the loan rather than the fact of it.

You already have six words for six specific people: അച്ഛൻ, അമ്മ, and the four age-graded siblings ചേട്ടൻ/അനിയൻ, ചെച്ചി/അനിയത്തി.

Every one is native Dravidian, and not one of them means “family” — each names a single, specific person.

Malayalam never inherited a word for the group itself, so when it needed one, it reached for Sanskrit. The people came first, and stayed native; the collective came later, and came borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente kuṭumbamāṇṁ” — this is my family
- the six named people, then the borrowed group word — “acchan, amma, cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, aniyatti ... kuṭumbam̐”
- bare against dressed — “kuṭumba” (Kannada), “kuṭumbam̐” (Malayalam)

Before you move on

Say “this is my family.” (*Ithu ente kuṭumbamāṇṁ*.) Is *kuṭumbam̐* native Dravidian or a loan? (**A Sanskrit loan**, like *iṣṭam̐* and *sukham̐* — and dressed in the same **-am̐**.) Name the six family words you already know. (*Acchan, amma, cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, aniyatti*.) Which of those six means “family” as a group? (**None of them** — that’s exactly the gap *kuṭumbam̐* fills.)

35.2 സുഹൃത്ത് (suhṛttü) — “friend,” a word built out of “good” plus “heart”

Kuṭumbani named the group you’re born into. This word names the one you choose.

What to know first

സുഹൃത്ത് — *suhṛttü* — friend

ഇത് എന്റെ സുഹൃത്താണ്. — *ithu ente suhṛttāṇũ*. — “This is my friend.”

The everyday spoken alternative is കൂട്ടുകാരൻ (*kūṭṭukāran*, male) / കൂട്ടുകാരി (*kūṭṭukāri*, female).

The letters in this word

ഹൃ is ഹ (*ha*) carrying the ള് sign — the short vocalic *r* inherited straight from Sanskrit, the same vowel that opened വൃശ്ചികം several chapters back. Malayalam is the only one of the four literary Dravidian scripts that still writes it as a distinct vowel sign rather than respelling it away.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഹൃത്ത് is Sanskrit सुहृद् (*suhṛd*), literally “good-heart”: सु (*su*) “good” plus हृद् (*hṛd*) “heart” — the very root a later chapter in this same stretch meets again as ഹൃദയം, “heart” itself. Friendship, in Malayalam’s borrowed word for it, is a matter of the heart before it is a matter of anything else.

Everyday speech reaches just as often for കൂട്ടുകാരൻ/കൂട്ടുകാരി — native കൂട്ട് (*kūṭṭü*, “joining, group,” the same root as the verb കൂടുക, “to join, unite”) plus the agentive -കാരൻ/-കാരി. That suffix is itself borrowed, from Sanskrit कार (*kāra*, “maker, doer”) fused onto a Dravidian personal ending — so even Malayalam’s more casual, native-rooted word for “friend” leans on a Sanskrit-derived ending to finish the job. Selective borrowing, as *santōṣam* already showed back near the start of this book, does not always mean choosing one word wholesale over another; sometimes it means splicing a Dravidian root and a Sanskrit ending into a single new word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente suhṛttāṇũ” — this is my friend
- the casual alternative — “kūṭṭukāran, kūṭṭukāri”
- the two pieces — “su,” good, plus “hṛd,” heart
- family and friend, one chapter — “kuṭumbam ... suhṛttũ”

Before you move on

Say “this is my friend.” (*Ithu ente suhṛttāṇũ*.) What does *suhṛttũ* literally mean, piece by piece? (“**Good**” *su* + “**heart**” *hṛd*.) Name the everyday spoken alternative, and what its ending is borrowed from. (*Kūṭṭukāran/kūṭṭukāri* — the -കാരൻ/-കാരി ending is from **Sanskrit kāra**, “maker.”)

Chapter 36

Child, Son, Daughter

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say child, son and daughter in Malayalam, and say which of the three matches Tamil most closely and which one Kannada softened.

Say ithu ente makalaanu, set makan/makal beside Tamil's identical makan/makal and Kannada's softened maga/magalu, and ask ninte makanu ethra vayassundu using Chapter 19's dative-subject question again.

36.1 കുട്ടി (kuṭṭi) — “child, kid,” the general word before the specific ones

Suhṛttū named someone you choose. This chapter turns to someone you don't — the people a family is built around.

What to know first

കുട്ടി — *kuṭṭi* — child, kid

ഇത് എന്റെ കുട്ടിയാണ്. — *ithu ente kuṭṭiyāṇū.* — “This is my child.”

കുട്ടി is the general word — any child, before you say whose son or daughter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കുട്ടി is native Dravidian, matching Tamil’s குட்டி (*kuṭṭi*) closely. Both languages let the same word cover two things: a human child, and the young of an animal — a പൂച്ചക്കുട്ടി (*pūccakkuṭṭi*) is a kitten, built on പൂച്ച, “cat,” met earlier in this book, the same way **kuṭṭi** attaches to any animal name for its young. English does something similar with “kid,” which covers both a child and a baby goat — one small word, carrying the same double duty in two unrelated language families.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente kuṭṭiyāṇṭ” — this is my child
- the animal sense — “pūcca ... pūccakkuṭṭi” — cat, kitten
- the family and the friend, once more — “kuṭumbam ... suhṛttū”
- the six family people-words, and the group word — “acchan, amma ... kuṭumbam”

Before you move on

Say “this is my child.” (*Ithu ente kuṭṭiyāṇṭ*.) What two things can *kuṭṭi* mean? (**A human child**, or **the young of an animal** — like *pūccakkuṭṭi*, kitten.) Which English word carries the very same double duty? (**Kid**.) Name the six family people-words once more, and the group word none of them supplied. (*Acchan, amma, cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, aniyatti* — and **kuṭumbam**.)

36.2 മക്കൾ (makan) — “son,” a word Tamil hardly changed at all

Kuṭṭi was the general word. Now the two specific ones — starting with the son.

What to know first

മകൻ — *makan* — son

ഇത് എന്റെ മകനാണ്. — *ithu ente makanāṇṭu*. — “This is my son.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മകൻ continues **Proto-Dravidian *makan**, “son.” Tamil keeps almost the identical shape, **மகன்** (*makan*) — same consonants, same vowels, same final *-n*. Kannada moved further: the *-k-* between vowels softened to *-g-*, and the final *-n* dropped, giving **ಮಗ** (*maga*). So on this word it is Malayalam and Tamil that hold the older, more conservative shape, and Kannada that innovated — the same closeness the very first greetings already showed in *nandi*, *athe*, *illa* and *śari*, this time in a family word rather than a greeting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente makanāṇṭu” — this is my son
- the two cousins — “makan” (Malayalam, Tamil) ... “maga” (Kannada)
- general then specific — “kuṭṭi ... makan”
- the friend-word, once more — “suhṛttū” — su plus hṛd

Before you move on

Say “this is my son.” (*Ithu ente makanāṇṭu*.) Which sister keeps almost the identical word? (**Tamil** — *makan*.) What did Kannada change? (**Softened *-k-* to *-g-*** and **dropped the final *-n***, giving *maga*.) What does *suhṛttū* literally mean? (**“Good-heart”** — *su* plus *hṛd*.)

36.3 മകൾ (makal) — “daughter,” the closest match yet

Makan matched Tamil closely. Its pair matches even closer — and gives you a reason to ask an old question again.

What to know first

മകൾ — *makal* — daughter

ഇത് എന്റെ മകളാണ്. — *ithu ente makalāṇṁ*. — “This is my daughter.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മകൾ continues **Proto-Dravidian *makal**, “daughter.” Tamil’s **மகள்** (*makal*) is not just close — it is **identical**, sound for sound. Kannada shows the same softening you just met in *maga*: **ಮಗಳು** (*magalu*), *-k-* to *-g-*, plus a closing *-u*. So where *makan/makan* was already a close match, *makal/makal* is the closer one still — two sisters holding one Proto-Dravidian root letter for letter, four thousand years and a script apart.

Now that you have a son and a daughter, the age question comes back with someone new to ask it about: **ninre makanṁ ethra vayassuṇṭṭu?** — “how old is your son?” — the same dative-subject-plus-*uṇṭṭu* shape, unchanged.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente makalāṇṁ” — this is my daughter
- the identical pair — “makal, makal” — Malayalam, Tamil
- son, daughter, both cousins — “makan ... maga; makal ... magalu”
- the age question, asked again — “ninre makanṁ ethra vayassuṇṭṭu?”
- general, then specific, twice over — “kuṭṭi ... makan ... makal”

Before you move on

Say “this is my daughter.” (*Ithu ente makalāṇṭṭu.*) How closely does Tamil match this word, compared with *makān*? (**Even closer** — *makal* is **identical** sound for sound, where *makān* only nearly matched.) Ask “how old is your son?” using the age question’s shape. (*Ninre makāṇṭṭu ethra vayassuṇṭṭu?* — “to your son, how much age exists?”) What is the general word for a child, before *makān* or *makal*? (குட்டி, *kuṭṭi*.)

Chapter 37

Face Words

Modes: ⇐ voice (3) 👁 eyes (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my eye, ear, nose and mouth in Malayalam, and say which of the four the family agrees on almost completely and which one Kannada alone breaks from.

Name kannu, chevi, mookku and vaay, run the near-total four-way match on eye against chevi’s three-against-one split on ear, and recall that Chapter 33 already named vaay once only to rule it out of vaayikkuka.

37.1 കണ്ണ് (kaṇṇũ) — “eye,” the same word four times over

തല, കൈ — head and hand, taught long ago, and nothing more of the body since, twenty-four chapters ago. This chapter adds four words to that short list, starting above the nose.

What to know first

കണ്ണ് — kaṇṇũ — eye

എന്റെ കണ്ണ്. — ente kaṇṇũ. — “My eye.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കണ്ണ് continues **Proto-Dravidian *kaṇ**, “eye.” Tamil கண் (kaṇ) sits right beside it; Telugu కన్ను (kannu) and Kannada ಕಣ್ಣು (kaṇṇu) sit

closer still, both almost identical to Malayalam’s own form. Four languages that otherwise pull apart on nearly everything — tense marking, half their everyday vocabulary, even the shape of their scripts — agree almost completely on this one word. It joins തല and കൈ, met earlier, as the third body word, and the first to show this exact, near-total four-way match.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente kaṇṇũ” — my eye
- the four sisters, nearly one word — “kaṇṇũ ... kaṇ ... kannu ... kaṇṇu”
- three body words now — “thala, kai, kaṇṇũ”
- family, then body — “makan, makaḷ ... kaṇṇũ”

Before you move on

Say “my eye.” (*Ente kaṇṇũ.*) Which three sisters come closest to matching Malayalam’s word? (**All three** — Tamil *kaṇ*, Telugu and Kannada both *ka(ṇ)ṇu* — a near-total four-way match.) Name the body words you have now. (*Thala*, head; *kai*, hand; *kaṇṇũ*, eye.) Name the previous chapter’s son and daughter words. (*Makan*, *makaḷ*.)

37.2 ചെവി (cevi) — “ear,” where Kannada is the odd one out

The four-way match on *kaṇṇũ* was close to perfect. This word breaks the pattern — but not the way you’d expect.

What to know first

ചെവി — *cevi* — ear

എന്റെ ചെവി. — *ente cevi.* — “My ear.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചെവി continues **Proto-Dravidian** *kewi, “ear.” Tamil செவி (*cevi*) and Telugu చెవి (*cevi*) match Malayalam almost exactly — all three softened the old initial *k-* into a *c-/ch-* sound before this particular front vowel. **Kannada alone kept the older sound:** ಕಿವಿ (*kivi*), *k-* untouched. So this time it is not Malayalam standing apart from three sisters, the way *kuṭumbam*’s dressed *-am* did — it is Kannada, holding onto the sound the other three let go of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente *cevi*” — my ear
- three softened, one not — “cevi, cevi, cevi ... kivi”
- two face words now — “kaṇṇū, *cevi*”
- the closest family match — “makal, makal” — Malayalam, Tamil

Before you move on

Say “my ear.” (*Ente cevi.*) Which three sisters agree on this word, and which one differs? (**Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu** agree — **Kannada** alone keeps the older *k-* sound, *kivi*.) Why is that the reverse of what you might expect? (Usually Malayalam is the one that goes its own way; here Malayalam sides with the majority and **Kannada** is the outlier.) Which earlier word was identical between Malayalam and Tamil, sound for sound? (മകൾ, *makal*, daughter.)

37.3 മുക്ക് (mūkkū) — “nose,” and the same softening you met on “son”

Two face words down. This one brings back a sound-change from the last chapter, in a new place.

What to know first

മുക്ക് — *mūkkū* — nose

എന്റെ മുക്ക്. — *ente mūkkū*. — “My nose.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മുക്ക് is native Dravidian, close to Tamil முக்கு (*mūkkū*) and Telugu ముక్కు (*mukku*). Kannada shows ಮೂಗು (*mūgu*) — the very same *-k-* to *-g-* softening you already met between Malayalam’s മകൻ and Kannada’s ಮಗ. It is a small, recurring signature: wherever Malayalam and Tamil hold a *-k-* between vowels, Kannada is likely to have worn it down to a *-g-*, whether the word is a family word or a body word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente mūkkū” — my nose
- the recurring softening — “makan, maga ... mūkkū, mūgu”
- three face words — “kaṇṇū, cevi, mūkkū”
- three against one, once more — “cevi, cevi, cevi ... kivi”

Before you move on

Say “my nose.” (*Ente mūkkū*.) What does Kannada’s ಮೂಗು (*mūgu*) show, that you already saw once before? (**The same *-k-* to *-g-* softening** as *makan* → *maga*.) Name the three face words so far. (*Kaṇṇū*, eye; *cevi*, ear; *mūkkū*, nose.) Which sister alone breaks the family’s agreement on *cevi*? (**Kannada**, *kivi*.)

37.4 വായ് (*vāy*) — “mouth,” the word an earlier lesson named only to rule out

Ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu, “I read Malayalam” — and an earlier lesson told you the obvious-looking mouth-word inside it wasn’t really there. Here, at last, is the real one.

What to know first

വായ് — *vāy* — **mouth**

എന്റെ വായ്. — *ente vāy.* — “My mouth.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

വായ് is native Dravidian, matching Tamil **வாய்** (*vāy*) almost exactly. Kannada shows the family’s own **v-to-b** shift here, **ಬಾಯಿ** (*bāyi*) — the same shift, in reverse direction from the *k-to-c* softening *chevi* showed you, that turns up across the family’s native vocabulary. Telugu’s everyday word, **నోరు** (*nōru*), is a different root altogether.

An earlier lesson already put **വായ്** on the table once — as the wrong answer. **വായിക്കുക** (*vāyikkuka*, “to read”) looks built on this very word, and Gundert’s dictionary says it isn’t: the trail runs instead to Sanskrit **वच्** (*vac*), “to speak.” That lesson named *vāy* only to set it aside. This is the word itself, finally taught for what it actually means.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente vāy” — my mouth
- the cousins — “vāy ... bāyi ... nōru” — Malayalam/Tamil, Kannada, Telugu
- the false trail, named again — “vāyikkuka” is NOT built on “vāy”
- all four face words — “kaṇṇũ, cevi, mūkkũ, vāy”

Before you move on

Say “my mouth.” (*Ente vāy.*) Which earlier lesson already mentioned *vāy*, and why? (**The *vāyikkuka* lesson**, to rule out that *vāyikkuka*, “to read,” is built on it.) What does Kannada’s *bāyi* show? (**The family’s v-to-b shift.**) Name all four face words. (*Kaṇṇũ*, eye; *cevi*, ear; *mūkkũ*, nose; *vāy*, mouth.)

Chapter 38

The Two Hearts

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my heart in Malayalam two ways, one Sanskrit and one native, and say which one everyday idiom actually uses and why hridayam is a genuine cousin of the English word heart.

Name hridayam and nenchu, place nenchidippu beside the santosham/nandi pattern from Chapter 2, and trace hridayam’s root to the same PIE ancestor as English heart.

38.1 ഹൃദയം (hṛdayam) — “heart,” a cousin of the English word

Suhṛttŭ, “friend,” was built on **hṛd**, “heart” — a piece promised, not yet taught. Here it is, whole.

What to know first

ഹൃദയം — *hṛdayam* — heart

എന്റെ ഹൃദയം. — *ente hṛdayam*. — “My heart.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഹൃദയം is Sanskrit हृदय (*hṛdaya*), “heart,” absorbed with the same nativizing -അം you already met on കൂടുംബം and ഇഷ്ടം. Its root, हृद् (*hṛd*), is not just Indo-Aryan but Indo-European: the same ancient

root that gave Greek **kardía**, Latin **cor/cordis**, and — by a long chain of regular sound changes inside Germanic — English **heart** itself. *Hṛdayam* and “heart” are genuine cousins, distant but real, through Sanskrit’s own branch of the family tree English belongs to. That resemblance is a coincidence of deep history, not of Malayalam’s own Dravidian family — Dravidian and Indo-European share no common ancestor at all. *Suhrttū*, “friend,” is this very root wearing “good” in front of it — **su** + **hṛd**, good-heart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente hṛdayam” — my heart
- the distant cousins — “hṛdaya ... kardía ... cor ... heart”
- the friend-word, taken apart again — “su + hṛd”
- mouth, then heart — “vāy ... hṛdayam”
- all the face words once more — “kaṇṇū, cevi, mūkkū, vāy”

Before you move on

Say “my heart.” (*Ente hṛdayam*.) Is *hṛdayam* a Dravidian word or a Sanskrit one? (**Sanskrit**, dressed in Malayalam’s own *-am*.) Name an English word that is a genuine, if distant, cousin of *hṛd*. (**Heart** — both from the same PIE root, by way of Greek *kardía* and Latin *cor*.) Which earlier word was built on this same root? (സുഹൃത്ത് — *su* “good” + *hṛd* “heart.”)

38.2 നെഞ്ച് (nenchŭ) — “chest,” Malayalam’s other heart

ഹൃദയം was borrowed, formal, and shared with English by deep ancestry. This chapter’s second word is none of those three things.

What to know first

നെഞ്ച് — *nenchŭ* — chest

എന്റെ നെഞ്ച്. — *ente nenchŭ*. — “My chest.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നെഞ്ച് is native Dravidian, cognate with Tamil’s own **நெஞ்சு/நெஞ்சம்** (*nenju/nenjam*), “chest.” Where **ഹൃദയം** names the organ and carries the Sanskrit-flavoured abstraction — a “heartfelt” thank-you, a broken heart in the literary sense — നെഞ്ച് is the word everyday idiom actually reaches for: **നെഞ്ചിടിപ്പ്** (*nenchitippŭ*), a heart pounding from fear or excitement, literally “chest-beat.”

Two hearts, then: one Sanskrit and formal, one native and physical. That is the same selective-borrowing pattern **സന്തോഷം** beside **നന്ദി** already showed, back near the start of this book — Malayalam does not simply prefer Sanskrit or prefer native; it keeps both, and lets register decide which one a given sentence reaches for. **തല** and **കൈ**, this stretch’s first two body words, were native throughout; **ഹൃദയം** and **നെഞ്ച്** show the same body carrying one word of each kind, side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente nenchŭ” — my chest
- two hearts — “hṛdayam,” formal; “nenchŭ,” everyday
- the idiom — “nenchitippŭ” — chest-beat, a pounding heart
- thala, kai, hṛdayam, nenchŭ — the body words so far
- mouth, once more — “vāy”

Before you move on

Say “my chest.” (*Ente nenchŭ*.) Which of this chapter’s two heart-words is native, and which is borrowed? (നെഞ്ച് native;

ഹൃദയം Sanskrit.) What does *nENCHİṭİppŭ* mean, literally?
 (“**Chest-beat**” — a pounding heart.) Which earlier pair showed
 this same native-plus-Sanskrit side-by-side pattern? (സന്തോഷം
beside നന്ദി, back near the start of this book.)

Chapter 39

Tea, Coffee, Milk

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can politely ask for tea, coffee or milk in Malayalam, and trace each word back along the road it travelled to get here.

Ask dayavaayi oru paal, run chaaya's overland Persian route against kaapi's maritime Arabic-Turkish-Italian-English one, and set paal's perfect three-way match against Chapter 15's vellam, which broke from Tamil entirely.

39.1 ചായ (chāya) — “tea,” which walked to Kerala rather than sailed

Two hearts done. Now the drink you would politely ask for first, in any Kerala home — and a chance to put the polite ദയവായി back to work.

What to know first

ചായ — *chāya* — tea

ദയവായി ഒരു ചായ. — *dayavāyi oru chāya*. — “A tea, please.”

Dayavāyi has been yours since early in this book; *oru*, “a/one,” you have already met attached to *nāl* and *maṇi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചായ traces to Northern Chinese **chá**, carried overland along Central Asian trade routes into Persian چای (*chāy*), and from there into Hindi-Urdu *chāy* and Malayalam *chāya* alike — the same land route most of North and South India took for their word for tea. Tea that instead reached Europe by **sea** kept a different, southern Chinese form, which is why English says **tea** and French says *thé* — one leaf, two roads: chai by land, tea by sea.

Grammar Lens: the two hearts, and the spine node so far

ദയവായി ഒരു ചായ leans on the very dative already named, **-ikku/-inu** — the same suffix beside Tamil’s *-ukku*, Telugu’s *-ku*, and Kannada’s *-ge*. This chapter carries both halves of the spine node ദയവായി and ഹൃദയം/നെഞ്ച് already opened: asking politely, and — if you ask for the wrong thing — repairing with ക്ഷമിക്കണം.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayavāyi oru chāya” — a tea, please
- the road — “chá ... chāy ... chāya”
- land against sea — “chai ... tea”
- please, once more, and its plainer everyday form — “dayavāyi ... irikkū”
- two hearts, once more — “hṛdayam ... nenchū”

Before you move on

Ask for tea, politely. (*Dayavāyi oru chāya*.) Name the three languages *chāya* passed through, in order. (**Chinese**, then **Persian**, then **Hindi-Urdu**, into Malayalam.) Why does English say “tea” instead of “chai”? (**It arrived by sea**, carrying a different Chinese form.) Which dative suffix does *dayavāyi ... enikku* share with Tamil, Telugu and Kannada? (**The dative** — *-ikku/-ukku/-ku/-ge*.) What is the repair half of this spine node’s word pair?

(ക്ഷമിക്കണം, sorry.)

39.2 കാപ്പി (kāppi) — “coffee,” which sailed while tea walked

Chāya travelled overland. This drink took the opposite road — and arrives from further away.

What to know first

കാപ്പി — *kāppi* — coffee

ദയവായി ഒരു കാപ്പി. — *dayavāyi oru kāppi*. — “A coffee, please.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കാപ്പി comes from **English** *coffee*, borrowed during the colonial period and reshaped to Malayalam’s own consonants and vowels. English’s own word for the drink is itself a loan, several times over: Arabic قهوة (*qahwah*) became Turkish **kahve**, then Italian **caffè**, then English *coffee*, before finally landing in Kerala as **kāppi**.

Set the two drinks side by side: ചായ walked overland from China, through Persia, into North and South Indian speech alike. കാപ്പി sailed from Arabia, through Ottoman Turkey and Renaissance Italy, into English, and only then into Malayalam. Two drinks, two opposite roads — one over land, one over sea — meeting on the very same tea-shop counter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayavāyi oru kāppi” — a coffee, please
- the long road — “qahwah ... kahve ... caffè ... coffee ... kāppi”
- two drinks, two roads — “chāya,” overland; “kāppi,” by sea
- two hearts, still — “hṛdayam ... nenchū”

Before you move on

Ask for coffee, politely. (*Dayavāyi oru kāppi.*) Which language did Malayalam borrow *kāppi* directly from? (**English.**) Name the four languages the word passed through before that. (**Arabic, Turkish, Italian, English.**) Which of this chapter’s two drinks travelled by land, and which by sea? (*Chāya* by **land**; *kāppi* by **sea**.)

39.3 പാൽ (pāl) — “milk,” where Tamil agrees completely

വെള്ളം, the earlier water-word, broke away from Tamil’s water-word entirely. This drink, the third in the chapter, does the opposite.

What to know first

പാൽ — *pāl* — milk

ദയവായി ഒരു പാൽ. — *dayavāyi oru pāl.* — “A milk, please.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പാൽ is native Dravidian, from **Proto-South-Dravidian** **pāl*, “milk.” Tamil keeps the shape **unchanged**: பால் (*pāl*), letter for letter the same as Malayalam. Kannada shows its own regular **p-to-h** sound law here too, giving ಹಾಲು (*hālu*) — the identical shift that turns Malayalam’s *pōkuka* into Kannada’s *hōgu*.

Set beside the water-word’s finding, this is the mirror image: വെള്ളം (water) broke from Tamil’s *nīr* entirely, choosing a completely different root; പാൽ (milk) shows the opposite — perfect three-way agreement in shape, with only Kannada’s regular sound law setting its form apart. Two everyday liquids, two entirely different outcomes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayavāyi oru pāl” — a milk, please

- unchanged, then shifted — “pāl ... pāl ... hālu” — Malayalam, Tamil, Kannada
- water against milk — “veḷḷam broke away; pāl agrees”
- three drinks, once more — “chāya, kāppi, pāl”
- the long road, once more — “qahwah ... kahve ... caffè ... kāppi”

Before you move on

Ask for milk, politely. (*Dayavāyi oru pāl.*) Does Tamil’s word for milk match Malayalam’s? (**Yes — exactly**, *pāl* both.) What does Kannada’s *hālu* show? (**The regular p-to-h law.**) Which earlier liquid word broke from Tamil entirely, unlike this one? (ಎಣ್ಣೆ, water.)

Chapter 40

The Meal

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I am having a meal in Malayalam, using a second eat-verb this book never taught until now, and close the polite-request-and-repair stretch that dayavaayi opened eight chapters ago.

Say njaan oon unnunnu against Chapter 32's tinnunnu, say enikku oon ishtamaanu on Chapter 6's dative and Chapter 34's frame, and name kshamikkanam as the repair half of the spine node dayavaayi's asking half opened.

40.1 ഉൺ (ūṇ) — “a meal,” the word that closes this stretch’s table

An earlier chapter taught തിന്നുക, “to eat,” for anything at all. It never taught the word for a proper, sit-down meal. Here it is.

What to know first

ഉൺ — *ūṇ* — a meal

ഞാൻ ഉൺ ഉണ്ണുന്നു. — *ñān ūṇ unṇunnu.* — “I am having a meal.”

The letters in this word

ഊ is the **independent** long-*ū* vowel — the shape a word uses when it *opens* with this sound and there is no consonant in front of it to carry the small sign ു instead. It is the same kind of independent vowel letter as the very first inherent-*a* opening; the sound only changes shape depending on what, if anything, comes before it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഊൺ is native Dravidian, sharing its root with the verb ഉണ്ണുക (*uṇṇuka*), “to eat a meal” — a second eat-verb this book has never taught, standing beside the everyday തിന്നുക. The difference is the same one English makes between “eating” in general and “having a meal”: *tinnuka* covers a snack, a fruit, anything at all; *uṇṇuka* names sitting down to the real thing.

Tamil’s cognate உணவு (*uṇavu*) generalised the very same root all the way to “food” itself. Kannada’s ഈട (*ūṭa*) narrowed it to “a meal,” matching Malayalam’s own ഊൺ sense for sense — three sisters, one Proto-Dravidian root, three different landing points.

Grammar Lens: the stretch this chapter closes

എനിക്ക് ഊൺ ഇഷ്ടമാണ്. — *enikku ūṇ iṣṭamāṇṁ*. — “I like having a meal” — the familiar dative **-ikku**, the *iṣṭam* liking-frame, one more turn of the same machine.

This chapter closes the spine node ദയവായി opened: ദയവായി asks; ക്ഷമിക്കണം repairs, the word for showing up after the ഊൺ is already over. And **-ikku** is still the same cousin of Tamil’s **-ukku**, Telugu’s **-ku**, and Kannada’s **-ge** that was first named earlier in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān ūṇ uṇṇunnu” — I am having a meal
- everyday against a proper meal — “tinnunnu ... uṇṇunnu”
- “enikku ūṇ iṣṭamāṇṁ” — I like having a meal
- ask, then repair — “dayavāyi ... kṣamikkaṇaṁ”

- this chapter’s three drinks and its meal — “chāya, kāppi, pāl ... ūṇ”

Before you move on

Say “I am having a meal.” (*Ñān ūṇ uṇṇunnu.*) How does *uṇṇuka* differ from the everyday *tinnuka*? (*Tinnuka* is **eating in general**; *uṇṇuka* is **having a proper meal**.) What are the two halves this spine node runs between? (ദയവായി asks; ക്ഷമിക്കണം repairs.)

Chapter 41

Pointing, and Asking

Modes: ⇄ voice (7) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Malayalam and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

41.1 ഇത് (itŭ) — this one — the thing near me

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: ഇത്

ഇത് — *itŭ* — this one — the thing near me.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is അത് *atŭ*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ഇത്” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *itũ*? (this one — the thing near me.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

41.2 അത് (atũ) — that one — the thing over there

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: അത്

അത് — *atũ* — that one — the thing over there.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ഇത് *itũ*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “അത്” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *atũ*? (that one — the thing over there.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

41.3 ഇവിടെ (ivite) — here — where I am

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ഇവിടെ

ഇവിടെ — *ivite* — here — where I am.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is അവിടെ *avite*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ഇവിടെ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ivite*? (here — where I am.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

41.4 അവിടെ (*avite*) — there — where I am not

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: അവിടെ

അവിടെ — *avite* — there — where I am not.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ഇവിടെ *ivite*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “അവിടെ” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *avite*? (there — where I am not.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

41.5 ആര് (ārū) — who? — asking about a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ആര്

ആര് — *ārū* — who? — asking about a person.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is എവിടെ *evite*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ആര്” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ārū*? (who? — asking about a person.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

41.6 എവിടെ (evite) — where? — asking about a place

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: എവിടെ

എവിടെ — *evite* — where? — asking about a place.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ആര് *ārū*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “എവിടെ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *evite*? (where? — asking about a place.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

41.7 i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

Say the six words from this chapter out loud, in order. Listen to how they begin.

Grammar lens: one slot changes

You did not learn six words. You learned **three beginnings** and reused them.

meaning	word
near	ഇവിടെ <i>ivite</i>
far	അവിടെ <i>avite</i>
question	എവിടെ <i>evite</i>

Malayalam spells the pattern out longest — ഇവിടെ, അവിടെ, എവിടെ — which makes it the easiest to hear. Change the front, and the meaning walks from **near** to **far** to a **question**. Nothing else in the word moves.

The same three beginnings run the thing-words too: ഇത് *itŭ* and അത് *atŭ* start exactly like the first two rows. This chapter did not teach you the matching question word for things — that one arrives later, and when it does you will already know what it has to start with. This is worth more than the six words are. When you meet a new word in this family later, you will not have to be taught all three of it — you will be taught one and work out the others.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the near word, then the far word, then the question word
- *Say it:* them again for place, not for things
- *Notice:* the part that did NOT change

Before you move on

Which beginning means near? (**i-**) Far? (**a-**) And which one turns the word into a question? (**e-**)

Chapter 42

Describing Things

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Malayalam and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

42.1 വലിയ (valiya) — big

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: വലിയ

വലിയ — *valiya* — big.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “വലിയ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *valiya*? (**big.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.2 ചെറിയ (*ceriya*) — small

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ചെറിയ

ചെറിയ — *ceriya* — small.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met വലിയ *valiya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ചെറിയ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ceriya*? (**small.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.3 നല്ല (*nalla*) — good

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: നല്ല

നല്ല — *nalla* — good.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met ചെറിയ *ceriya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “നല്ല” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *nalla*? (**good.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.4 പുതിയ (putiya) — new

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: പുതിയ

പുതിയ — *putiya* — new.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met നല്ല *nalla* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പുതിയ” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *putiya*? (**new.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.5 പഴയ (*palaya*) — old — of a thing, not of a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: പഴയ

പഴയ — *palaya* — old — of a thing, not of a person.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met പുതിയ *putiya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പഴയ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *palaya*? (**old — of a thing, not of a person.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.6 before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

Say the five words from this chapter out loud, then say each one in front of a noun you already know.

Grammar lens: where an adjective goes

You did not learn five separate words. You learned **where an adjective goes**, and five words that go there.

meaning	word
big	വലിയ <i>valiya</i>
small	ചെറിയ <i>ceriya</i>
good	നല്ല <i>nalla</i>

Every one ends in -a, sits in front of the noun, and never changes. This is worth more than the five words are. Every noun you already know — your name, the house, the water, the day — can now take any of them in front, and every adjective you meet from here goes in the same place.

Your turn

- *Say it*: each of the five in front of a noun you already know
- *Say it*: two of them with the same noun, one after the other
- *Notice*: whether the adjective changed shape when the noun did

Before you move on

Where does an adjective go in this language? (**In front of the noun.**) Does it change shape to match the noun? (unchanged.)

The Malayalam script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ക = ka, മ = ma, ര = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** കാ = k $\bar{a}$, കി = ki, കീ = k $\bar{i}$, കു = ku, കൂ = k $\bar{u}$, കെ = ke, കേ = k $\bar{e}$, കൊ = ko, കോ = k $\bar{o}$. (The *e/o* signs are written *before* their consonant but read after.)
3. **The *chandrakkala* strips the built-in vowel, and bare consonants join as conjuncts.** സ + ക → സ്ക (ska), ന + ദ → ന്ദ (nda), ല + ല → ല്ല (lla). A circle anusvāram ണ adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

അ a · ആ ā · ഇ i · ഊ ī · ഉ u · ഊ ū · എ e · ഏ ē · ഐ ai · ഓ o · ഔ ō · ഔ au.

Worth flagging

- **The largest Dravidian alphabet.** Because Malayalam borrowed so heavily from Sanskrit, it keeps the full Sanskrit inventory — aspirates (ഖ kh, ധ dh...) and all three sibilants (ശ ś, ഷ ṣ, സ s) — alongside native Dravidian letters Tamil also has (the retroflex ള ḷ, ഴ ḻ, ഹ ṇ).
- **Rounded forms, many conjuncts.** Malayalam’s curved letters and rich stock of stacked/ligated conjuncts give it a distinctive dense look.

Malayalam in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Malayalam is the *closest sister of Tamil* — the two split from one language only about a thousand years ago — so its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (*nandi*, *illa*, *śari*, and the *pōyi varām* farewell). At the same time it absorbed a vast Sanskrit layer, which is why its formal greeting (*namaskāram*) and its full letter-set are Sanskritised. The lessons trace, word by word, what is inherited Dravidian and what is borrowed.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

-ിക്ക് *-ikku*

the dative suffix *-ikku*, 'to / for' — and the idea of stacking
Introduced in Chapter 6.

അറിയുക *ariyuka*

to know — the verb inside എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം, and the one that will not let you be the subject
Introduced in Chapter 32.

ആര് *ārũ*

who? — asking about a person
Introduced in Chapter 41.

അത് *atũ*

that one — the thing over there
Introduced in Chapter 41.

അവിടെ *aviṭe*

there — where I am not
Introduced in Chapter 41.

ചെറിയ *ceriya*

small
Introduced in Chapter 42.

ചെവി *cevi*

ear — where three of the four sisters agree, and the fourth alone keeps the older sound
Introduced in Chapter 37.

ചായ *chaaya*

tea — Chinese, carried overland through Persian and Hindi before it ever reached Kerala
Introduced in Chapter 39.

ചിന്തിക്കുക *cintikkuka*

to think — a Sanskrit noun turned into a verb by the same -ഇക്കുക that made ക്ഷമിക്കുക, and the first of four verbs about what happens inside a head
Introduced in Chapter 33.

ചോദിക്കുക *cōdikkuka*

to ask — a Sanskrit word for pushing that walked into a gap Malayalam had made by narrowing its own inherited verb to “hear”
Introduced in Chapter 34.

ദയവായി *dayavāyi*

please (dayavāyi — “as a compassion,” from ദയ daya “compassion”)
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ദിവസം *divasam*

“day” — everyday Sanskrit divasam beside the more literary Sanskrit dinam
Introduced in Chapter 23.

എഴുതുക *elutuka*

to write — the same word as Tamil எழுது, carrying the 9 that only these two sisters kept, and the chapter’s closing count of four
Introduced in Chapter 33.

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം *enikku malayāḷam ariyām*

‘I know Malayalam’ — built with no subject, because knowing happens TO you
Introduced in Chapter 6.

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് *enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇṁ*

‘I like Malayalam’ — a noun, a copula, and a dative; the one sentence in this book where putting yourself in the subject slot is not merely odd but impossible
Introduced in Chapter 34.

എങ്ങനെ *eṇṇane*

how
Introduced in Chapter 3.

എന്റെ *enre*

my
Introduced in Chapter 2.

എടുക്കുക *eṭukkuka*

to take — native to the bone, yet ending in -ക്കുക like the borrowings; the letter that actually does the stamping is the ഇ
Introduced in Chapter 34.

എവിടെ *eviṭe*

where? — asking about a place
Introduced in Chapter 41.

ഹൃദയം *hrdayam*

heart — Sanskrit tatsama, and a genuine (if distant) cousin of the English word
Introduced in Chapter 38.

ഇല്ല *illa*

no / there isn't (illa — the negative)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ഇത് *it̥*

this one — the thing near me

Introduced in Chapter 41.

ഇവിടെ *ivite*

here — where I am

Introduced in Chapter 41.

ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka*

to work (lit. “work-do”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

കാപ്പി *kaapi*

coffee — an English colonial-era loan, itself from Arabic by way of Turkish and Italian; tea and coffee arrived by opposite roads

Introduced in Chapter 39.

കാലാവസ്ഥ *kālāvastha*

weather — a Sanskrit compound literally meaning “state of TIME”: kaala (“time”) + avastha (“state, condition”) — a real echo of Spanish's tiempo meaning both “time” AND “weather”

Introduced in Chapter 20.

കണ്ണ് *kaṇṇ̃*

eye — Proto-Dravidian, nearly identical across all four literary Dravidian languages

Introduced in Chapter 37.

കാണുക *kāṇuka*

to see — the family's shared see-root, kept as Malayalam's everyday word, and the mood endings that share one slot with tense

Introduced in Chapter 32.

ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇam*

(you) should forgive / sorry (kṣamikkaṇam — from kṣamikkuka “to forgive,”

Sanskrit kṣama + necessitative -aṇam)

Introduced in Chapter 9.

കുട്ടി *kuṭṭi*

child, kid — the general word, native Dravidian, before Malayalam narrows to son or daughter

Introduced in Chapter 36.

കുടുംബം *kuṭumbam*

family — the collective word Chapter 12's six people-words never needed, because each of them already named one specific person

Introduced in Chapter 35.

മകൾ *makaḷ*

daughter — identical to Tamil’s own word, sound for sound, closer even than the son-word

Introduced in Chapter 36.

മകൻ *makan*

son — Proto-Dravidian, closely matching Tamil, where Kannada softened the same root

Introduced in Chapter 36.

മനസ്സിലാക്കുക *manassilākkuka*

to understand — literally “to put it in the mind,” a three-piece word you can take apart by ear, with a second form that hands the understanding to you instead

Introduced in Chapter 33.

മുക്ക് *mūkkŭ*

nose — native Dravidian, a fourth near-perfect match across the family

Introduced in Chapter 37.

നാളെ കാണാം *nāḷe kāṇām*

see you tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 4.

നല്ല *nalla*

good

Introduced in Chapter 42.

നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram*

hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

നന്ദി *nandi*

thank you (nandi — the native Dravidian word, Tamil’s cousin)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

നെഞ്ച് *nenchŭ*

chest — Malayalam’s other heart, native this time, and the one everyday idiom reaches for

Introduced in Chapter 38.

പാൽ *paal*

milk — native, matching Tamil exactly, and matching Kannada by the family’s regular p-to-h shift

Introduced in Chapter 39.

പഴയ *palaya*

old — of a thing, not of a person

Introduced in Chapter 42.

പേര് *pēr*

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

പോകുക *pōkuka*

to go — one stem, three tense endings, and each of the three is the entire conjugation

Introduced in Chapter 32.

പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāṁ*

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

പുതിയ *putiya*

new

Introduced in Chapter 42.

രാവിലെ *rāvile*

“morning” (rāvile) — a compound of രാവ് (rāvũ, “night,” a cognate doublet of ഇരവ്/iravũ already met in ML-C24 — same root, not literally the same word) + locative-ish suffixes -il/-e; literally built from NIGHT, not light or rising — a genuinely different strategy than Kannada’s “the shining” or Telugu’s Sanskrit “rise”; പ്രഭാതം (Sanskrit tatsama, the same prabhāta root Telugu draws on) and പുലർച്ച (native, thinner etymology) also exist as alternatives

Introduced in Chapter 26.

സഹായിക്കുക *sahāyikkuka*

to help — “to go along with somebody,” and the fourth time in two chapters that a Sanskrit word has taken an everyday job from an inherited one

Introduced in Chapter 34.

സന്തോഷം *santōṣam*

joy / pleased to meet you

Introduced in Chapter 2.

സാരമില്ല *sāramilla*

it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ശരി *sari*

okay / alright / correct (śari)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം *śubha madhyāhnam*

“good afternoon” (śubha madhyāhnam), a formal greeting built on a noon synonym rather than the everyday afternoon compound

Introduced in Chapter 31.

ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം *śubha sāyāhnam*

“good evening” (śubha sāyāhnam) — confirmed real, used “from late afternoon until sunset” per a directly-fetched source; built on ശുഭ (ML-C25) + സായാഹ്നം (sāyāhnam), a SEPARATE Sanskrit tatsama for “evening,” Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” — NOT built on ML-C27’s native വൈകുന്നേരം; സായാഹ്നം’s own root, साय (“end”), is CONFIRMED via Wiktionary’s separate साय entry to trace to the same PIE *seh₁- as Telugu’s సాయంత్రం (sāyam) and Latin sērus — a properly-verified cognate, not just a plausible guess*

Introduced in Chapter 30.

സുഹൃത്ത് *suhṛttṛ*

friend — Sanskrit “good-heart,” a root this chapter’s own heart-word will meet again

Introduced in Chapter 35.

സുഖം *sukham*

well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

സുപ്രഭാതം *suprabhātam*

“good morning” (suprabhātam) — Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting, confirmed used in BOTH formal and informal contexts, and independently corroborated as the “most general” morning greeting by a SECOND directly-fetched source (not just one); built from su- (“good”) + പ്രഭാതം (already met, ML-C26, “morning/dawn”), NOT from ശുഭ (ML-C25’s “auspicious,” used for Malayalam’s own GREETING-GOODNIGHT) — a genuinely different Sanskrit “good” morpheme; the SAME word as Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం, but with an inverted role: PRIMARY greeting in Malayalam, only a SECONDARY alternative in Telugu (where శుభోదయం, a different root, is primary)

Introduced in Chapter 29.

താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka*

to live, to stay

Introduced in Chapter 5.

തിന്നുക *tinnuka*

to eat — the inherited Dravidian eat-word Malayalam kept as its everyday one, and the ending that tells a native verb from a borrowed one

Introduced in Chapter 32.

ഉച്ച *ucca*

noon, most likely from a different Sanskrit metaphor than Kannada and Telugu — height rather than middle

Introduced in Chapter 17.

ഉണ്ണ് *uṇṇ*

a meal — the noun behind ഉണ്ണുക, Malayalam’s second eat-verb, standing beside Chapter 32’s everyday തിന്നുക

Introduced in Chapter 40.

ഉണ്ട് *untũ*

there is, there are, [someone] has — and ഇരിക്കുക, to be somewhere; the two-piece machine every Malayalam verb is built on
Introduced in Chapter 32.

വൈകുന്നേരം *vaikunnēram*

“evening” (vaikunnēram) — native Dravidian compound, Wiktionary-glossed “latening time,” from വൈക് (vaikũ, plausibly the root of വൈകുക, “to get late” — a reasonable inference, not something Wiktionary’s compound entry states outright) + -ഉം (-um) + നേരം (nēram, “time,” itself native Dravidian, not Sanskrit); Wiktionary itself ALSO lists “afternoon” as a second sense, though phrasebook sources cleanly split evening (this word) from afternoon (a separate compound built on ഉച്ച, ML-C17’s “noon,” plus കഴിഞ്ഞ) — an honest source-tension worth flagging, not smoothing over
Introduced in Chapter 27.

വലിയ *valiya*

big
Introduced in Chapter 42.

വരുക *varuka*

to come — and the past tense, the one slot where a Malayalam verb can still surprise you
Introduced in Chapter 32.

വായ് *vāy*

mouth — the word Chapter 33 already named, only to rule it out
Introduced in Chapter 37.

വായിക്കുക *vāyikkuka*

to read — a word that looks as though it were built on വായ്, “mouth,” and is not; the trail runs to Sanskrit വാച്, “speech”
Introduced in Chapter 33.

അച്ഛൻ അമ്മ ചേട്ടൻ അനിയൻ ചേച്ചി അനിയത്തി

father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words — Malayalam’s own distinct set, still following the shared Dravidian age-first pattern
Introduced in Chapter 12.

അതെ

yes (athe — “that [is so]”)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

ആണ്

is (the copula)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

ആറ് ഏഴ് എട്ട് ഒമ്പത് പത്ത്

six to ten — Malayalam keeps Tamil’s rare 1 where the others lost it
Introduced in Chapter 7.

ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ്

“afternoon” (uchakaliññ) — a transparent two-word phrase, not a single dictionary headword: ഉച്ച (ML-C17’s “noon”) + കഴിഞ്ഞ്, the past converb form of കഴിയുക (kaliyuka, Wiktionary-confirmed Proto-Dravidian *kāzi*, “to be over, spent”) — *Wiktionary itself directly shows only the finite past tense കഴിഞ്ഞു (kaliññu); the converb form used in this compound is a reasonable grammatical inference, not itself the form Wiktionary lists; literally “noon having passed” — a structurally different strategy than Telugu’s, where the SAME noon-word (మధ్యాహ്నం) simply widened its own meaning rather than compounding with a second word*

Introduced in Chapter 28.

എന്ത്

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ്

my name is...

Introduced in Chapter 2.

ഒന്ന് രണ്ട് മൂന്ന് നാല് അഞ്ച്

one to five — Tamil’s closest sister, its numbers almost unchanged

Introduced in Chapter 7.

കറുപ്പ് വെള്ള ചുവപ്പ് നീല

black, white, red, blue — Malayalam shares Tamil’s native colors, and its Sanskrit blue too

Introduced in Chapter 11.

ചിങ്ങം കന്നി തുലാം വൃശ്ചികം ധനു മകരം കുംഭം മീനം മേടം ഇടവം മിഥുനം കർക്കടകം

the twelve months of the Malayalam (Kollam Era) solar calendar — also solar, like Tamil’s, but named for ZODIAC SIGNS rather than nakshatras

Introduced in Chapter 16.

ഞാൻ

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു

I speak Malayalam

Introduced in Chapter 5.

തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ

the seven weekdays — Malayalam shares Tamil’s native planet-words, being its closest cousin

Introduced in Chapter 10.

തല കൈ

head and hand — matching Tamil’s native pair almost exactly

Introduced in Chapter 13.

നീ / നിങ്ങൾ

you (familiar / respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്?

how old are you? — literally “to you how much age exists?”; the SAME Sanskrit *vayas* word, but Malayalam adds a dative-subject + existential verb, a genuinely different shape than Kannada/Telugu’s plain possessive

Introduced in Chapter 19.

നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്?

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

നായ, പൂച്ച

dog and cat — *naaya* continues the solid, ancient native Dravidian dog-root shared with Kannada and Tamil, no mystery; *poocha* matches Tamil’s everyday cat-word closely, part of the pattern where Dravidian genuinely splits on “cat” more than “dog”

Introduced in Chapter 21.

പോകുക

to go (and *വരിക*, to come)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ

green and yellow — *paccha* matches Tamil’s *paccai* almost exactly (the same pan-Dravidian *pac-* root *already seen in Kannada and Telugu*); *manja* is a completely separate native Dravidian root, a doublet of *manjal* (“turmeric”), matching Tamil’s own *mañcal*! — a third, independent solution to this arc’s recurring green/yellow puzzle

Introduced in Chapter 22.

പതിനൊന്ന് — ഇരുപത്

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens, then *irupathu* (20), transparently “two-tens” — *iru* (“two”) + *pathu* (“ten”), matching Tamil closely

Introduced in Chapter 20.

പാതിരാ

midnight, built on Malayalam *paathi* “half” rather than Sanskrit *ardha*

Introduced in Chapter 17.

മണി

hour — Malayalam’s OWN dictionary tradition treats bell/hour/gem as ONE Sanskrit word, unlike Tamil’s closely related *mani*, which its own dictionaries split into two unrelated homophones

Introduced in Chapter 18.

രാത്രി

“night” — the Sanskrit *tatsama* already shortened inside *paathira*, with a different PIE root from Latin *nox*

Introduced in Chapter 24.

വീണ്ടും കാണാം

we'll meet again

Introduced in Chapter 4.

വെള്ളം അരി ചോറ്

water (a genuinely DIFFERENT word than Tamil's), and rice raw/cooked, closely matching Tamil

Introduced in Chapter 15.

വസന്തകാലം വേനൽക്കാലം മഴക്കാലം ശൈത്യകാലം

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — matching Tamil's pattern of native heat/rain/cold words plus a Sanskrit “spring”

Introduced in Chapter 14.

ശുഭ രാത്രി

“good night” — the standard Sanskrit-tatsama phrase (rāthri already met, śubha new); some sources describe modern Malayalam speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead — the same claim, similarly thinly sourced, is also made about Telugu

Introduced in Chapter 25.

സുഖമാണോ?

how are you? (lit. “are you well?”)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

സംസാരിക്കുക

to speak, to converse

Introduced in Chapter 5.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 23

23.1 നാൾ — *the native day-word that narrowed its job*
Has Sanskrit divasam erased native naal?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 23

23.1 **ကဝေ** — *the native day-word that narrowed its job*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it has not; nāl still survives; naal still survives

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

0–9

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens, then **irupathu** (20), transparently “two-tens” — **iru** (“two”) + **pathu** (“ten”), matching Tamil closely പതിനൊന്ന് — ഇരുപത്
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 20, p. 97

A

a meal — the noun behind ഉണ്ണുക, Malayalam’s second eat-verb, standing beside Chapter 32’s everyday തിന്നുക ഊണ് (ūṇ)
explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 40, p. 187

Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 121

“afternoon” (uchakaliññ) — a transparent two-word phrase, not a single dictionary headword: ഉച്ച (ML-C17’s “noon”) + കഴിഞ്ഞ, the past converb form of കഴിയുക (kaliyuka, Wiktionary-confirmed Proto-Dravidian *kazi*, “to be over, spent”) — *Wiktionary itself directly shows only the finite past tense കഴിഞ്ഞു (kaliññu); the converb form used in this compound is a reasonable grammatical inference, not itself the form Wiktionary lists; literally “noon having passed” — a structurally different strategy than Telugu’s, where the SAME noon-word (మధ్యాహ്నం) simply widened its own meaning rather than compounding with a second word ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ*

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 121

Asking Someone’s Age

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 93

B**before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule**

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 42, p. 197

big വലിയ (valiya)

Chapter 42, p. 197

black, white, red, blue — Malayalam shares Tamil’s native colors, and its Sanskrit blue too കറുപ്പ് വെള്ള ചുവപ്പ് നീല

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 11, p. 57

C**Case Endings and Dative Subjects**

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 25

chest — Malayalam’s other heart, native this time, and the one everyday idiom reaches for നെഞ്ച് (nenchŭ)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 177

child, kid — the general word, native Dravidian, before Malayalam narrows to son or daughter കുട്ടി (kuṭṭi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 165

Child, Son, Daughter

chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 165

coffee — an English colonial-era loan, itself from Arabic by way of Turkish and Italian; tea and coffee arrived by opposite roads കാപ്പി (kaapi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 181

D**daughter — identical to Tamil’s own word, sound for sound, closer even than the son-word മകൾ (makal)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 165

Day

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 107

“day” — everyday Sanskrit divasam beside the more literary Sanskrit dinam ദിവസം (divasam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 23, p. 107

Days of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 51

Describing Things

chapter topic; Chapter 42, p. 197

Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 101

dog and cat — naaya continues the solid, ancient native Dravidian dog-root shared with Kannada and Tamil, no mystery; poocha matches Tamil’s everyday cat-word closely, part of the pattern where Dravidian genuinely splits on “cat” more than “dog” നായ, പുച്ചു

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 21, p. 101

E

ear — where three of the four sisters agree, and the fourth alone keeps the older sound ചെവി (cevi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 171

Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 119

“evening” (vaikunnēraṁ) — native Dravidian compound, Wiktionary-glossed “latening time,” from വൈക് (vaikŭ, plausibly the root of വൈകുക, “to get late” — a reasonable inference, not something Wiktionary’s compound entry states outright) + -ഉം (-um) + നേരം (nēraṁ, “time,” itself native Dravidian, not Sanskrit); Wiktionary itself ALSO lists “afternoon” as a second sense, though phrasebook sources cleanly split evening (this word) from afternoon (a separate compound built on ഉച്ച, ML-C17’s “noon,” plus കഴിഞ്ഞ) — an honest source-tension worth flagging, not smoothing over വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnēraṁ)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 27, p. 119

eye — Proto-Dravidian, nearly identical across all four literary

Dravidian languages കണ്ണ് (kaṇṇŭ)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 171

F**Face Words**

chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 171

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 63

Family and Friend

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 161

family — the collective word Chapter 12’s six people-words never needed, because each of them already named one specific person കുടുംബം (kuṭumbam)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 161

Farewells

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 17

father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words —

Malayalam’s own distinct set, still following the shared Dravidian age-first pattern അച്ഛൻ അമ്മ ചേട്ടൻ അനിയൻ ചേച്ചി അനിയത്തി
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 63

Four Core Colours

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 57

friend — Sanskrit “good-heart,” a root this chapter’s own heart-word will meet again സുഹൃത്ത് (suhṛttṛ)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 161

G

good നല്ല (nalla)

Chapter 42, p. 197

Good Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 129

“good afternoon” (śubha madhyāhnam), a formal greeting built on a noon synonym rather than the everyday afternoon compound ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam)

Chapter 31, p. 129

Good Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 125

“good evening” (śubha sāyāhnam) — confirmed real, used “from late afternoon until sunset” per a directly-fetched source; built on ശുഭ (ML-C25) + സായാഹ്നം (sāyāhnam), a SEPARATE Sanskrit tatsama for “evening,” Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” — NOT built on ML-C27’s native വൈകുന്നേരം; സായാഹ്നം’s own root, साय (“end”), is CONFIRMED via Wiktionary’s separate entry to trace to the same PIE *seh₁*- as *Telugu’s* సాయంత్రం (*sāyam*) and *Latin sērus* — a properly-verified cognate, not just a plausible guess ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 125

Good Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 123

“good morning” (suprabhātām) — Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting, confirmed used in BOTH formal and informal contexts, and independently corroborated as the “most general” morning greeting by a SECOND directly-fetched source (not just one); built from su- (“good”) + പ്രഭാതം (already met, ML-C26, “morning/dawn”), NOT from ശുഭ (ML-C25’s

“auspicious,” used for Malayalam’s own

GREETING-GOODNIGHT) — a genuinely different Sanskrit

“good” morpheme; the SAME word as Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం, but

with an inverted role: PRIMARY greeting in Malayalam, only a

SECONDARY alternative in Telugu (where శుభోదయం, a different root, is primary) സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātām)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 123

Good Night

chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 115

“good night” — the standard Sanskrit-tatsama phrase (rāthri

already met, śubha new); some sources describe modern

Malayalam speakers often code-switching to English “good

night” instead — the same claim, similarly thinly sourced, is also

made about Telugu శుభ రాత్రి

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 25, p. 115

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”) പോയി വരാം (pōyi varām)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 17

Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 105

green and yellow — paccha matches Tamil’s paccai almost

exactly (the same pan-Dravidian *pac-* root already seen in

Kannada and Telugu); *manja* is a completely separate native

Dravidian root, a doublet of *manjal* (“turmeric”), matching

Tamil’s own *mañcal* — a third, independent solution to this

arc’s recurring green/yellow puzzle പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 22, p. 105

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

Head and Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 69

head and hand — matching Tamil’s native pair almost

exactly തല കൈ

Chapter 13, p. 69

heart — Sanskrit tatsama, and a genuine (if distant) cousin of the English word ഹൃദയം (hṛdayam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 177

hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”) നമസ്കാരം (namaskāram)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

here — where I am ഇവിടെ (iviṭe)

Chapter 41, p. 191

hour — Malayalam’s OWN dictionary tradition treats bell/hour/gem as ONE Sanskrit word, unlike Tamil’s closely related mani, which its own dictionaries split into two unrelated

homophones മണി

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 18, p. 89

how എങ്ങനെ (eṅṅane)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 13

how are you? (lit. “are you well?”) സുഖമാണോ?

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

how old are you? — literally “to you how much age exists?”; the SAME Sanskrit vayas word, but Malayalam adds a dative-subject + existential verb, a genuinely different shape than Kannada/Telugu’s plain possessive നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 19, p. 93

I

I ഞാൻ

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 41, p. 191

‘I know Malayalam’ — built with no subject, because knowing happens TO you എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം (enikku malayāḷam aṛiyām)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 25

‘I like Malayalam’ — a noun, a copula, and a dative; the one sentence in this book where putting yourself in the subject slot is not merely odd but impossible എനിക്ക് മലയാളം

ഇഷ്ടമാണ് (enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇṁ)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153

I speak Malayalam ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 21

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 7

is (the copula) ആണ്

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

it doesn't matter / no problem / you're**welcome സാരമില്ല** (sāramilla)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

J**joy / pleased to meet you സന്തോഷം** (santōṣam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

M**midnight, built on Malayalam paathi “half” rather than Sanskrit****ardha പാതിരാ**

Chapter 17, p. 85

milk — native, matching Tamil exactly, and matching Kannada**by the family's regular p-to-h shift പാൽ** (paal)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 181

Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 117

“morning” (rāvile) — a compound of രാവ് (rāvũ, “night,” a cognate doublet of ഇരവ്/iravũ already met in ML-C24 — same root, not literally the same word) + locative-ish suffixes -il/-e; literally built from NIGHT, not light or rising — a genuinely different strategy than Kannada's “the shining” or Telugu's Sanskrit “rise”; പ്രഭാതം (Sanskrit tatsama, the same prabhāta root Telugu draws on) and പുലർച്ച (native, thinner etymology) also exist as alternatives രാവിലെ (rāvile)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 26, p. 117

mouth — the word Chapter 33 already named, only to rule it**out വായ്** (vāy)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 171

my എന്റെ (enre)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

my name is... എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ്

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

N

name പേര് (pēr)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

new പുതിയ (putiya)

Chapter 42, p. 197

Night

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 111

“night” — the Sanskrit tatsama already shortened inside paathira, with a different PIE root from Latin nox രാത്രി

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 24, p. 111

no / there isn’t (illa — the negative) ഇല്ല (illa)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Noon and Midnight

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 85

noon, most likely from a different Sanskrit metaphor than

Kannada and Telugu — height rather than middle ഉച്ച (ucca)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 17, p. 85

nose — native Dravidian, a fourth near-perfect match across the family മൂക്ക് (mūkkū)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 171

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 97

Numbers One to Ten

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 33

O

okay / alright / correct (śari) ശരി (sari)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

old — of a thing, not of a person പഴയ (paḷaya)

Chapter 42, p. 197

ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 33

ഐ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 39

ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 45

ഔ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 63

ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 77

◌o — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 81

One greeting, three afternoon strategies

etymology topic; Chapter 31, p. 129

one to five — Tamil’s closest sister, its numbers almost unchanged ഒന്ന് രണ്ട് മൂന്ന് നാല് അഞ്ച്

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 33

P

Please

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 39

please (dayavāyi — “as a compassion,” from ദയ dayā “compassion”) ദയവായി (dayavāyi)

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 8, p. 39

Pointing, and Asking

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 191

S

Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 73

see you tomorrow നാളെ കാണാം (nāḷe kāṇām)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 17

six to ten — Malayalam keeps Tamil’s rare ് where the others lost it ആറ് ഏഴ് എട്ട് ഒമ്പത് പത്ത്

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 33

small ചെറിയ (ceriya)

Chapter 42, p. 197

son — Proto-Dravidian, closely matching Tamil, where Kannada

softened the same root മകൻ (makan)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 165

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 45

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — matching Tamil’s pattern of native heat/rain/cold words plus a Sanskrit

“spring” വസന്തകാലം വേനൽക്കാലം മഴക്കാലം ശൈത്യകാലം

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 14, p. 73

T

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 153

tea — Chinese, carried overland through Persian and Hindi before it ever reached Kerala ചായ (chaaya)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 181

Tea, Coffee, Milk

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 181

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 89

thank you (nandi — the native Dravidian word, Tamil's cousin) നന്ദി (nandi)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

that one — the thing over there അത് (atü)

Chapter 41, p. 191

The Core Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 133

the dative suffix -ikku, 'to / for' — and the idea of stacking -ിക്കു (-ikku)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 6, p. 25

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 21

The Meal

chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 187

The Mind and the Page

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 145

the seven weekdays — Malayalam shares Tamil's native planet-words, being its closest cousin തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 51

The Traditional Months

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 81

the twelve months of the Malayalam (Kollam Era) solar calendar — also solar, like Tamil's, but named for ZODIAC SIGNS rather than nakshatras ചിങ്ങം കന്നി തുലാം വൃശ്ചികം ധനു മകരം കുംഭം മീനം മേടം ഇടവം മിഥുനം കർക്കടകം

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 16, p. 81

The Two Hearts

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 177

there is, there are, [someone] has — and ഇരിക്കുക, to be somewhere; the two-piece machine every Malayalam verb is built on ഉണ്ട് (uṇṭü)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 133

there — where I am not അവിടെ (aviṭe)

Chapter 41, p. 191

this one — the thing near me ഇത് (it̥)

Chapter 41, p. 191

to ask — a Sanskrit word for pushing that walked into a gap Malayalam had made by narrowing its own inherited verb to “hear” ചോദിക്കുക (cōdikkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153

to come — and the past tense, the one slot where a Malayalam verb can still surprise you വരുക (varuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 133

to eat — the inherited Dravidian eat-word Malayalam kept as its everyday one, and the ending that tells a native verb from a borrowed one തിന്നുക (tinnuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 133

to go (and വരിക, to come) പോകുക

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 17

to go — one stem, three tense endings, and each of the three is the entire conjugation പോകുക (pōkuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 133

to help — “to go along with somebody,” and the fourth time in two chapters that a Sanskrit word has taken an everyday job from an inherited one സഹായിക്കുക (sahāyikkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153

to know — the verb inside എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം, and the one that will not let you be the subject അറിയുക (ariyuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 32, p. 133

to live, to stay താമസിക്കുക (tāmasikkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 21

to read — a word that looks as though it were built on വായ്, “mouth,” and is not; the trail runs to Sanskrit വാച്, “speech” വായിക്കുക (vāyikkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 145

to see — the family’s shared see-root, kept as Malayalam’s everyday word, and the mood endings that share one slot with tense കാണുക (kāṇuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 133

to speak, to converse സംസാരിക്കുക

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 21

to take — native to the bone, yet ending in -ക്കുക like the borrowings; the letter that actually does the stamping is the ഇ എടുക്കുക (eṭukkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 153

to think — a Sanskrit noun turned into a verb by the same
-ഇക്കുക that made ക്ഷമിക്കുക, and the first of four verbs about
what happens inside a head ചിന്തിക്കുക (cintikkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 145

to understand — literally “to put it in the mind,” a three-piece
word you can take apart by ear, with a second form that hands
the understanding to you instead മനസ്സിലാക്കുക (manassilākkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 145

to work (lit. “work-do”) ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (jōli ceyyuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 21

to write — the same word as Tamil எழுது, carrying the 9 that
only these two sisters kept, and the chapter’s closing count of
four എഴുതുക (eḷutuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 145

W

water (a genuinely DIFFERENT word than Tamil’s), and rice
raw/cooked, closely matching Tamil വെള്ളം അരി ചോറ്

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 77

Water and Rice

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 77

we’ll meet again വീണ്ടും കാണാം

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 17

weather — a Sanskrit compound literally meaning “state of
TIME”: kaala (“time”) + avastha (“state, condition”) — a real
echo of Spanish’s tiempo meaning both “time” AND
“weather” കാലാവസ്ഥ (kālavastha)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 20, p. 97

well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്” സുഖം (sukham)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 13

what എന്ത്

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

what’s your name? നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

where? — asking about a place എവിടെ (eviṭe)

Chapter 41, p. 191

who? — asking about a person ആര് (ārū)

Chapter 41, p. 191

Y

yes (athe — “that [is so]”) അതെ

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (familiar / respectful) നീ / നിങ്ങൾ

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

**(you) should forgive / sorry (kṣamikkaṇaṁ — from kṣamikkuka
“to forgive,” Sanskrit kṣama + necessitative**

-aṇaṁ) ക്ഷമിക്കണം (kṣamikkaṇaṁ)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 45

Other

ഇരവ് / ഇരുൾ — two native words, two jobs

etymology topic; Chapter 24, p. 111

ഉ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 17, p. 85

ക — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 25

ച — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 39

ഞ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 63

ട — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 69

ണ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 51

ത — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 69

ദ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 20, p. 97

ന — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 51

നാൾ — the native day-word that narrowed its job

etymology topic; Chapter 23, p. 107

പ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 45

മ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 57

യ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 19, p. 93

ര — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 25

- 𐌵 — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 73
- 𐌶 — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 33
- 𐌷 — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 18, p. 89
- 𐌸 — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 21, p. 101
- 𐌹 — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 57